Those Who Favor Fire

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Teen And Up Audiences

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No Archive Warnings Apply

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Adora/Catra (She-Ra)

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Adora, Catra, Bow, Glimmer, Mara, Razz, Shadow Weaver | Light Spinner (She-Ra), Perfuma (She-Ra), Scorpia (She-Ra), Sea Hawk (She-Ra), Mermista (She-Ra), He-Man | Adam

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pretty much everyone makes an appearance at some point, Yule Festival, Basically I Wanted to Write a Princess Prom Scene, Volleyball Player Adora, Music Teacher Catra, Childhood Friends, Friends to Exes to Lovers, But One of Them Doesn't Realize They Broke Up, slow burn?, probably gonna be angsty, Alternate Universe - Modern Setting, lots of references

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Those Who Favor Fire

by queenmillicentofbystander

Summary

Adora doesn’t know she and Catra ever broke up. Catra doesn’t believe Adora is ever coming back.

When Adora left Catra in their tiny town of Thaymor to play volleyball at the University of Bright Moon she made a promise. When Catra watched her drive away with nothing but false hope to keep her warm, she let Adora go. Now it’s 8 years later. Adora’s an Olympic gold medalist, ready to keep her promise, and Catra’s a high school music teacher, desperate for a peaceful winter break. But some promises are harder to keep than others, and peace on earth does not mean peace for you.

Notes

I was gonna wait until I moved to post this, and I was gonna finish fine tuning the next chapter too. But I finally came up with a title today. It's been weeks my friends, I've never gone this long without a title. I'm a titler. Titling things is my shit. My English teacher in high school was always like "That essay was okay, but damn... your title? Amazing."

Could I have used the song that inspired this fic, because of course all of my writing is inspired by songs? Maybe. But I already did that and I have something to prove this time around.

(That song by the way is Better of Gone by Logan Mize)

This fic is obviously going to be different from my last one but I hope you still like it.

Thanks to infinitegay, petty_labelle, and Horchata_Latte for beta-ing. Each of your thoughts have really helped me flesh this out and make it better than I could've dreamed. And, of course, this thing has all the right commas now.

See the end of the work for more notes

Prologue - Some Say the World Will End

"I leave, with tears blurring all that I see." - Euripides

August 10 th , 2013 -

Catra stared at the familiar pale blue walls of Adora's bedroom and wiggled her toes in the thick gray carpet. Her jaw was clenched, and her long nails were digging into the palms of her hands, but she hadn't cried yet or broken down and begged. She was keeping it together and she wanted credit for that. But who was going to give it to her? No one would, she never got credit for anything she did. Not from anyone except—

"Okay!" Adora walked back into the bedroom, toothbrush in hand. She held it up proudly. "Can't believe I almost forgot this."

Catra cocked her head. The bristles on the toothbrush were flared and pale. "That thing's destroyed, Adora. How long have you been using the same toothbrush?"

Adora's brow furrowed, and she turned it over in her hand. "I—I don't know? Does that matter?"

Catra managed to crack a smile. "Yes, dummy. You're supposed to change it like every three months."

Adora's eyes went wide. "Every three months?"

Catra's smile got a little bit bigger, and she nodded.

Adora groaned. "Well, crap. I need a new toothbrush."

Catra was full-on grinning now. "Why am I not surprised?"

Adora glared at her, but it was playful and warm. Catra wondered when she would see that glare again. Then Adora turned and

tossed the offending toothbrush into the trashcan in the corner. It went right in.

When she turned back, she gave Catra a winning smile. It took over her whole face and lit it up brighter than the sun. And Catra…

Catra's smile fell, and she couldn't manage to put it back on again.

After a second Adora's smile fell off too. She stepped forward, opened her arms, and wrapped them around her best friend. Pulling Catra close, she pressed a gentle kiss to the side of her head. Catra closed her eyes tight and fought off the tears.

"Hey," Adora whispered, "it's okay baby. I know. I… I know."

At those words, Catra, who'd been standing stiff, holding all of her muscles tight to keep from shaking, melted. She let herself shiver, wrapped her arms around Adora's waist, and buried her face in her neck. She took heavy, deep breaths, and let herself hold Adora as tight and as close as she wanted to.

She only had a few moments left and she decided it wasn't worth it to hold back for a single one of them.

Adora laced her fingers through Catra's hair, which was growing out of its pixie cut and was now grazing her jaw. "I'm gonna be back every Thanksgiving, and winter break, and spring break and you're gonna come visit me in the summer… you're gonna get sick of me." Adora chuckled. But Catra didn't. She just clung on tighter.

Adora closed her eyes and returned the embrace. "And when I'm done, I'm coming home. I promise."

Catra forced a chuckle and pulled her head out of Adora's shoulder. "What makes you think I'm still gonna be here?" She almost smiled. "How many famous musicians do you know who live in Thaymor?"

Adora grinned. “Then I’ll come to Fright City!” She stroked her thumb over Catra’s cheek. “I’m gonna go wherever you go, Catra.”

A sharp pang laced through Catra’s chest. She shouldn’t ask. She told herself she wouldn’t. She knew the answer, and she knew what it would do to her, but it was instinct. It was the same question she’d been asking Adora since she was six and it came out without a second’s thought.

“You promise?” she whispered.

Adora nodded. “I promise.” And she meant it.

Adora’s heart was pounding in her chest. She ran her hands down Catra’s arms, tracing her birthmarks and scars along the way. She glanced quickly at Catra’s mismatched eyes, then took her hands and pulled them to her own chest. She closed her eyes, drawing on some inner strength, then lifted her head and met Catra’s confused stare.

“Adora…?”

“I love you,” Adora whispered, staring earnestly into Catra’s eyes. “So much.”

Catra blinked and tears started to well in her eyes. “I…” she swallowed, “I love you too.”

Adora’s smile was blinding. She pulled Catra into a hug and held her tight. Adora didn’t ever want to let go, and Catra was terrified for the moment she would.

“Adora!” Mara’s voice called up the stairs. “We’ve gotta go, kid!”

Catra pulled herself out of Adora’s arms, reluctant but resigned, head ducked and staring at the floor. She took a deep breath and gave Adora the strongest smile she could manage.

And Adora saw right through it.

Catra turned to head for the stairs, but Adora stopped her, grabbing her by the hand and pulling her back. She took Catra's chin in her hand and lifted it, wiping the tears that Catra hadn't even realized she'd let slip from her cheeks.

"Please," Adora whispered again, squeezing Catra's hand, "don't forget it. It's gonna be hard, and I know there are gonna be times that you'll want to give up on me and that I won't seem worth it but—"

Catra covered Adora's mouth with her palm. She shook her head. "You're such an idiot," she breathed. Slowly, she pulled her hand away and gave Adora a soft and gentle kiss.

"Don't you get it, Adora?" She smiled but it was sad and weak. "I love you too. I always have. I waited my whole life for you. I think I can wait a couple years longer."

Adora's shoulders relaxed, and she smiled. "I can't believe you love me…."

Catra rolled her eyes and reached down to take Adora's hand again. "Believe it, Princess. Now come on, before—"

"Holy fuck, Adora, come *on*!" Adam yelled from downstairs, and Catra burst into laughter.

"We're coming!" she cackled, turning to grab Adora's last suitcase off the bed. She pulled Adora down the stairs and Adora marveled at the way Catra made her feel by just holding her hand. And how she'd have to go without it, for months.

It made her want to cry.

As the little yellow Subaru, piloted by Mara and packed full of Adora's things, pulled out of the driveway and made its way down the street, Adora stuck her head out the window and waved back at her twin brother, grandmother, and girlfriend, her heart breaking in two. She felt like she was leaving so much of herself

behind and she didn't know how she was going to live without those pieces.

From the driveway of the little yellow house with the blue roof and apricot tree in the front yard, Catra waved goodbye and finally let herself cry. Razz wrapped an arm around her waist and Adam put his hand on her shoulder. She shook with the force of her tears, but they were quiet, and no one said a word.

As Catra stared after the slowly disappearing car, she was struck again with the realization that had hit her months ago when Adora had first come to her telling her about the scholarship.

She was never going to see Adora again.

Adora was off to be a famous volleyball player. Adora was off to the Olympics. Adora was off to bigger and better things. Adora had dreams, good ones, real ones, and she was going to get them. She was going to get everything she ever wanted.

And Catra wasn't really one of those things.

Catra fingered the brilliant red letterman jacket she wore. It was Adora's. She meant to give it back. But there it was, still on her shoulders while Adora drove away.

She clutched at it, feeling the fuzzy wool under her fingers. Maybe she could keep it – just this one thing. Maybe it wouldn't hurt.

Catra's tears fell harder. No, it was going to hurt. She knew. She knew it wouldn't matter how long she waited or how much she loved her. She wasn't going to see her ever again.

"Oh, Cyra," Razz sighed, giving Catra a squeeze around the waist. "Don't be so sad. Adora will be back. She promised."

"Seriously," Adam chuffed, "you think she's missing Thanksgiving and Grandma Razz's mixed berry pie? Come on, you know Adora better than that."

Catra forced a smile and gave a quick nod. “You’re right,” she lied. She lied so easily.

Adora didn’t come home that Thanksgiving. Or any thereafter.

August 5 th , 2021 –

As the ball landed on the sandy ground, the crowd erupted into violent cheers.

Adora turned on her heel, running at Bow and throwing her arms around him. He screamed loud in her ear, and she screamed just as loud in his. They were jumping and screaming and crying and the world seemed brighter, and everything was perfect.

Well, nearly.

Somehow, in less than a minute, a reporter managed to make their way onto the court. They ran up to Bow and Adora and shoved a microphone in their faces. Before they could even think to be angry though, the reporter was leaning in and asking the only question that could’ve broken through.

“An amazing win! In your very first Olympic run, you’ve won the gold! How are you going to celebrate something so monumental?”

Bow raised his arms above his head and cheered. “I’m gonna marry Glimmer Moon!” He pulled away from Adora and looked around, hunting down a crop of pink hair. When he found it, the tiny woman dressed in purple was already shoving her way through a throng of people. His face, already bright, lit up to a thousand watts, and he ran for her.

Before she has the chance to say his name, he had her around the waist and up in the air. He spun them around and laughter bubbled out of them as the crowd cheered and cooed.

“I’m so proud of you!” Glimmer cried, reaching, and holding Bow’s face in her hands.

He lowered her to the ground and pressed a hand to her cheek. “I love you too.”

And then he kissed her slow and deep.

The crowd just got louder.

Adora watched and smiled, but her heart ached.

“And for you?” the reporter asked, holding the mic out now only to Adora. “What does the great Adora Grayskull have planned?”

Adora smiled, then looked directly into the camera, hoping *she* was watching, and that she’d hear her across those hundreds of miles.

“I’m going home.”

Good Thing I Didn't Wait For You

Chapter Notes

Hey! Thanks for coming back! I know it's been a minute, like a whole month I think, and that was NOT supposed to happen, but the schedule should be a lot more consistent now. I won't leave you guys hanging.

And this chapter is almost 8,000 words so that's gotta mean something.

For those that are wondering - my move went... ok. I'm still not actually in my house yet because renovations are taking forever and I'm currently crashing in a hammock in my parents exercise room. (Yes, exercise room, I won't call it a gym.) (Yes, a hammock. My parents, for who the fuck knows why, have a camping hammock hung up in their exercise room. My dad is... eccentric.) BUT! Not all is lost - the moving truck still hasn't shown up and my work orientation has been pushed back two weeks because of complications with my background check. So we're doing great! ... Wait.

Anyway. This chapter took a lot of time and I have probably read it more times through than I have fingers on my hands. So, I hope you like it! Logistically though, I should warn you, this fic is gonna be kinda complicated. We will be switching between 1st person perspectives, because apparently that's the only way I write, and we'll be switching between tenses too. Each chapter will start with a "flashback" in past tense, and then switch to "modern day" (technically December of last year, but who's fretting?} in present tense. Everything will be marked with dates and each chapter will be marked with it's speaker. Hopefully that's not too confusing.

And with that - ENJOY!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra

"But my word fell apart, and all they could do, the whole universe, was to silently move on." – Khadija Rupa

October 28, 2012

It was supposed to be my seventeenth birthday, and I was supposed to be spending it with Adora, *just* Adora, baking red velvet cupcakes and playing the She-Ra drinking game. Instead, I was wearing the tightest pleather jumpsuit in existence and listening to Kyle, dressed as a gorilla, bitch about clarinet superiority complexes or something. Honestly I'm not actually sure what he was bitching about because the second we got to Lonnie's, I pounded three shots of vodka and found my way into Adora's lap. And that's where I was going to stay until the end of time.

I wasn't giving up the view.

Adora had practically begged me to dress up that year. She'd said that she'd get the whole costume ready, that it would be so easy, and that I'd look "so cool, I promise!" I didn't tell her it wasn't that big a deal– that I would've dressed up just because she asked me to. Instead, I "gave in" as dramatically as possible, put on the skintight pleather jumpsuit, cat ears, and goggles and mentally prepared for a stupid high school party.

I thought the whip was pretty cool though.

Then I saw Adora's costume and um… yeah it was *really* cool.

Guess since I was going as Catwoman she had to be Supergirl.

"They aren't even rivals," I nearly choked, staring at her bare stomach. She wore a cropped white t-shirt with the Superman shield printed on the chest, and the tightest, shortest, blue skirt imaginable. Her hair wasn't in that damned ponytail, but she had

a little black headband in, and her long, loose bangs framed her face.

Gay. Gay. Gay. I'm so fucking gay.

Her lips puckered into a frown. "I know, but she's the only blonde I could come up with!"

"Um…" I wanted to reach out and put my hand on her abs. Or her ass. Or her tit. Just on her. Any part of her. "Stephanie Brown."

Adora stuck her foot into a bright red boot. "Who's that?"

"She's one of the Batgirls."

Adora straightened and leveled a glare at me. "Now you tell me."

I don't think I would've told her even if I'd known. Because then I would've missed out on her in the tiniest shirt I've ever seen, the feeling of her arm wrapped around me, and my thigh pressed up against her bare stomach. And that memory still keeps me warm at night.

But Kyle wouldn't shut up and just let me enjoy it.

"Catra?" he asked, and I lifted my head, crashing back to reality. He and Rogelio, who I was only just realizing had a lizard mask pushed up onto his head, were sitting on the couch kitty corner to the chair where I sat on Adora's lap. Kyle cocked his head to the side. "You okay? You seem a little out of it."

I glanced between him and his boyfriend. Lizard and gorilla? What the hell…?

But Rogelio was smirking at me. Knowingly. I fought back a grimace. "Yeah," I said, straightening a bit, "I'm fine. Just thinking about…" I pursed my lips, "the rivalry between band and choir kids?"

Kyle threw up his hands. “Don’t even get me started! It’s ridiculous! And I have to play for both sides! You can’t imagine the stress that puts me under. I have to be two—”

I tried to zone out again, pressing my leg more firmly into Adora’s abs. But before he could really get going, Lonnie appeared, a pair of large white wings strapped to her back, and clapped her hand on his shoulder. “Come on, Kyle!” She beamed. “No one wants to hear about that.”

Kyle frowned. “She asked.”

I raised a brow. “Technically, I didn’t. I just said I was thinking about it.”

Adora nudged me with her arm. “Catra…” she said, her mouth turned down into the world’s most adorable and disapproving little frown.

The urge to lean in and kiss it off her mouth was overwhelming. I don’t know how I resisted.

Lonnie moved in next to Kyle on the couch and tried to throw her arm over his shoulder, but her wing got in the way. I would’ve laughed at the awkward little shuffle she and Kyle did until they were pressed up against each other’s arms, but it was so…

Loaded.

I glanced at Adora the same moment she glanced at me. I almost smirked. I knew what she was thinking just from the set of her eyes and mouth. I knew that she, just like me, was wondering what was going on with those three.

“So, Lonnie,” I leaned forward on my elbow. “What the hell are you supposed to be? An angel doesn’t really seem your speed.”

She scoffed and crossed her arms. “I’m not a fucking angel!” She pointed to two pipe cleaner contraptions sticking out of a headband that sat forward on her head. “I have antenna!”

“Oh!” Adora perked up, smiling. “A butterfly!”

I grinned as Lonnie threw her hands up, honestly pissed. “How many fuzzy butterflies have you seen Adora?”

Adora pursed her lips. “Um… well, counting you—”

“Mothra!” Lonnie snapped. “I’m Mothra!”

Adora beamed. “Oh! Mothra! Yeah, I—I…” her smile fell. “I don’t know what that is…”

I cackled and pressed a hand to Adora’s cheek. She turned into my hand, face open and timid. “Adora, never change.”

“It’s a Japanese horror movie monster!” Kyle said, nearly bouncing in his seat. “It’s a giant moth that—”

“It’s not important,” Lonnie muttered, suddenly sullen. I frowned a little, looking from her to Kyle. Then, for the hell of it, I looked at Rogelio. And I noticed his hand on her knee.

“What is important,” Lonnie leaned back, sounding a little more confident, “is that this party is a snooze fest. It’s about time we spiced things up a bit.”

Adora wiggled nervously beneath me. “How?”

Lonnie lifted her arm and I noticed for the first time, somehow, a large, clear, empty bottle.

“Spin the bottle.”

There was like, a full second of silence, and then I groaned. “Seriously?” Everyone looked at me. “We’ve been playing that since the sixth grade. Aren’t we a little old for it now?”

Lonnie eyed me up and down. “Didn’t know you felt so strongly about it.”

I crossed my arms and leaned into Adora. "I just think it's stupid." I glanced quickly at Adora's face. "I mean we've all kissed each other already."

Except we hadn't. And I knew that. Of course, I knew that. Because none of us had ever kissed Adora.

And I *really* wanted to.

I'd wanted to kiss Adora since I'd figured out what wanting to kiss someone felt like.

But Adora had been avoiding Spin the Bottle, and Seven Minutes in Heaven, and every other game like it since we started playing them. She would hide in the bathroom, or make up an excuse and go home early, or even pretend to be so drunk she passed out to avoid playing. Sometimes, she would just sneak outside and stare at the stars. But she'd done it. She had gone all the way through high school and never once had to play one of "the kissing games".

Almost.

"Adora hasn't." Lonnie smirked, and I could feel Adora freeze up underneath me. "I don't think she's ever played Spin the Bottle with us."

"Or Seven Minutes in Heaven!" Kyle added, throwing up his hands. "Aw, now we gotta play. Come on, Adora! It'll be fun!"

Adora was pale, and her eyes were wide. "Wha—I—I've totally—" But she couldn't get the words out. Adora's always been a terrible liar.

I covered her hand with mine and traced little patterns on the back with my nails. I could feel her relax underneath me. A little anyway.

"What about kiss or drink?" I said, throwing a smirk at Lonnie. "If you don't want to kiss whoever it lands on, you have to take a

shot.”

Lonnie grinned. “What? You don’t want to kiss Kyle?”

My smirk grew. “I’d rather drink the entire bottle of cheap ass tequila you brought.”

“Hey!” Kyle whined and everyone laughed.

Lonnie got ahold of herself and nodded. “Sure Weaver. Kyle, go grab the ‘cheap ass tequila’. Rogelio and I are gonna go find Scorpia and Entrapta.”

I cocked my head as they all stood up, Lonnie gently pushed Kyle forward by his shoulders, ruffled his hair, then reached back and linked pinkies with Rogelio. I seriously had no idea what was going on there, but once they were out of sight they were out of mind.

Because I was about to play Spin the Bottle with… Scorpia.

Scorpia had moved to Thaymor from Fright City at the beginning of our junior year and she was… a lot. She was loud, and huggy, and had no respect for personal space. But she offered to be my partner in gym class. It was the first year since Elementary school that Adora and I weren’t in the same one, and it wasn’t like I had a ton of friends. So, I took her up on it.

Before I knew it, she had my number, and we were texting and walking from gym to our lockers together. Then the next semester we were in the same chemistry class, and she introduced me to her lab partner Entrapta and we started studying for tests together. By the time summer rolled around, we were actually hanging out, the three of us, movie nights and stuff.

And it was fine. It was kinda great. I’d never really had friends other than Adora, not any that actually liked me, and Scorpia liked me!

Turns out, she liked me too much.

She tried to put her arm around me on the Ferris Wheel at the Summer Fair after conveniently distracting Entrapta by telling her there was a Dippin' Dots cart down by the Merry-Go-Round.

I wanted to pretend it never happened and move on but, of course, she made that impossible. She just kept doing things – sitting really close, suggesting board game nights for two, calling me *Wildcat.*

And she spent way too much money on my birthday present.

But, fuck, I loved the look on Adora's face when I opened that box and pulled out a record player. The steam coming out of her ears made me tingle. And when Scorpia said "Happy Birthday, Wildcat!" I thought she was going to snarl.

Everybody knew of course – Scorpia had a crush on me. A big, fat crush. The kind of crush that, could, well, crush a person.

I didn't want to crush Scorpia. But I didn't exactly want to get crushed either.

I wasn't doing a great job at the whole "let them down gently" thing. And I was about to risk kissing her.

"Hey," Adora whispered, and I pulled myself back to reality; back to the feeling of her arms wrapped around me and her body beneath mine. "You okay?"

I smiled. "Yeah, just thinkin'."

She rubbed her hand up my arm. "What about?"

My smile got bigger. "You kissing Kyle."

Her nose scrunched up and her mouth curdled. "No! Catra!"

I cackled and jumped from her lap. Then I held out a hand and she grasped it tight. I pulled her to her feet. "Look, one of us is gonna have to kiss Kyle and I don't want it to be me."

Her mouth fell open. “What?” she yelped. “Why does one of us *have* to kiss Kyle? I thought the whole point of the drinking was you didn’t have to kiss anyone you didn’t want to!” She dropped my hand and grabbed my waist, giving me a little shove.

My heart jumped into my throat.

“And the bottle could land on anyone! I could end up kissing…” she stumbled, “anyone.”

An evil little thought crept into my mind, and I acted on it without hesitation.

“You’re right. Like, I could end up kissing Scorpia.”

Her jaw clenched and the look in her eyes made my heart throb.

“If you end up kissing Scorpia, she’s going to have a heart attack and die. So, better hope that doesn’t happen.”

I grinned. “I knew you liked her.”

Adora rolled her eyes, then her face lit up and she threw out her arm. “Adam!”

He was walking past us, pretty slowly, obviously a drink or two in, and she grabbed onto his bicep and yanked him closer. He stumbled, and the giant shield he held in his right hand nearly swung up and hit Adora in the head.

He may’ve been dressed like Captain America, but he did not have the metabolism or the coordination.

“Whoa!” He grabbed us both by the shoulders and steadied himself. “’Dora, what the hell?”

“Sorry,” she breathed, squeezing his arm. “We’re about to play Spin the Bottle. Come play. Please!”

I furrowed my brow. I wasn't exactly sober, but it didn't really make sense to me why Adora would want to play a kissing game with her twin brother…

"Um…" Adam met my eyes and looked just as confused. "Sorry, I think you've got the wrong person. I'm your brother, Adam? If we kissed—"

She shook her hands. "No! Ew! Gross. You can drink instead of kissing."

Adam nodded slowly, and I resisted the drunken urge to ruin his perfectly coiffed hair. "So… why do you want me to play?"

Adora groaned. "The more people are playing, the less likely I am to land on…" she glanced at me, and I cocked my head. Then she shook her head and leaned forward to whisper in Adam's ear. But Adora's shit at whispering, and I still heard every word.

"*Certain people."*

I frowned and my stomach twisted up in knots. I didn't know what the fuck "certain people" meant, but I was pretty damn sure I was one. And it hurt.

But maybe it shouldn't have because Adam just started grinning.

"*Oh…*" he snickered and shook his head. "Yeah, you're on your own for this one, Kara."

"What?" Adora almost shrieked. "Who's Kara?"

I chuckled and Adam sighed. "It's Supergirl's real name. I can't believe you bailed on Thor and the Avengers to dress up as a character you know nothing about… you're a fake fan."

I put my hand on Adam's shoulder. "Wait, Adora, you were gonna be Thor?"

She crossed her arms over her stomach and dropped her chin. "Yeah…"

"That would've been sick! You would've made an awesome Thor!"

Adam smirked and Adora's frown deepened. The knots in my stomach wound tighter. "But you don't like Marvel."

"I…" I swallowed, suddenly feeling very warm, "what does that have to do with anything?"

Adora bit her lower lip. "If I was Thor, what would you have been?"

I didn't know what to say to that. Luckily I didn't have to say anything.

"Captain!" Sea Hawk cried, throwing an arm around Adam's shoulder. He was wearing the most normal thing I'd ever seen him in – a black tank top and black pants, and his trumpet was nowhere to be seen. He did have a black bow in one hand a quiver full of arrows strapped to his back. But all in all, pretty tame. "It's time!"

Duncan appeared at Adam's other shoulder then, dressed in a scary fancy Iron Man costume. "Yeah, Orko's got the fireworks outside. Let's go!"

"Wait!" Adora threw up her hands, "Do you guys wanna play Spin the Bottle?"

Duncan wrinkled his nose. "I'd rather go light the fireworks."

Sea Hawk frowned. "I'm sorry, Adora." He clapped Adam's shoulder. "Avengers? Assemble!" He threw his arm up in the air and ran for the door. Duncan and Adam followed. And Adora stared after them like she was going to die.

About ten minutes later, a freakishly tall lizard, a ridiculously scrawny gorilla, a suspiciously angelic Mothra, a pirate who couldn't decide which hand was her hook hand (Scorpia), a purple pig-tailed Borg (Entrapta, obviously), Catwoman, and the hottest fucking Supergirl to ever exist, were all sitting in a circle in Lonnie's TV Room with an empty bottle laying on its side in the middle. And Lonnie held a red solo cup in her hand and a bottle of mostly full Kirkland Tequila in between her legs.

"Okay," she said, "rules are simple. You spin the bottle. Whoever it lands on, you kiss. If you don't wanna kiss 'em, you've gotta take a shot." She held up the cup and traced her finger over the little bottom section. "You fill this little part, that's a shot. Got it?"

"God, Lonnie," I rolled my eyes, "this isn't our first time!"

She arched an eyebrow. "It's Adora's…"

I glanced at my Supergirl out of the corner of my eye. She was stiff as a board.

"She's taken a fucking shot before. And she's seen a movie. Let's go already."

Lonnie smirked at me, and just like Rogelio's smile from earlier that night it was… knowing. "Okay, okay. Geez, Catra."

Lonnie reached into the center of the circle, grabbed the bottle by the center, and spun.

My breathing stopped. I think everyone's did for a second. It was such a stupid game, but it never failed to turn all of us into squealing, blushing messes.

I looked up from the bottle to see where it landed and out of the corner of my eyes saw Adora's shoulders fall in relief. That's when

it hit me.

I was playing Spin the Bottle with… Adora…

My heart rate kicked into high gear, and I felt like I couldn't breathe.

I didn't even realize that the bottle landed on Scorpia until Entrapta's voice broke through my spiral. "Scorpia, you look quite flushed. Are you warm? Do you feel sick?"

"No! Nope!" Scorpia laughed nervously, and I finally looked at her. "Just, uh, ha, playing—playing the game."

I blinked, then looked to Lonnie. It was harder to tell with Lonnie's even, brown skin, but she was blushing almost as much as Scorpia.

Maybe I was the only one who didn't have a crush on every fucking one.

Well, me and Entrapta. I was pretty sure Entrapta didn't usually have crushes.

After a second more of blushing and bumbling, Lonnie and Scorpia leaned across the circle and gave each other a quick kiss.

And somehow their faces got even redder.

Kyle clapped. "My turn!" He reached forward, spinning the bottle quick and hard. After several solid spins, which I was almost aware enough to be impressed by, it landed on Rogelio.

Kyle beamed. "Don't mind if I do!"

Rogelio shook his head and leaned forward, lifting his mask away from his face. Kyle met him halfway, put his hands on his cheeks, and gave him a big, hard kiss.

Lonnie groaned. "You two are so gross."

“I don’t—what?” Adora whispered under her breath, and I actually managed a smile. I turned and met her eyes.

“They are gross.”

Her timid little smile was so bright I think I short circuited again.

I had a one in six chance of kissing Adora.

“Catra?” Scorpia said my name, and I was so startled I actually looked away from an angel in a crop top. “It’s your turn.”

I glanced down at the bottle.

One in six. That was a better chance than I was ever going to get again. That was 16.66% chance. That was so high.

I could kiss Adora. I wanted so badly to kiss Adora.

And I hoped to God I would never get what I wanted.

I reached out and took the bottle in my hand. I swallowed, closed my eyes, and with all the hand strength I possessed, I spun.

I didn’t open my eyes until I heard Lonnie cackling.

I followed the line of the bottle and relief and disappointment crashed over my body like a tsunami.

“I think I’ll take that shot now.”

Lonnie shook her head. “Awww come on, Catra. You really that afraid to kiss me?”

I leaned back on my hands. “I’m afraid of kissing anyone who might’ve kissed Kyle.”

And just like that Lonnie was red again. Honestly, it was a nice color on her.

Kyle was pale as a sheet though, and I was kinda worried I stopped his heart.

But Rogelio? Rogelio was cracking up. I'd never heard him laugh like that. He was bent in half, shaking. And that made me feel kinda proud of myself.

Lonnie turned to Kyle with an accusatory finger. "I thought *you* weren't ready to tell anyone!"

"I didn't say anything!" Kyle cried, throwing up his hands. "Why do you automatically think it's me?"

"Well, it's not Rogelio!"

"Why not?" Kyle's voice was just getting higher and higher and I snickered. "What? Because he's so perfect?"

"Because he never talks!"

"He *texts*."

Rogelio just started laughing harder.

Adora elbowed me and when I met her eyes, they were a little sad. I could read the plea in them so easily.

I sighed. "Look, you guys are really obvious." I reached over to Lonnie and took the red solo cup from her hand and the tequila from between her legs. "You're wearing a throuples costume for fuck's sake." I'd finally figured it out. Godzilla, King Kong, and Mothra. It was clever, I could give them that. "Even Adora noticed, and she's hella oblivious." I uncapped the tequila and filled the cup to the line.

"Hey!" Adora cried.

I gave her a soft smile and patted her knee. "You're fine."

Lonnie crossed her arms. “Are you seriously drinking instead of kissing me? That’s low, Catra, even for you.”

I cocked my head. “First off, nothing’s too low for me. Second, no.” I held the cup to my lips and tipped it back. I tried not to wince as the tequila burned down my throat. “But I’m not kissing Kyle vicariously sober.”

I moved to my knees, reached for Lonnie, and kissed her hard on the mouth.

I heard a couple little gasps, and then pulled away.

I smirked at the red creeping up onto Lonnie’s cheeks. “Did you like that, Lonnie?”

Her wide eyes narrowed and she shoved me away. “Oh, shut up, Catra!”

I cackled, falling back next to Adora, who caught me. I smiled up at her, expecting I’d get one back. But Adora wasn’t smiling. She looked sad.

“So, uh…” Scorpia tapped the tips of her fingers against her hook, “how long have you three been a thing?”

With that, and the fireworks that started going off, the game kind of fell apart. Adora never had to spin the bottle.

One long island iced tea later, I was lying on my back on what I was pretty sure was Lonnie’s parents’ bed right in that sweet spot of tipsy but not drunk. Adora was lying next to me and, from what I could tell, she was about the same. She’d had one beer and was working on a white Russian. We hadn’t spoken in about five minutes but our hands were gently moving against each other with the rise and fall of our breathing, and after a second of me wondering if it was always going to be like this, just the two of us

grazing rather than really touching, she twisted her fingers and wound them in mine.

My heart leapt into my throat.

“You okay, Princess?” I asked nudging her with my shoulder.

“Yeah,” she breathed, squeezing my hand. “Why wouldn’t I be?”

I shrugged, still staring at the ceiling. Unlike most people would’ve, Lonnie’s parents had painted their ceiling the same deep blue as their walls and the spackling took on a whole new kind of depth in that color. “You’ve just been kinda quiet. It’s not like you.”

Adora scoffed. “I can be quiet.”

“But you don’t have to be.” I broke my eyes away from the blue. I focused on the curve of Adora’s cheek and the line of her nose.

God, she was so beautiful. It hurt.

She sighed, but instead of turning to look at me, she turned her head away. “I didn’t like playing Spin the Bottle is all.”

I frowned. “That was like… over an hour ago.”

She shrugged.

My frown grew. “And you didn’t even have to kiss anyone!”

Adora turned away from me, ripping her hand out of mine. “I just didn’t like playing, okay!” Her voice hiked in pitch. My eyes went wide and she shrunk in on herself, crossing her arms and pulling away.

I turned on my side to face her and put a hand on her arm. I pulled myself closer and started to trace little circles into her skin.

“Why didn’t you like playing?”

She bit her lip and closed her eyes. She was quiet, but I waited.

"I—I didn't like seeing you kiss Lonnie," she whispered, and she bit her lip harder. Like maybe if she bit it off or something she could take back what she'd just said.

But she couldn't. She said it. But it obviously didn't mean what I wanted it to mean.

If it did, Adora wouldn't want to take it back.

"What," I joked, trying to give the words back to Adora, "don't like me kissing someone else?"

I knew her answer was going to break my heart.

"No!" she'd say and shake her head. "I just don't think she should get any ideas. You two would be a disaster."

"No, I just don't think it was fair to Kyle and Rogelio. Their relationship is obviously new, and I think the game put a strain on it."

"No, it was just weird watching you kiss my brother's ex-girlfriend."

Whatever her reason, it wasn't going to be the one I wanted to hear.

I waited for her to answer, but she wouldn't meet my eye. My heart started to beat harder and louder in my chest. It started to hope. So, I forced a snicker, shoved the hope down, and pressed a single finger to the center of her forehead.

"Aww, were you jealous?"

Her eyes locked on mine with a flash and they were hard and filled with lightning.

I stuttered, dropping my hand and letting my mouth fall open a little. Adora only ever looked like that on the court. Adora only ever looked like that when she was She-Ra.

So why was she looking at me like that?

When I started to pull away Adora's entire face softened and she grabbed at my hand.

"I—" she faltered, then loosened her grip and sighed, letting my hand slip away.

"Do you ever think about it?" she whispered, her eyes tight, and something like agony leeching into her voice. "Us? Kissing I mean?"

And then my heart stopped.

"I—" I couldn't form words. I couldn't remember words. All I could remember was that I was supposed to look at Adora's eyes when she spoke, not her mouth.

"Because I do," she whispered, like it was her deepest, darkest secret. "All the time. That's why I don't play Spin the Bottle. I—I want you to be my first kiss. I always have. And… I want it to be special."

I blinked. "Adora—"

She sat up in a rush. "But it's okay if you don't want that!" She held out her hands. "I'm more than happy to be your friend, Catra!" Her voice got thick. "I *have* to be your friend, Catra. Please, don't be mad at me. I can't… I can't lose you too."

I could tell just by the little shake in her fingers she was about to start panicking, so I grabbed Adora by the head, a hand on either side, and tangled my fingers in her hair. I pulled her forward until her forehead rested against mine. Her breathing was ragged and I carded my nails through her hair, scraping her scalp gently.

“Adora, stop.”

She stilled and took a slow and deep breath.

“Good?”

She nodded and leaned in to press her head into the crook of my shoulder.

“I—” I held Adora a little tighter, “I think about it too.”

Adora turned her head, her lips brushing the thin stripe of bare skin above my collar and below my jaw. “You do?”

I nodded. “Yes. And other… stuff.”

She exhaled and her breath tickled me all the way to my toes. She lifted her head and the hand she had at my waist squeezed. “What ‘other stuff’?”

I bit my lip. “Just… things!” I threw up my hand. “I don’t know!”

I could see the happy little twitch in the corner of her mouth and the lift in her cheeks. “Like sexy things?”

I narrowed my eyes. I’d had a lot of thoughts about Adora. I thought about kissing her, the way her mouth would feel against mine. And yeah I’d also thought about what she’d taste like and how it’d feel to have her fingers buried inside me. But usually they were sweeter than that. What it’d be like to wear Adora’s letterman. How it’d feel to walk hand in down the hall at school. What it’d be like to know that she loved me. But she didn’t need to know that.

“Don’t get cocky, Princess.”

Adora laughed, with a little wet snort thrown in. She leaned in, tapping her nose against mine. “Too late.”

A laugh ripped out of me and I brushed my thumb over her cheek – something else I often imagined. “You’re such an idiot.”

She beamed at me. “Yeah, I know.”

Then we fell silent and the air around us slowly got thicker and hotter. My hands wanted to shake, but I grounded them by holding onto Adora. I stared into her gray-blue eyes and let them anchor me.

And then she glanced at my lips and started to lean forward.

Fuck. Yes.

When her lips pressed against mine, they were soft and sweet; timid and gentle. But my entire body felt like it had been lit on fire. I tightened my grip on Adora, pressing in and sliding my lips against hers.

Adora got insistent then, tangling her fingers in my hair. She shifted above me and parted her lips. She wrapped them around my lower lip, and with the barest hint of teeth, pulled. I shivered, hard, and I could feel the smile on her face.

I sighed and before I could comment on her stupid grin, her mouth was on mine and her tongue in my mouth.

I rolled my hips instinctively and wrapped my legs around her waist. Then she laughed.

She pulled my head back by my hair and dropped her mouth to my ear. “This was worth the wait.”

Then I turned and kissed her again, with everything that I had, and she kissed me. And we didn’t stop. We kissed all night. It was the best night of my entire life. And it just led to better ones.

But if I could take that night back, I would. In a heartbeat.

It’s fine. She’s gone now. She got away and she’s better off. And so am I.

August 30, 2021

“Okay,” I say, stepping away from the whiteboard. “That’s how you read a chord. It’s a diagram. If you can’t figure that out, you’re beyond help.”

A few of the students in front of me actually laugh and I feel a small sense of triumph. It’s the first day back after summer break and I’m already getting laughs. By the end of the semester, these suckers are gonna love me.

I glance at the clock, I have about fifteen minutes left. That’s plenty of time to teach them a chord and check how everyone holds their guitars. Well, probably. Eh, it’s worth a shot.

I go back to the board, draw a quick E chord, explain why when you’re playing three notes at once you still call it that, and watch as they all fumble to put their fingers in the right spots.

After a minute, I step up to a girl in the front row with cropped dark hair who I recognize from my *Intro to Music* class last year. She’s in a thick blue jacket, which is weird ‘cause it’s literally August, and she’s kinda scowling.

“Frosta, right?” I ask, crouching in front of her and looking at her hand. She gives me a curt nod, as I take her fingers and arch them just a little more. “Good job,” I remark. “Now try strumming?”

Her eyes get a little wide and she looks down at the guitar in her lap like it has teeth. I bite back a smile.

“It’s really easy. You just—”

My entire body flinches at the sound of the door crashing open.

I look up and, with hurried steps, Perfuma rounds the corner of the short hall from the front door to the classroom. She's in a pink sundress that, personally, I think has too many straps to be functional, and looks particularly giddy.

And immediately I know something horrible is about to happen.

I turn back to Frosta. "Okay, hold your hand here, up above the strings—"

"Catra! I'm so happy to see you!" Perfuma cries, running to the center of the room. "I really want to talk to you."

I take Frosta's hand and slowly drag it down. "What about?"

"Um…" she looks around, like she's suddenly aware that I have students. "I really think we should talk privately."

I roll my eyes and nod at Frosta. She understands and brushes her fingers along the strings. She strums.

"It's your free period, Plumeria, not mine. I'll talk to you after class."

I can hear Perfuma's foot tapping but I just stand and moved onto the next student.

"Catra, it's about… the Olympics."

I freeze. Slowly I move from my partial crouch and turn to stare daggers at my so-called "friend".

"What did you say?"

Perfuma's eyes are big and whiny. "I just… I had a few questions for you. About the Olympics. I think—"

I don't even let her finish her sentence before I'm marching down the choir risers. I grab Perfuma by the arm and drag her back

around the corner. We stop in front of my office, hopefully out of ear shot.

Unless I start yelling. And I might start yelling.

I throw Perfuma's arm down. "What questions could you possibly have for me about the *Olympics*?"

She almost looks scared. Good. She should be scared. She should be terrified.

I cross my arms and Perfuma takes a steadying breath. "I just thought it was interesting. Adora Grayskull said she was going home. She's from here, isn't she?"

I clench my teeth. Guess Perfuma's decided to play dumb. She knows Adora's from Thaymor – her picture and old trophies are literally plastered all over the walls of this school. What she doesn't know is how hard it is for me to walk by those pictures and trophies every day and not rip them down and throw them on the ground. Or, she didn't. I thought.

"Scorpia," I growl and Perfuma pales a little.

"Catra…" Perfuma reaches out and hesitantly puts a hand on my upper arm, "Scorpia was very excited. I'm sorry if you feel like she betrayed your trust. I know that wasn't her intention. She was just trying to be an honest and communicative partner."

I roll my eyes. "Great. That makes it all better."

Perfuma frowns. "Why aren't *you* excited?"

My jaw pops open. "Why in the fucking world would I—"

"Wildcat!" The doors crash open again and Scorpia comes barging through them, arms thrown wide. "Ah I've missed you!"

Before I know it, she's sweeping me into a hug, and I can barely breathe. After about two seconds, I tap Scorpia's arm, but she

doesn’t seem to register it.

Perfuma smiles a little. “Uh, dear, I think you should put Catra down now.”

Scorpia turns, me still crushed in her embrace, and beams. “Oh! Perfuma, hey!”

Perfuma nods at me, and Scorpia stutters. “Oh—right!”

She releases me and I take a deep breath. “The fuck is wrong with you people!” I nearly shout. “I have a class!”

Scorpia frowns. “Hey, I’m sorry. I didn’t even think. I just—gosh, I was so excited to see you! What with Perfuma and I being gone all summer on our trip, there’s just so much catching up to do!”

I straighten a little and rub the back of my neck. “Yeah,” I mutter, “I bet.”

She nods furiously. “Like, yesterday, Perfuma and I were speed running the Olympics. Just watching the important ones, ya know? And I felt a little weird watching beach volleyball, but also I knew I’d feel weird if I didn’t because—I mean, Adora was also my friend and—”

I stiffen at the sound of her name. “What’s your point?”

“Right!” Scorpia shakes her head. “Sorry, getting a little off track there. My point is, after the final match Adora said…” Scorpia lowers her head, and her voice, like she’s sharing a secret and not the words of a publicly, and internationally broadcast interview, “she said that she was gonna come home.”

I don’t uncross my arms, and I don’t stop scowling.

“So?”

“So?” Scorpia whisper shouts, throwing out her arms. “It’s Adora! That’s a big deal!”

I sigh and shift my weight. I glance back at my students to see Frosta walking around and helping her classmates adjust their fingers and showing them how to strum. It's almost enough to make me smile.

"It's not," I sigh, meeting Scorpia's anguished eyes. "Really."

Scorpia sticks out her lower lip. "Bu—"

Perfuma raises her hand. "Why is it not a big deal, Catra?"

I clench my teeth again. Perfuma always does this. She asks the right questions. Nothing makes me want to hate her more.

But she's Scorpia's girlfriend. They're so in love it's gross. And, after all this time, Perfuma's also… my friend. I guess.

"It's just not. I—" I tighten my grip on my forearms. "Adora and I —"

I can't get the words out. I can't explain it to them. Not that I want to.

"What?" Scorpia presses. "I thought you—"

I snap.

"Where is she?" I growl, throwing my arms out. "If she's coming home then where, the fuck, is she?"

Scorpia and Perfuma's eyes are wide, and I take a deep breath. Until recently, I don't know how recently but I'm guessing pretty recently, Perfuma didn't even know about Adora. And Scorpia… Scorpia doesn't know what really happened. I can't yell at them for trying to understand things they don't.

"Look, Adora's made promises like this before. She's…" I wrap my arms around my chest, "she's not great at keeping them."

“Oh,” I look up into Scorpia’s eyes, and they're brimming with tears, “Wildcat… Come here!”

She reaches out for me and I hold out a hand. “Scorpia, I don’t—I don’t want a hug right now.”

Her lip puckers a little, but she nods and drops her arms. “Okay. Then you won’t get one.”

Perfuma steps forward, putting a hand on her girlfriend’s arm. “Is there anything we *can* do Catra?”

I tip my head back. “Um… leave, maybe?” I roll it forward. “I just wanna finish my class.”

Scorpia nods once, and grabs Perfuma’s hand. “Absolutely, boss. We will see you later!”

“And you’ll call us?” Perfuma asks as Scorpia flips them around and heads towards the door. “If you need anything else?”

I rub the back of my neck but nod. “Yeah. But… don’t expect a call.”

She frowns a little and then lets herself be pulled out the double doors into the hall.

I sigh and wait a few seconds before turning back around. I can hear my heart pounding in my ears, and it’s so loud.

I buried so many thoughts under floorboards in my mind and now they’re beating.

I walk back to the front of my classroom and smile at the dozen or so eyes that are staring me down.

“Sorry about that. Ms. Plumeria and Coach D’Ream are…” I huff, “very nosy.” I shake my head. “Anyway! Okay, so who’s next—”

But before I can walk over to any student, the shrill sound of the bell rings through the classroom.

I bite the inside of my lip. “Okay!” I try and smile, but I can tell it’s strained as hell. “I’ll see you all tomorrow!”

I go back to the piano, picking my lesson plan, syllabus, and a list of everyone’s names off the top while everyone files out. I brush my hair out of my eyes and reach down onto the stand to grab my guitar when a pair of teal jeans enters my line of sight.

I groan.

“Good, you’re here,” Mermista says, plopping herself into the edge seat that Frosta had just been in. “I wanna talk to you.”

I level her with a glare and grab my guitar by the neck. “What about?”

Mermista shrugs, inspecting her manicured, navy nails like they’ll tell her. “The Olympics. Sea Hawk said you guys had a friend competing in beach volleyball and—"

“Unfuckingbelievable.”

Mermista’s eyebrows rise. “Oh-kay. Someone’s feeling touchy today.”

“Yeah!” I nearly crumple the papers in my hand. “I am! Now get out,” I point at the door, narrowing my eyes, “before your band teacher shows up.”

“Man, this girl really did a number on you…”

I almost growl. “Mermista…”

“Yeah?”

I take a steadying breath. “We’re friends. I kinda like you. I tolerate your… arsonist—”

"You've literally been his friend longer than I have—"

"So, I'm going to ask you, as your friend, that you leave this alone. Understood?"

It takes a second, but soon Mermista's rolling her eyes. "Fine. Whatever. I don't even care, I was just bored."

She's lying, I know she is. But I appreciate the lie more than she could ever know.

"What are we talking about?"

I jump at the sound of Entrapta's voice. "Fuck!"

She's right behind me, and even though she just asked me a question, she's looking down at the binder in her hands. And she still has her safety goggles on her head.

"Adora Grayskull," Mermista says, and I hiss. She holds up her hands, like she's trying to calm me down or something. "Jesus, Catra."

"You just said you'd leave it alone!"

She crosses her arms and shrugs. "It's Entrapta, you really think she's gonna make a big deal out of it?"

I breathe in. Right. Entrapta won't give a shit.

But when I look back at her, she's lowered the binder and she's actually looking at me. Worse, she's looking at me with *soft* eyes.

I close my eyes. "Fuck."

"I'm sorry I intruded," Entrapta starts and my eyes snap open. "I'll go wait for you by the car if that's better." She purses her lips just as I go to speak. "But, if it helps, according to my records, Adora hasn't been back to Thaymor since winter break her freshman year of college, despite family, friends, and numerous

opportunities to return. That pattern of behavior suggests the probability of her coming back to be very low."

I smile a little and I can feel the sting of tears in my eyes. "Thank you, Entrapta."

She nods. "I'll go wait by the car now."

I shake my head and reach out for her shoulder. "You don't have to. Just give me a minute to grab my things."

She smiles softly, then turns and goes to sit in the chair next to Mermista.

"Where's your boyfriend?" she asks, opening her lunchbox and pulling out one of those little gummy hamburgers.

Mermista groans. "He's not my boyfriend."

I turn to head into my office. "Yeah, because he's your fiancé."

"Look, just because I said yes, doesn't mean I'm gonna marry him."

I snicker as Entrapta asks, "What does it mean then?"

I slip into my office and set my paperwork down on my desk. I flitter about for a minute, zipping my guitar into its case, folding up my laptop, grabbing my tumbler, trying to gather my thoughts, when I notice a bright yellow sheet of paper on my desk.

It's the PTA monthly newsletter. I go to pick it up and my eyes quickly scan the page.

I notice snowflakes in the bottom left corner.

My fingers start to shake. Surrounded by a border of snowflakes in the bottom left corner is an announcement. Fundraising's starting. For the New Year's Eve Gala.

I let the newsletter flutter back to the desk and take a deep breath.

Then I hear a fucking trumpet playing.

The door to my classroom bursts open for the third fucking time and Sea Hawk walks in, head tipped back, mouth glued to that damned piece of tin, making the most obnoxious squawks I've ever heard.

He passes my office and I forget my bag, my tumbler, and my sanity. I march after him into the main room to see Mermista groan and Entrapta clap her hands.

"Sea Hawk!" I yell, and his steps falter. He pulls the trumpet from his mouth and turns to smile at me.

"Catra! How lovely to see you, old friend. How was your first day back?"

I grab him by the collar and drag him back towards the exit hall. "Mermista," I seethe, and her eyes are wide. "Take your stupid trumpet playing pirate and get the fuck out of my classroom. Now."

Mermista stands up slowly. "Yeah, okay," she breathes. She walks forward, taking Sea Hawk's arm. I drop his collar and cross my arms.

"Catra," Mermista almost whispers, shooting me a look not of contempt like I expect, but of genuine concern, "call me if you need anything. Okay?"

I take a deep breath. "Whatever."

"Please."

I shoot her a quick glance and notice that even Sea Hawk is looking at me with sympathy.

I hate it.

“Fine.”

Finally, they leave.

After a second, I drop my arms to my sides and cross into the center of the room. I slump in my chair and throw my head back. I feel like crying. I’ve been such an ass, and I know that. And I don’t know what else I could’ve been.

Entrapta steps up in front of me, twisting her hands together. “Can I ask you a question?”

I lift my head.

“It’s Adora related.”

“I may not answer.” I say, straightening.

“I assumed,” she says, twiddling her thumbs.

“What’s the question?”

“Do you…” she almost flinches, “*want* Adora to come back?”

My breath catches. “I—What would she even come back for?”

Chapter End Notes

> 🥳 YAY! 🥳
>
> Sorry, just really excited that I got this done today. I'm already working on the next chapter so that should be out next Friday!
>
> Comment! Kudos! Tell me how you really feel!
>
> Again, a thanks to my betas Horchata_Latte, petty_labelle, and infinitegay. Your enthusiasm for this story is so

rewarding. I love every little thought you have about it. I'm glad I get to take this journey with you.

You too! ❤️

The Way You Look At Me

Chapter Notes

Hello! And we're back!

Just a friendly little reminder - in the immortal words of Thumper the bunny, "If you don't have something nice to say, don't say nothing at all." Negative comments, though they seem like nothing, can be really hurtful. And if you don't like the fic or disagree with some of the choices I've made you are always free to stop reading. Thank you.

Now to talk shop - Catra and Adora grew up in Thaymor. Thaymor is basically a small midwestern town where a graduating class never has more than 300 people. I grew up in a town like that in Michigan and it lends itself so well to this kind of story. Bright Moon, in comparison, is like LA or San Diego. Big, shiny, west coast city with a fancy ass university.

Also - I forgot to mention in the last update but after the initial posting of the prologue I realized that I accidentally posted the wrong draft of the prologue. The differences are minor, really it's just a paragraph or so at the end, but BASICALLY what you need to know, for plot, is that Adora left her letterman jacket with Catra when she went off to school.

Okay! Well, this is the first chapter from Adora's point of view, and I hope you all can see past your rage (lol) and enjoy it! Happy reading!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora

" We've grown old, no words can say how much I've missed you. So instead of these, I'll just say It's good to see you again." – Anyonymous

December 31, 2012

Decembers in Thaymor are magic. There's snow on the ground, and lights in the trees, and the air is crisp with the beginnings of winter. But the December of mine and Catra's senior year was more than all that. It was enchanted.

We'd only started dating about two months before, but since that first kiss I'd felt like I was floating. Everything was just… better. She'd always been what kept me warm, but in those few weeks she became my own personal sun. It was like I revolved around her. She stole all my attention and was the center of every single thought I had.

I was so in love with her. And I didn't have a clue how to tell her.

But I was happy. I shouldn't have been, and I knew that. It was… wrong to feel so good when *they* weren't there. And I missed them with every beat of my heart. Really, I swear. I spent most of Christmas Day in tears, waiting for them to walk into the room and wish me good morning. But the ache was dulling every day, and there were nights I'd forget to be sad.

Awful feelings just didn't last when Catra was around. She made things too good.

It was New Year's Eve, the last day of the Thaymor Annual Yule Festival, and the New Year's Eve Gala was only a few hours away. Catra and I were seniors, and even though we'd gone the the year before, this time was special. This time, instead of a large group of friends taking pictures and going out for dinner, it was just the two of us. This time she was my date, even if no one else knew it.

We hadn't told anyone we were dating yet. Well, except Adam, who caught us making out in my bedroom because he never learned how to knock. But other than him, we were waiting. I didn't know for how long; I just knew that her mom would kill her

if she ever found out. And Mara and Razz would potentially ban sleepovers, which was the last thing I wanted. But I also just wanted to stand up on the roof of Thaymor High and scream for the whole world to hear, "I love Catra Weaver! And she's my girlfriend!"

But that day we were at the park, just us with nothing to hide, walking through the Ice Sculpture Forest, and she had her hand shoved into my coat pocket with her fingers loosely wrapped around mine.

I was so caught up in the warmth of her hand, even through her thick wool gloves, I didn't notice the grimace on her face, or that she'd stopped walking.

"A unicorn?" she shook her head, "Seriously? Wasn't the theme this year monsters or something?"

I cocked my head and held back a smile. "No? What kind of winter festival would have a monster theme? That's like, super weird."

"Well," She threw up her free hand, "what's the theme?"

"Mythic," I said, turning to get a good look at the sculpture. The creature was up on its hind legs, obviously in the middle of a whinny, mane carved like there was wind blowing, with a proud, long horn sticking out of the center of its head, and a large pair of wings on its back, spread wide, ready for flight.

"Well, a unicorn is still a dumb choice. Too topical." Catra lightly tugged on my hand like she was ready to move on, but I was still looking.

I didn't know what she meant about "topical", and I was going to ask her, but instead I muttered, "Technically it's an alicorn," and let myself imagine what it would look like in full color, with bright, rainbow wings.

"What?" Catra said, like she didn't hear me.

I flinched. “It has wings.” Reluctantly I turned my head and met her confused expression. “And a horn. So, *technically,* it’s an alicorn.”

It took a second, but Catra’s eyes rolled, just like I knew they would, and she put her free hand on her hip. “Of course you know that.” She shot me a look out of the corner of her eye and wore the tiniest smirk. “This is your favorite sculpture we’ve seen so far, isn’t it?”

I narrowed my eyes. “So, what if it is?”

Catra laughed. She reached over and tapped me on the nose, and I could feel her nail pressing through the fabric of her scratchy gloves. “You’re such a dork.”

I sputtered. “Bu—Your favorite was the castle with the dragon!” Her expression shifted, smirk disappearing. “Don’t even pretend it wasn’t!”

She pursed her lips a little. “So?”

“So?” I scoffed. “That’s so dorky!”

She rolled her eyes again, but I could tell from the set of her mouth I was right. “Whatever, Princess.”

I huffed and glanced back at the alicorn. For a second I felt ridiculous. It was just a pretty horse – why did I like horses so much anyway? It wasn’t like I rode them anymore. I quit the equestrian team years before. I chose volleyball and I didn’t have any reason to regret it. But sometimes… sometimes I’d remember what it was like to ride…

I felt Catra’s lips on my cheek and they broke me out of my thoughts. “It’s okay,” she murmured, squeezing my arm. “I like dorks. Almost as much as I like princesses.”

I met her eyes and took in the small smile that she was wearing. Her eyes looked so pretty in the twilight with little Christmas lights

reflecting in them. And they were so big, and open.

And in that second, I was taken back. I remembered her sitting on the edge of my bed, her hair long and tangled down her back while I sat across from her holding her hands.

"You have to promise not to freak out." I'd said, dropping my jaw. "Promise."

"Fine!" she sighed, throwing her head back. "Just tell me!"

"And you can't say anything about money, or quitting, or not making it, or—"

"God! Adora! Tell me!"

Then I'd finally smiled. "You can try out for cheer."

Her brow wrinkled and she frowned. After a second her expression grew skeptical – suspicious. "How?"

I couldn't stop smiling. "My mom. And dad, probably, too. They called your mom and told her they'd pay for everything! And my mom said she'll pick you up from every game, and competition. She's probably gonna be there anyway! And when Adam and I get a car, we'll come get you. And she's already called the coach and told her that you taught yourself how to do a standing backflip and she said they're really excited for your tryout."

Catra swallowed and opened her mouth. "Adora—"

"I know." I held up my hands. "You don't want my parents to spend money on you. Or waste their time. And you don't think you'll even make the team, or that you'll be any good…" I bit my cheek at that one. "I know you think all of that, but you're wrong. And even if you weren't…" I take a deep breath and pick Catra's hands up from her lap, "it doesn't matter."

There were tears in the corners of Catra's eyes. "It should."

I shrugged. “It doesn’t.”

Her voice was choked, and her eyes were wide. “Why?”

I moved to my knees, crawling towards her on the bed. I came up on her side and wrapped my arm around her waist. I pressed my forehead to her temple.

“We care about you Catra. *You* matter.” She turned her head and almost smiled. I’d practiced this little speech, making sure I’d say exactly the right words to reach her. I had to reach her.

“It was their idea ‘ya know? My dad overheard you talking about it, and he asked me after you left why you couldn’t try out. When I told him your mom’s a bitch, he said that wasn’t a reason.”

She let out the quietest little snicker.

“I told him what she said about the money and everything else. Then he just nodded, you know that thing he does where he sticks out his lower lip? And walked off.” I squeezed her waist. “Two days later my mom tells me to sit down at the kitchen table and asks me if I think she could convince your mom to let you tryout.”

And that was true – mostly. Really though, she’d told me that she’d thought about paying for Catra’s cheer and wanted to be able to take her to her meets. But she was worried, worried that Catra’d say no, and about the cost. My parents weren’t sure they’d be able to afford it, or even have the time, with me on the equestrian team and in volleyball, and Adam’s soccer and football. So she wanted to know – would I quit one for Catra?

I didn’t even have to think about it.

Adam even quit soccer. He said it was because he needed to get serious about football if he was gonna get scholarships, but I knew him better than that. It was for Catra.

“I don’t understand why she cares,” Catra swallowed. “It was just a stupid idea…”

“It wasn’t stupid,” I said, feeling sure of myself. “And that’s why my parents are doing this. They believe in you, just like I do.” I lifted my head. “So, please, just let them do this. Please.”

What felt like an hour later Catra finally smiled, small, with wide and shining eyes.

“Okay, Princess. I guess I’ll let you spoil me.”

It was the same look, that day on my bed and that evening in the park, and I felt the same bone deep warmth. It was in that exact second that I realized I didn’t choose volleyball over horses. I chose Catra over everything else.

“Come on,” she said, tugging me back towards the snow packed path. “It’s getting late. And you’re a princess, so it’ll take you forever to get ready.”

I rolled my eyes. “I am ready before you every time.”

“Well yeah,” she shrugged, and we made our way back to the road and towards my house, “princes take even longer.”

“Oh yeah? Why’s that?”

“Layers.”

I snickered and squeezed her hand, slipping my frozen fingers under her glove and onto her palm.

“Hey!” she cried and tried to rip her hand away. But I tightened my grip.

“So warm…”

She rolled her eyes and stopped struggling. “You’re the worst.”

I tugged her closer. “But you *like* me.”

She shook her head, and for a second we walked in silence. Right before I went to ask her about Scorpia, and if she was still being weird about even talking to Catra, Catra dropped her head and whispered, “What makes you think it was the dragon, anyway?”

I blinked. “Um…” I shrugged, trying to sort through the thoughts I hadn’t been thinking for what felt like ages. “I don’t know,” I finally shrugged. “Just a feeling.”

She scoffed. “A feeling?”

“You just,” I fiddled with the zipper on my coat, “you looked at it like it was special.”

Kinda like how you sometimes look at me.

After a moment of silence Catra sighed. “You think too much Grayskull.” Then she smirked and her hand darted up to rip my beanie off my head.

“Hey!” I cried as she pulled away from me and shove the hat onto her head. She smirked and jumped out of my reach when I lunged for her.

“Catra!”

She turned and ran down the street, her squeaky laugh echoing in the still winter air.

And I chased after her.

An hour or so later I stood in my bathroom in a calf length red dress, my hair lying flat around my face, and stared hard into the mirror. I was staring at my bare face, and in my left hand I gripped a tube of mascara.

“I can do this,” I breathed, and even I didn’t believe me. Still, I lifted the tube and slowly unscrewed the lid. “I can do this.”

Then there was a quiet tapping at the door.

I panicked, letting out a squeal and chucking the tube of mascara into the tub. It clattered against the wall, and I flinched at the sound.

“Adora?” Mara called, “can I come in?”

“Um—yeah! I—sure!” I laughed nervously, brushing my hair out of my eyes. “I mean, why not?”

Slowly the door opened, and Mara peaked inside. She looked me up and down and beamed, then opened the door wider. “Oh, Adora…”

I held up my hand. “Don’t get sappy on me.”

She pursed her lips, straightening and walking into the bathroom. “Why not?”

“Because,” I brushed my hands down the length of my dress, “you’re my aunt. You’re supposed to be ‘ya know… cool about these things.”

“I’m cool!” she scoffed. “I’m so cool. I’m basically ice.”

I sighed and looked her up and down. “You’re about to hug me.”

Before I could take a breath her arms were wrapped around me and she squeezed so hard I couldn’t breathe. “You look so beautiful Adora!” I gasped for air and she shook me back and forth. “You’ve grown up so much and I’m so proud of you!”

I could feel myself flush with embarrassment, but something inside me fluttered like a heartbeat and tears pricked at my eyes. For just a second I imagined someone else’s arms around me and listened for a different voice in my mind.

But there was none.

Finally, I hugged her back. “Thanks,” I breathed. “I think I needed to hear that.”

She nodded, eventually pulling away. She brushed the hair out of my eyes and her smile was soft. “I know this year’s been… hard. But you and Adam have handled it like champs and I’m so proud of everything you’re becoming. And I know they are too.”

I almost smiled back. “I know.”

After a minute she recovered and grabbed me by the shoulders. “So! Are you wearing your hair down?”

I frowned. “Um… no? That feels like… a lot. But I don’t want it to be just the same, right?”

She nodded and picked up a strand. “What about putting something in it? Like a headband or a bow?”

I grimaced. “A bow?”

She laughed, tucking the hair behind my ear. “Okay! No bow.” She looked at me a little longer, then her face lit up with a smile. “Wait! I have just the thing!”

Next thing I knew she’d dragged a chair into the bathroom, and I was sitting while she brushed my hair back and a large, gold, butterfly clip sat on the counter.

“So,” she asked, glancing at my reflection in the mirror, “why is my mascara sitting in the tub?”

I bit my lip. “You startled me.”

She grinned. “Were you trying to put it on?”

I dropped my gaze. “Maybe.”

She nodded, then started pinning up my bangs in the little poof that Catra always made fun of. After she was done, she gave it a gentle little pat. “Do you want help?”

I lifted my head a little. “With what?” My eyes widened. “Makeup?”

She nodded, picking up the brush again and pulling the rest of my hair back into a ponytail.

“I—I don’t know,” I admitted, wringing my hands. “Do you think I should wear it?”

She shrugged, wrapping the elastic around my hair. “Only if you want to.”

I nodded as she pulled my hair tight and smoothed it with her fingers. “Will I… will I look super different, do you think?”

“Only if you want to. But I’ve always thought of makeup as a way of making you look like… more. If that makes sense?” She took the butterfly clip off the counter and held it above my head. “An enhancer.” She took the clip and secured it right above my ponytail.

“Okay,” I breathed, straightening in my chair. “Maybe just a little.”

She smiled and rubbed her hands down my arms. “You’re being very brave today She-Ra.”

I let out a long breath. “I just… I want tonight to be special.”

Mara nodded, dropping her hands and walking over to the tub. “It will be kiddo, don’t worry.” She reached down and picked up the mascara, shaking her head. “Razz wouldn’t even let me in to see Catra.”

“Really?” I asked. I could feel my heart start to beat a little harder. I was nervous to talk about Catra with Mara. I was trying so hard to be normal about her, to act like I always did. But I didn’t know

how to do that anymore – I wasn't even sure what was different. But I knew Mara would see right through me. I knew she'd figure out something was going on.

"Yeah. She's being very cagey about her outfit." Mara chuckled. "They even had Adam standing guard."

She came back to the counter and opened the drawer to my left, pulling out a clear, thin box full of colored powders and a dark blue rectangular tube. She reached down and turned my chair so it was angled to face her.

My heart rate picked up again, for an entirely different reason. I stared at the box of colors and swallowed. "Oh."

Mara followed my gaze and rolled her eyes. "Just breathe Adora. If you don't like it, we can take it right off."

I nodded and she picked up the thin, clear box. With a click it opened and she picked up a brush somewhere from inside it. I watched as she rubbed the brush in one of the squares of color, a light gold, then lifted it towards my face.

"Close your eyes kid."

I gave her a short nod and did as she asked.

It was a pretty quick thing – she brushed some powder on my eyelids, rubbed some lipstick on my lips, and helped me brush mascara into my eyelashes. When we were done, she had me turn in the chair and look at myself in the mirror.

"So," she grinned, "what do you think?"

"Oh," I breathed, shock coursing through my whole body. I reached up and let my hand hover over my cheek.

I am *a princess,* I thought.

It was like my face was glowing, just a little, and I finally understood what Catra meant when she said I was beautiful and princess-y and all that other stuff. I wasn't gorgeous or anything, but I felt… pretty.

And a little ridiculous.

"Do I look stupid?" I asked, and Mara laughed.

"No, you do not look stupid." She shook her head. "Don't you trust my skills?"

I swallowed and wiped my palms on my skirt. "I just… I want tonight to be special and I don't want to ruin it by being… too much," I sighed, leaning forward and turning my head to the side.

Mara nodded, standing up and sliding the makeup back in the drawer. "You said that. And why does *tonight* have to be special?"

I froze, my fingers on my mouth. "What do you mean?"

She shrugged. "Just wondering what's so great about tonight…" Mara eyed me with a small smirk on her lips. "Is it just senior year, or is there maybe… something else?"

I swallowed, leaning back in my chair. "What else could it be?"

"Oh, I don't know." She rolled her head and put her hand on the back of her neck. "But Catra's obviously going all out for this one. And you aren't going with a big group this year. So, I was just thinking—"

"Catra and I are dating!" I blurted. Then I threw my hand over my mouth and cursed. The words had been itching in my mouth and it felt so good to let them out, but I definitely hadn't meant to. Not really. Obviously, I'd said them, but it was a split-second decision that I regretted instantly.

Or I thought I would.

“I knew it!” Mara clapped, the brightest smile on her face.

I dropped my hand from my mouth and frowned. “You what?”

She put her hand on her hip and rolled her eyes. “Come on kid, you aren’t exactly subtle. I’ve seen the way you look at Catra for years now. It’s only gotten worse the last couple months.” She leaned back against the counter. “So, I want details. What happened? When did you finally break?”

I stared at her, totally taken aback. “Um… her birthday…”

Mara snickered and crossed her arms. “Pretty good present, huh?”

I blinked and shook my head. “Wait, are you—you’re not worried? Or upset? Or—”

Her brow furrowed. “Why would I be?”

“Well we—we have sleepovers! And I didn’t tell you! And it’s been, like, *months* . And if I hadn’t told my *mo—”*

“Whoa, whoa, whoa,” Mara held out her hands, placing them on my shoulders. “Kid, breathe.”

I took a deep breath and she kinda laughed.

“I’m not mad. Or worried. I’m sure you had your reasons for keeping it to yourselves. And you *did* tell me, eventually. And if you hadn’t today, I know you would’ve sooner or later. You’re not really the type for secrets.”

I sighed, dropping my shoulders under her grip. “I’m really not.”

She snickered. “As for sleepovers – if you two are gonna have sex, I don’t think there’s much I could do to stop you.” She smirks. “So I don’t see a reason that sleepovers have to stop.”

I cocked my head and clicked my tongue. “You’re definitely an aunt.”

Mara rolled her eyes. “Well, appreciate it. Now, come on. Your girl is waiting.”

I was sitting on the couch when Catra came out of Razz’s bedroom. I remember that I was picking at my cuticles and thinking about how I was going to tell Catra that I’d told Mara we were dating. I remember pulling a piece of skin too hard and wondering, *will she be mad at me?*

Then I heard her footsteps.

“Hey, Adora.”

I looked up and suddenly I wasn’t thinking anything. My mind went completely blank and my pulse started to race. I stood and grabbed a fistful of my skirt. “Catra,” I murmured, “you look—”

She smirked at me. “I know.”

She was wearing a suit. The perfect suit. It was burgundy, hugged her in all the right places, and she had the sleeves rolled up to just below the elbow. Her shirt was bright red and her bow tie hung loose around her neck. She had on fingerless gloves, and her long nails were painted black. She stood with a hand on her hip and brushed her bangs from her eyes. “You don’t look too bad yourself, Princess.”

I could feel myself blush. “Mara did my hair.” I lifted a hand to my head and smoothed it down. “And makeup. But, uh,” I gestured to her outfit and then back to mine, “we match.”

Catra’s smirk softened. “Yeah, I guess we do.”

I nodded and stepped closer to her. “Where um…” I don’t know why I suddenly felt so nervous. It was just Catra – the same Catra who’d stolen my hat a few hours before and told me horses were stupid.

But she was in a suit, and she looked so…

It was like Mara said about makeup – it makes you more; enhanced. Catra in that suit was enhanced. And I could barely handle it.

I wanted to reach out and kiss her so much it hurt. But instead I gripped my skirt and just looked.

"Where did you get the suit?"

Catra's cheeks got pink and my fingers ached to hold her. "Um… Goodwill. Razz tailored it though. And also took it to the dry cleaners." She scoffed, scratching the back of her neck. "She tried to tie my bowtie but she forgot how."

I stepped forward again and finally let myself touch. I reached out and grabbed the end of her bowtie, rubbing the silky fabric between my fingers. "I like it like this," I said, smiling a little. "It's… defiant. Like you."

She chuckled and went to put her hand on my waist. But a second before, Razz stepped out of her bedroom, holding up a pair of black, ballet flats. "Cyra! You forgot your shoes, silly girl!"

Catra dropped her hand and stepped back, pulling her bow tie from my fingers. "Right. Guess I'll need those."

Razz handed the shoes to Catra and chuckled to herself. "So, Adora, what do you think? Grandma Razz did a good job, no?"

I smiled, stepping back into Catra's space. Her eyes went wide, but I didn't back away. I took her hand in mine and gave it a solid squeeze.

"You did great Razz." Catra's hand was warm and solid, and my nerves melted away. "You look beautiful," I whispered.

Catra blushed, hard, and her voice was soft when she said, "I… thanks. You too." Then she smiled and she looked at me like she'd

looked at that dragon. “I’m… I’m excited. I feel like I’ve been waiting for tonight my whole life.”

I grinned. For some reason, that thrilled me. Maybe because I wanted to believe that I was what Catra had been waiting for.

“Me too.”

December 14, 2021

“I can’t believe you’re retiring!” Glimmer cries from the perch she’s taken up on my kitchen island. She throws up her hands. “Adora! You’re 26!”

I roll my eyes and turn back to the box I have set on the counter in front of me. It’s filled with plates and bowls, and other dishware I’m taking to Goodwill. Still, I’m trying to pack it nicely. I’d feel terrible if it all broke on the way there.

I pick up a plate and a bundle of newspaper. “Yeah, and I play professional volleyball. I’d retire by 35 anyway.”

“That’s in, like, nine years!” Glimmer groans. “That’s so far away!”

She’s right. Which is exactly the problem. It’s too long, way, way too long.

“Who is Bow supposed to play with?” she asks, and I shrug, not even bothering to come up with a real answer.

Frankly, as much as I love and care about Bow, I don’t care who he plays with next. He’s going to be fine. No, he’ll be great. He’s a great player and a better partner. I’m not worried about him.

It’s one of the few things I’m not worried about.

“What about silverware?” Bow asks, who seems just as concerned about his career as I am. He holds up a fork and pats the side of

his box, one of the few that says keep,

I purse my lips. “Keep the really tiny spoon and fork. Oh! And the reusable straws.”

He sifts through the drawer. “What about this plastic spoon with… is that the Trix bunny?”

“Keep!” I cry, startling him. “Sorry, yes um… keep that one.”

He raises an eyebrow but nods slowly and starts going through the drawer.

“You’re just gonna get rid of everything?” Glimmer nearly shrieks. I’m honestly impressed she hasn’t lost any of the energy she started this conversation with. “Seriously? How long do you plan on staying with your aunt and grandma?”

I shrug again, reaching up into the cabinet above my head to grab a plain, white, mug. “As long as I have to.”

“And then what?” I glance back at her. “You’re just gonna, what, buy all new stuff?”

I try not to grimace. “If I have to.”

I don’t want to buy new stuff though – not dishes and silverware anyway. Not if I’m buying them alone. But I won’t say that out loud. I won’t even let myself think the full thought. I can’t make myself promises. Especially ones that someone else has to keep.

There’s a pause, and for a second I’m stupid enough to think Glimmer’s little tirade is over. “Who the hell is this girl?”

I sigh, dropping my hands to either side of the box and grip the counter.

“Glimmer…” Bow starts.

"No!" Glimmer's voice is high, irritated, and starting to irritate me. "I mean it Bow! We've known Adora since freshman year and I can't remember her *ever* mentioning a Catara!"

I close my eyes and huff. "It's Catra." My voice is hard. "And I talked about her all the time freshman year, so I don't—"

"Wait…" Glimmer cuts me off. She gasps. "The Horde Scum?"

I flip around, glaring. "Is that seriously all you remember?"

Glimmer crosses her arms. "Your girlfriend was Horde Scum! That's defining! Gah, and you'd play her covers of their songs constantly!" She shakes her head. "You did not talk about her *all* the time!"

I sigh. Horde Scum is what people would call diehard fans of The Horde, literally one of the biggest pop punk bands of all time. And Glimmer was right about one thing – Catra had been a fan. And I had played the covers she recorded and put up on YouTube… a lot. She'd only ever made two, and I would play them on repeat for hours, especially after winter break my freshman year. It was just so comforting to hear her voice. And yeah, it hurt, but listening to her sing, even listening to some of my favorite Horde songs, always helped me breathe.

They warmed me.

"They were good covers," I say.

Glimmer rolls her eyes. "I didn't say they weren't, but after a while everything gets old." She wrinkles her nose. "Kinda deep cuts though. 'No One Wants Me' and 'Maelstrom'? I mean they're good, some of the best, but they weren't like, singles or anything. But that's not the point!"

I cross my arms. "So you do have one?"

She sighs and drops her arms. "Yes. Adora… You stopped listening to those covers. And you stopped talking about her completely.

Not that you brought her up a ton to begin with." I grimace. "I mean…" she frowns, "didn't you break up?"

I swallow and drop my head. The quiet ringing of silverware tapping against each other stops as Bow stills. I can feel both of their eyes on me, but I just stare at my feet.

"It wasn't that simple," I mutter.

"Okay, well explain it then." Glimmer's voice is soft now, gentle, "You never told us anything. You just…" she sighs, "moved on."

I take a deep breath and lift my head. I stare Glimmer down for a second, gripping my arms tighter.

I did not move on.

I want to tell her – I really do – but I still feel like I did eight years ago. I don't think she'll understand. Glimmer has been with Bow officially since we were twenty, and before that she dated really casually. But Bow's always been right there. They grew up together, went to college together, live together. And it's Bow – the friendship/communication expert. Glimmer's never had to make the choices I have, or walk away from anything she wanted, even it was only for a little while.

Bow puts his hand on my shoulder, pulling my gaze. "It's okay Adora. We just want to understand."

I clench my jaw. "It's complicated, okay? But we didn't break up. We just… we made a plan."

What I won't dare say, the words hanging on the tip of my tongue, weigh heavy in my heart.

She's waiting for me.

"Really?" Glimmer asks, but not like she thinks I'm ridiculous, just like she's nervous. "Because it feels like maybe you're doing that

thing where you run headfirst into something because you know if you think about it you're gonna unravel."

I bite my tongue. I hate this. I hate that Glimmer is picking at this. I'm trying, hard, to keep my hands from shaking as I go to grip the countertop again.

"I know what I'm doing, Glimmer. Just… trust me. This was the plan the whole time."

Bow squeezes my shoulder. "What was?"

"I was always gonna go home," I explain. "As soon as I got a gold medal I was gonna go home." I let out a shaky breath. "I have been working for this for so long…"

Bow nods and moves his hand to rub my back. "I get it. It's hard, being away from the people you love."

I swallow. "You have no idea."

Glimmer sighs, loudly, and hops off the counter. "Okay. I—I can respect that." She frowns. "But do you really have to leave the day after our wedding?"

I chuckle and straighten. "Glimmer, you're lucky I stayed to go to your wedding."

She gasps. "You're Bow's best man!"

I nod and rub the back of my neck. "Exactly."

She shakes her head, feigning disappointment. "This Thaymor must be pretty special."

I smile a little and turn back to the cupboard. "You'll see for yourself."

Glimmer groans, and I chuckle. "I can't believe you convinced us to have our honeymoon in a small town in the Midwest. In

December! We could be sipping cocktails out of coconuts on a beach somewhere!"

"Aw, come on Glimmer!" I can hear the smile in Bow's voice. "Thaymor's Yule Festival is legendary. And the bed and breakfast we're staying at has amazing reviews. You know you'd rather have a white Christmas."

"No," Glimmer says, and I glance back to see her shaking her head. "In the words of Mariah, 'all I want for Christmas, is you'."

Bow beams. "You got me, baby."

I roll my eyes and reach into the cupboard for another mug. After a second Glimmer steps up next to me and opens a drawer.

"Anything you want me to keep in here?" she asks, sifting through the wooden spoons and whisks.

"Nope." I pop the p. "Razz and Mara have all that."

She nods and starts pulling out utensils. "So, Catra, huh? What's she like?"

I can't help the smile that takes over my face. "Oh, now you ask?"

She shrugs. "Better late than never right?"

My heart leaps at her words. I look down at my hands and think about how cold they always are now. I think about how long eight years is, and for a second I let myself get wrapped up in the fears I've been burying under the memory of Catra telling me she loves me.

What if it's been too long? What if she met someone else? What if we don't fit like we used to? What if she gave up on me?

I clench my fist. I remember the way Catra would look at me – like I was special. I remember how her hand felt in mine – how it fit perfectly. I remember her promise.

"I love you too. I always have. I waited my whole life for you. I think I can wait a couple years longer."

"Yeah," I mutter, "I guess it is."

December 17, 2021

Thaymor is still magic in December. There's snow on every lawn, Christmas lights on every tree, and downtown is bustling as everyone gets ready for the Yule festival. My heart fills as I drive down the streets, memories flooding my mind.

I'm in my truck, and I have a U-Haul hitched to the back. I should stop at home, unload, and plan. I should buy flowers or something. Instead, I head straight for the high school, only one person on my mind.

She's the star of every memory.

Even though Catra and I haven't… well, talked much the last several years, we were still friends on Facebook and Instagram. I've watched her life closely, and sometimes I feel like a stalker. I check her page at least once a day, looking for any little details I can get about her life.

And that's how I know she's a teacher now. That's how I know she's at Thaymor High (go Billy goats!) and probably teaching a group of rambunctious kids guitar or how to sing right this minute.

I pull into the school parking lot and park in the far corner. As I get out of my car and start for the front doors, I do my best not to get overwhelmed. On the outside, nothing has changed. The marquee is still announcing the New Year's Eve Gala and the sidewalks are covered in bright purple salt. But I don't know what's behind those doors, and I'm nervous.

I go to the office first and ask them about Catra. The woman behind the front desk is short, thin, with dark skin and thick black hair pulled up into a bun.

"Hey," I whisper, breaking the silence. I glance at the clock and pull my old letterman jacket tight. School gets out in about 15 minutes, but I don't think I can wait that long. "I was just wondering if you know if Catra Weaver is in today?"

The woman looks up and startles. "Oh!" she cries, in a tiny voice. "Um, uh, wow. We're… you're…"

I nod, smiling a little. "Yeah." I hold out my hand. "Adora Grayskull. Nice to meet you."

She takes my hand and smiles a little back. "Hi! I'm Penny."

I wait a moment then purse my lips. "Catra Weaver?"

"Oh! Yes!" She stands, then sits, then shakes her computer mouse. "She is…" Penny's eyebrow furrows as she scrolls, "teaching Guitar Level 1 right now. But she's here!"

I grin. "Thank you."

I turn to leave but she jumps up again. "Congratulations by the way! And, um, welcome back."

I nod, grab the door handle and pull it open. "Thanks. Glad to be back."

I start down the hall towards the choir room, or what I think is the choir room. I never actually took choir, but Catra did, and I walked her to class enough I should be able to remember how to get there.

As I walk my pace slowly gets quicker and quicker, and the next thing I know I'm running down the hall. Catra's here. She's close. I'll get to see her soon. It's like I can feel her getting nearer in my

bones, and I swear I feel warmer. As I run, I pull off my coat and throw it over my arm.

Catra. Catra. Catra.

I almost run past the choir room doors, but I stop myself by grabbing the handle. I take a second to catch my breath and listen.

Someone's talking. The voice is muffled, but it's raspy and warm and my heart starts to ache.

I pull the door open slowly, trying not to make a sound, and enter the room.

"—one song. But you all have to promise to come to the festival. Promise?"

My heart throbs. *Catra.*

"Promise!" a chorus of voices cries out.

"Good!" I step further down the short hall that leads past the choir teacher's office into the main room. There's a strumming sound, and then a quiet humming.

Catra's tuning her guitar.

Something about that, about her being so close, doing something I've seen her do what feels like a hundred times, sends a bolt of lightning through my chest.

"Okay, this one's called 'Pilot Light'."

There're a few whoops and then Catra starts to play and everything goes still. I stop where I'm standing and close my eyes.

"In ten years I'll pass you on the street, and you'll be with someone prettier than me," Catra sings and I wrap my arms

around my torso. I have to hold myself together or I'm positive I will fall apart. *"And I'll have to come to terms with that, yeah I'll have to come to terms with that."*

It's a song I've never heard before, but I can already tell Catra wrote it. It feels like her.

"The way I see it you won't see me, on a snowy Sunday, grey and dreary. And she giggles when she steals your hat. She giggles when she steals your hat."

I take another step forward, feeling like I'm going to leap out of my skin if I don't get closer, if I don't get to see her.

"You poke her sides, and then you laugh."

I peer around the corner, and all I can see are the choir risers and a dozen or so kids sitting in hard plastic chairs with guitars zipped up in cases by their sides and music stands in front of them.

"You're as beautiful as you ever were, more now that you're so much happier. And for once I hate that I was right. Just this once I hate that I was right."

My eyes follow the sound and then, moving with the music, Catra walks into my line of sight. I stare at her back, the long brown hair she holds in a ponytail now cascading down it, and the way her jeans hug her legs. My mouth goes dry.

" *Your smiles are bright, your eyes are light, and I bet she burns all on her own."*

I can't help myself. I step around the corner, holding a hand to the brick wall and I watch her sway as she strums and sings and fills the room with music.

"I'm hollow and cold, locked just outside death's door. Plan to wait it all out on my bathroom floor. I'd give my all for hellfire, or any kind of feeling. Something left along with you love. Something fled while I was fleeing."

I lean against the wall, holding myself back just a bit, and close my eyes. I let the sound of Catra's voice fill my ears and sink into my chest.

"The missing of you is worse than every fight and aching heart. Being empty is its own kind of agony."

I open my eyes and frown. The words of the song finally start to reach me and something about them twists my stomach.

"In ten years I'll pass you on the street, and I'll have ruined all my dreams. But you won't even notice me. No, you won't even notice me.

"You'll be kissing her on the forehead and thanking God her heart's not red. You'll say 'You look good in my hat. So," I can hear the smirk in her voice, " *freaking,"* several students groan, *"cute in my hat.'"*

But I don't groan. I think about Catra ripping my hats off my head, beanies and baseball caps, and running away. I think about how cute she looked in them.

"Does she kiss you like she's dying? Does she scream and shout and rage?"

I take another step forward, moving out of the shadow of the hall.

"I'm hollow and cold, locked just outside death's door. Plan to wait it all out on my bathroom floor. I'd give my all for hellfire, or any kind of feeling. Something left along with you love – The thing that starts me singing."

My stomach twists again, and I clench my fist.

"No one likes seeing someone else, walking round in their old sweater. She looks so very warm and I know she wears you

better. I won't burn you down I swear. Can't even warm myself. 'Cuz when you left me here dear my pilot light went out."

I swallow.

"In ten years I'll pass you on the street, and you'll be with someone prettier than me. And I'll have to come to terms with that. Yeah I'll have to come to terms with – being hollow and cold, locked just outside death's door. I'll wait life right out on my bathroom floor. I'd give my all for hellfire, or any kind of feeling. Something left when you left me love. But I'll keep on singing."

I can hear the blood pounding in my ears.

" *I'll keep singing. Yeah I'm still singing. Just. Keep. Singing."*

And then with a final flourish, the song came to an end. I expected there to be a blanket of silence over the room, or maybe some applause. But finally I seem to notice the incredibly loud whispering.

I tear my eyes from Catra's back and glance at the risers filled with students. Every single one of them is staring at… me.

Shit.

"Seriously?" Catra breathes, and I can hear the mild annoyance in her voice. "You guys asked me to play and you couldn't even—?"

"Um… Miss Catra?" A young woman with cropped black hair raises her hand. "There's… someone's here."

I stiffen, and Catra cocks her head. "What do you—"

She turns around.

When our eyes meet it's like the world turns upside down. Her eyes are like gemstones, large and bright and I've missed them so much. I've missed the freckles that are sprinkled all over her cheeks, and the way her dark, wavy hair frames her face. I've missed her warm, tan skin and the scars and birthmarks I can see on her arms. I've missed just looking at her.

She's older now – I can see that in the faint lines around her mouth and eyes and the way her jaw has sharpened. She's the most beautiful thing I've ever seen.

"Hey, Catra."

She stands, frozen, with her mouth hanging open just a little and her hands gripping her guitar. I straighten and dig inside of myself to find the will to smile.

Because I'm happy. Or I should be. But that song made my heart ache, and Catra's looking at me like I'm… like I'm a stranger.

The bell rings, and that shakes Catra from her stupor.

"Class dismissed," she almost whispers, not taking her eyes off of me. But none of her students move. She takes a step back. "Seriously," her voice is hard and louder, "get out."

Someone coughs, but nothing happens.

"I said," she raises her voice, not quite to a yell, but enough to tense my shoulders, "get out!"

The students all start to stand up in a hurry, grabbing their things and scurrying towards the door. Several of them stare at me as they pass, and all of them are whispering.

"Is that Adora Grayskull?"

"Dude, her trophies are up all over the school."

"Isn't her picture in the cafeteria or something?"

I don’t pay them any attention. I just stare at Catra, at the curve of her mouth, the shape of her nose, and the way a loose curl wraps around her cheek.

Finally, after all of the students have left, she meets my gaze again and sighs.

“Hey, Adora.”

Chapter End Notes

So... do we still hate Adora?

Also, did you notice? It's not a continuity error. It's foreshadowing. Kind of. Past-shadowing? Eh, whatever. I hope you picked up on it.

The song Catra plays is a song I wrote. Or, at least I wrote words. I'm no composer. But I'm thinking of posting the full lyrics all in one place on tumblr. There's gonna be a few more original songs in this fic, and hopefully they don't suck!

I'm gonna try really hard to post next Friday. The only reason this wasn't done in time was some good ol' fashion discouragement. But I'm really excited about what's coming, so let's all cross our fingers.

Comment! Kudos! Subscribe! Love me dammit!

Calling All Grayskulls

Chapter Notes

Hey! Surprise! It's an early (or late depending on how you want to think about it...) update!

I would've possibly gotten done earlier and posted last Friday except I went to a con! I dressed up as Catra and went with my friend and young cousin, who dressed as Sea Hawk and Melog. It was great! And, of course, I bought almost every She-Ra print I could find!

This chapters a little shorter than some of the previous ones but I think it makes up for in feels what it lacks in length.

Anyway, enjoy!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra

"Anne came dancing home in the purple winter twilight across the snowy places." – L. M. Montgomery

March 13, 2008

Nothing in my life has ever been reliable, and I could prove that with one phone call to the right nursing home, or one page of my therapist's notes, but that doesn't matter. What matters is that at twelve years old, there was one thing I could actually count on – that my best friend, Adora Grayskull, would answer the phone when I called.

She and Adam got cellphones when they turned thirteen and Adora got really… Adora about it. She assigned everyone she knew their own personal ringtones and was always switching it on

from vibrate in between classes. She shoved it in her sports bra during practice and games and if she did happen to miss a call, she returned it immediately. Rain, shine, day, or night, Adora Grayskull was reachable.

So, that night, I called her.

"Hello?" Her voice was groggy, but relief burst in my chest when I heard it.

"Hey, Adora," I breathed, loosening my grip on the payphone's metal chord.

"Catra?" I heard her shift and yawn. "It's after midnight. What—"

"Can I spend the night at your place?"

"I…" There was a pause, and I felt like my heart was going to beat out of my chest. "It's a school night," she said, sounding nearly as confused as she did sorry. My throbbing heart sunk. "I don't know if my parents—"

Her words were drowned out by the sound of the engine in the car that was parked right behind me turning over. I looked back to glare at the shiny, lowriding, orange muscle car and the man driving it.

The man flipped on his lights, basically blinding me and I went to throw up my middle finger when Adora said, "Catra, where are you?"

I sighed, dropping my arm and turning back around to face the payphone. "The Speedway on Fawn." I closed my eyes and pinched the bridge of my nose. "So, can I—"

"Catra!" Adora was definitely awake now. "That's a mile from your house!" There was some rustling and Adora's voice hiked in pitch. "And it's pouring outside!"

I groaned. "No shit, Adora! Why do you think I'm calling you?"

There was a moment of silence and I immediately felt bad. Adora wasn't the reason I was standing, dripping wet, outside a gas station, using the last of the money I'd managed to scrounge up that month on an expensive ass payphone. Adora was the reason I had someone to call.

"Catra—"

"I'll leave in the morning before everyone wakes up, okay?" I grabbed the metal chord again and rubbed the grooves with my thumb. "I promise. I just—"

"Come in the back door," Adora said, cutting me off. Her voice was firm, and I could practically see the determined look on her face. "I'll make sure everyone's asleep."

Emotion ripped through my chest so violently that I almost sobbed. "Yeah," I gasped, "yeah, okay. Thanks."

"Be careful," she whispered, and I managed a smile.

"Always am."

Five minutes later, I was running up the stairs of Adora's back porch. The rain was coming down in sheets and I thought I'd never be dry again, but when the Grayskull's kitchen light came on and I saw Adora standing on the other side of the glass door, I felt warm.

Her hair was tangled and matted to the side of her head, and she was wearing those stupid unicorn pajamas that were way too short, but she was probably the most glorious thing I'd ever seen.

She slid the door open and held out her hand.

I took it. She pulled me inside so fast I almost tripped over the threshold.

“Adora!” I hissed, quietly. She steadied me, then brushed the wet hair out of my eyes and gripped my shoulders.

“Catra,” she scowled, “you better have an amazing reason for this.”

I scoffed and brushed her off my shoulders. “You sound like your mom.”

She crossed her arms and her scowl deepened. “That’s not a reason.”

I rolled my eyes. “Geez, give me a second to breathe.”

She huffed, then turned and grabbed a towel off the kitchen table. She shoved it into my hands. “Here.”

I took the towel eagerly and started to rub it over my face. I glanced at Adora and sighed. “My mom’s a bitch,” I said, leaning to my right and wrapping the towel around my hair. “That a good enough reason, Princess?”

“Catra!” Adora whispered, or at least she tried to.

I unzipped my jacket. “What?”

She just shook her head and turned me around, pulling my dripping wet jacket off my arms. “Come on,” she breathed, “I have some pajamas you can wear. I’ll hide your clothes in the laundry room.”

I nodded and shivered at the feeling of her hands grazing over my arms. “Thanks,” I murmured, trying to rub feeling back into my hands.

She stepped around and looked at me. Her brows were pinched, and she was frowning.

“What?”

She shook her head. “Nothing. Let’s go.”

She flicked off the light, and just as I was about to hiss about not being able to see, I felt her hand wrap around mine.

She pulled me silently through the kitchen and into the living room, her thumb rubbing my palm the entire way. I stared down at where I was pretty sure our hands were, trying to make out the shapes in the dark.

And then it wasn’t dark anymore and I ran into Adora’s back.

I lifted my head and bit back a snarl. “Hey! What—” Then I caught sight of Adam over Adora’s shoulder, standing with his finger on the light switch.

“Shit.”

He brushed his hair out of his eyes and looked from Adora, to me, then back again.

“Why is Catra here?” he asked, dropping his hand, and scratching his upper thigh through his tiger-striped boxer shorts.

Adora didn’t respond, just stared straight at her brother with her mouth open.

I squeezed her hand, and she glanced back at me. She searched my face like I could tell her what to say. But I didn’t have anything.

“She…” Adora trailed off, then swallowed and turned back to Adam with steel glinting in her eyes. “She can’t go home.”

Adam’s brow furrowed. “Why not?”

I could feel Adora’s eyes on me again, but I was looking back at the door and getting ready to run.

“Please, Adam,” Adora murmured, and she sounded so desperate, I would’ve let her do anything.

Adam was not me. “I’m getting mom.”

Then the asshole scurried back down the hall.

I ripped the towel from my hair and threw it at Adora. Then I pulled my jacket from her other hand.

“Wha—are you leaving?” she cried, voice louder now that she’d already been caught.

“Your mom’s gonna call my mom, idiot!” I shoved my arms through the sleeves. “I have to!”

“Catra,” Adora grabbed me by the shoulders, holding me firmly in place, “stop.”

“Adora—”

“Why can’t you go home?” She dropped her head so that her eyes were the same level as mine. She’d grown, like, four inches that year and now towered over me. Normally it just pissed me off, but just then, the way she was looking at me and the way she had to crouch to meet my eyes, made me feel itchy.

I tried to pull away from her, but she held on tight. “Catra, does your mom…” she swallowed, and tears shone in her eyes, “hurt you?”

I stiffened. “No.”

The corners of Adora’s eyes crinkled. She didn’t believe me.

“No!” I hissed. “Look, she doesn’t—” I shook my head, “she doesn’t hit me or anything! We’re just fighting and—” My hands started to shake and I felt like I was drowning. I wasn’t lying. Exactly. Shannon Weaver wasn’t the type to outright hit me. She was the type to hold my arms too tight and grip my jaw while she

told me what a disappointment I was. She was too smart to leave marks.

"It's fine. Really." I bit my lip. "She's just mad about my guitar."

Adora frowned. "What about it?"

My guitar had been a Christmas gift from the Grayskulls. It was used and had someone else's initials scratched into the back of the neck, (EKS, which I joked stood for Everyone Kan Suck-it, but Adora said was actually for Emily K. Schueler) but it was my most prized possession. And I had kept it from Shannon for almost three months.

"She never wanted me to have one," I explained, frustrated that Adora wouldn't just let me leave, "and she's pissed that I 'tricked you' into getting me one."

Adora's frown deepened. "But we gave you that guitar for Christmas…"

"Yeah, and?" I ripped myself out from under Adora's hands. "What Shannon doesn't know won't hurt her."

"But she does know!"

I groaned. "*Now!* Look," I shook my head and took a step back, "we got in a fight and she locked me in my room and took my pillow and blanket, kay?"

Adora's eyes were wide, and she was reaching for me again. "She locked you in your room?"

"Yes," I sighed, letting Adora put her hand on my shoulder again. I could hear footsteps, and I knew it was too late. "I snuck out the window…" I whispered, meeting Adora's gaze for one split second before my eyes drifted down to the figures walking down the hall.

"Fuck."

"Adora," Marlena Grayskull stood on the other side of the room in all her glory. She was tall, still taller than Adora, and her vivid red hair was collected on one shoulder in a long, thick braid. She was wearing white silk pajamas and a fluffy blue robe. "What's going on, dear?"

Adora turned to her mom, and I realized she was crying. She squared her shoulders and took a deep breath. "Catra needs to spend the night, Mom."

Marlena looked from Adora, to me, then back again. I tried not to flinch when she looked at me, but I'm pretty sure I failed.

"Why does she *need* to spend the night?"

Adora's hand wrapped around mine. "She—"

"I'm sorry, Mrs. Grayskull." I stepped forward, turning my hand in Adora's so that I could squeeze. "I was… leaving. Just…" I took a deep breath and closed my eyes, "please don't call my mom."

When I opened my eyes, Marlena was looking down at mine and Adora's hands, and there was a little wrinkle in between her eyebrows.

Then she glanced down at Adam and frowned. "Adam, get to bed."

Adam's mouth fell open. "But Mom—"

Marlena quirked an eyebrow. "Get to bed."

Adam deflated. Then he turned and started the long dredge down the hall to his room.

I clenched my jaw. We were in for it. Marlena was a decent woman; she wasn't going to rip Adora and I to pieces in front of Adam. But she would definitely rip us to pieces.

When we heard the door to Adam's room click shut, I pulled my hand from Adora's and stepped forward.

"Now," Marlena took a deep breath, "Adora—"

"Don't get mad at her," I said, standing a little taller. "She was just—"

"No!" Adora stepped in front of me, grabbing my hand and holding it tight. "Mom, you can't—"

"Catra can stay."

Adora and I froze. I stared hard at Marlena Grayskull, and she smiled at me. It was sad, but it was still a smile.

"Really?" Adora breathed, and she sounded so fucking relieved.

Marlena nodded. Then she looked at me, and her eyes were warm and sincere. "You're always welcome here, Catra. Just…" she sighed, "please, call so that Randor or I can come and get you."

My eyes were wide. I couldn't believe what I was hearing. "Really?" I choked out, and my eyes stung.

"Well, I don't want you walking across town in the middle of the night."

I bit my lip. "Okay. I'll… I'll call."

Then Marlena Grayskull, with all the grace and warmth a person could have, cocked her head and pursed her lips. "Promise?"

"I promise."

Ten minutes later, I was curled up against Adora in her twin-sized bed, wearing a pair of her sleep shorts and a large t-shirt. She had an arm thrown over me and a leg sticking out from under the covers.

“You’re too freaking warm,” she explained, but she just held me tighter.

“Goodnight, Princess,” I whispered, and a soft little smile took over her sleepy face.

“Goodnight, Catra.”

December 17, 2021

“Hey, Catra.”

You know I’d actually started to think my memories were exaggerating – the way they made her voice so gentle and sincere. People don’t talk like that. People lie and pretend and are careless. Adora wasn’t any different.

But her voice could convince you she is.

I stare into her gentle, sincere eyes, and my stomach rolls.

I have to leave. Now.

Without another thought, I drop my eyes to the floor and walk past her.

“Catra?”

I ignore her and step around the corner. I shove open my office door and pretend I don’t hear her say “What—Catra, where are—”

The door falls shut behind me and I walk around the desk. I grab my guitar case up off the floor and throw it on the desk. I’m moving quickly, but when I go to unzip the case, my hands are shaking too hard for me to grip the zipper.

And the office door is opening.

“Catra?”

In a burst of frustration, I yank the zipper down and throw the case open. I set my guitar down and ignore the way my heart seizes when my fingers trace over the letters scratched into the neck.

"Are—" Adora's voice changes and I almost look up. "Are you even gonna look at me?"

I zip up the case and grab my bag off the floor. I don't bother looking over my desk for anything that I might need over break – I'll break into the fucking school if I have to – I am not wasting another second here.

"Catra—"

Her voice sounds desperate now, and I have to look up. It's instinct. Dormant, sure, but what am I supposed to do against fifteen years of programming?

Fuck. She looks…

She looks terrified. Her eyes are wide and shiny, and her lip is pulled tight between her teeth. She has one hand fisted above her heart and the other gripping her elbow.

"Catra…?" she breathes, and my hand flies to my sternum. I clutch the charm that hangs around my neck and under my clothes. The sharp edges dig into my hand and the light pain is grounding.

Enough that I realize I can't just walk out without a word.

I straighten, slowly, hand still tight around the charm. Her mouth falls open a little and she lets out a shuddery breath.

"Catra…" she swallows, and I drop my hand, "Please. Say something."

I bite my bottom lip and run my eyes over her. She's here. She's really here. This isn't a nightmare, or a dream, or some simulation

Entrapta made up on her VR so I could practice handling "emotionally charged situations." Adora is here, in my office, and she looks like she's going to shatter.

"Adora…" her face literally brightens, like she's been jinxed and I'm the only one who can give her back her voice. It makes my stomach roll. "What are you doing here?"

Her brow furrows and she drops her arms. "What do you mean what am I doing here?" A nervous smile pulls at her mouth. "I—I said I'd come back."

My mouth pops open and for a second I just stare at her. I stare at the bright red and blue Thaymor High letterman that she's wearing.

"And when I'm done, I'm coming home. I promise."

There are so many feelings surging through my body, and I don't know how to deal with any of them. But they're pushing at my throat and I have two options – I could throw up, or I could laugh.

So, I laugh.

And I forget that Adora wasn't supposed to come back at all and that she's my favorite person. I forget the promises I made or that I used to care what promises were. And I forget that she's Adora, and that she can't possibly know better. I forget years of therapy and every good intention I've ever had, and I laugh.

"Yeah!" I cackle. "Eight years ago!"

She frowns, and it's so funny. She's so stupid. She's just—

"You—I thought—"

I shake my head and drag my hand through my hair. "Sorry, you're right. Eight and a quarter years ago."

Her frown deepens. “I—you don’t get a gold medal overnight…” She crosses her arms over her stomach. “I had to go pro first and —”

I laugh harder, falling back. “Unbelievable!”

“Catra!” she sounds angry. Good. I straighten and cover my mouth with my hand. “Wha—” she cuts herself off. “Are you… you’re crying.”

I blink and run a hand over my cheek. She’s right. I’m crying. *Shit.*

“Yeah, well, you’re an idiot.” I breathe out, steadying myself. I purse my lips and grab my guitar up. “Now, if you’ll excuse me.”

She doesn’t step out of my way, so I shove myself past her. She seems frozen, like the early winter chill has settled into her bones. I scoff. It’s not even below twenty outside.

There’s still a part of me, buried and hiding in the corner, that knows I’m being a bitch and that I should stop. But I’m not listening to that part right now.

I move out into the main choir room and turn for the door. I take a deep breath and push out into the hall.

“Catra—”

The sound of Adora’s voice is cut off by about two dozen students, all crowded around the door, staring with wide eyes. The moment I step into the hallway they all fall back a little, but that doesn’t keep my blood pressure down.

“What do you want?” I shout, and several students flee, but most of them stay.

Frosta, who’s standing across the hall with her arms folded, coughs. She gives a small nod. “They want her.”

And the door that just slammed behind me opens, and a hand falls light on my shoulder.

"Catra—"

I flinch and pull away. I want her to stop saying my name. Especially if she's going to say it like that.

"Catra, please." I make the mistake of meeting her eyes again, and they're so blue and full… "Talk to me. I don't understand why you're upset!"

I take a deep breath and look around at all the wide-eyed teenagers staring us down.

I grip my guitar tighter. "You left, Adora." Her mouth falls open. "I don't owe you an explanation."

And with that, I shove my way through the crowd of doe-eyed hormone machines and start down the hall.

I'm stupid enough to think I've shaken her.

"Catra!" she cries out, but the crowd of students has gotten louder, and I can hear them bombarding her with questions.

"Are you Adora Grayskull?"

"Do you have your gold medal with you?"

"Why are you in Thaymor?"

"Can I see it?"

"Did you really go to school here?"

"How do you know Miss Catra?"

How do you know Miss Catra?

"Catra!" Her voice gets louder. "Catra wait!"

I make it to the end of the hall and go to turn when a hand grabs me by the shoulder. This time it's firm and holds me back.

"You—" There's a quiver in her voice. I stare straight ahead, "You said…" She grips me tighter. "I thought you understood."

I stiffen and when I finally manage to respond, it's just a whisper. "Go home, Adora."

I yank my shoulder out from under her hand and keep walking.

The second I'm in my car I'm pulling my phone from my pocket.

Adam picks up after two rings.

"What's up, Catrina?"

I dig my fingernails into my thigh. "You're a fucking asshole!" I yell, my anger ripping out of me at the sound of his smile. "I am going to tear you to shreds with my bare hands, I swear to God —"

"Whoa!" Adam hisses, "Mean kitty."

"Mean kitty?" I shriek. "Stupid, *useless*, self-obsessed pretty boy! You could've warned me! I thought we were friends! But you don't think of anyone else, or their feelings or—" I stumble over my words, my own fucking tears shaking me apart.

"Wow…" he whistles. "Useless is new."

I stiffen and replay the words I just screamed at him in my head. "Oh… oh fuck, Adam. I'm… I'm sorry." My voice gets thick with more stupid tears. "I—she—she just showed up and I freaked out —"

"Wait, who showed up?"

I scoff. “Who do you think?” He doesn’t respond, and the silence gets heavy. “Adora,” I breathe, my voice shaking over her name. “Obviously.”

“What?” Adam sounds surprised, and it makes me grimace.

So I’m not the only one she doesn’t talk to anymore…

“She… she came to my last class,” I mutter. “Why didn’t you tell me she was coming home?”

Adam groans. “I didn’t know. Mara invited me over for dinner tomorrow, but I didn’t think anything of it…”

I take a deep breath. “You swear you didn’t know?”

“I swear, Catra. I haven’t talked to Adora in almost two weeks. Last I knew she…” he trails off.

I wait. “Last you knew, what?”

He sighs. “She was talking about coming home, but she had a wedding in Bright Moon or something. And you know how she is.”

I clench my jaw. “How is she?”

He scoffs. “She always has an excuse. I mean, when was the last time she was here, seven years ago?”

I bite my lip. “Eight.”

“Yeah. Exactly.”

I drop my head and brush my hair out of my eyes.

“I’m sorry, Cat,” Adam murmurs. “What did she say?”

I burrow further into my seat and watch the doors warily. Students are walking out into the parking lot, but only a few handfuls. The rest, I’m sure, are crowding the halls to get an eyeful of the hometown hero.

I drop my gaze to my lap. “It—nothing. She just… wanted to say hi.”

“Catra—”

“I gotta go,” I say, catching sight of a lab coat and long, thick purple hair. “I’ll talk to you later.”

Adam sighs. “Okay. Be cryptic. I’ll get it out of you eventually.”

“Uh-huh,” I murmur, watching Entrapta as she skips to the car. “Bye.”

“Bye.”

I hang up the phone and the passenger door is pulled open. Entrapta slides into her seat without a word, putting her bag at her feet and buckling herself in. She settles into her seat and glances at me out of the corner of her eye.

“Hey, Entrapta.” I swallow.

She smiles. “Hello, Catra!”

For a second we sit in silence, and I stare at the steering wheel. I don’t know what I’m waiting for, but it feels like I’m waiting.

Entrapta cocks her head. “Are you going to start the car?”

I nod and reach out to turn the key. The engine shakes to life and I wonder, for possibly the millionth time, why I don’t just buy a new car.

“I saw Adora,” Entrapta says, and my hand stills over the gear shift.

“Oh?”

“Yup!” she chirps, pulling her iPad out of her bag. “My prediction was wrong it seems.” She flips through something on the screen,

scrolling to what looks like unintelligible scribbles. “I said hello. I hope that’s okay.”

I sigh and slowly wrap my hand around the gear shift. “That’s fine, Entrapta. You can do whatever you want.”

She nods and sets the pad in her lap. “Are you okay?”

I roll my shoulders back and shift into drive. We pull out of the parking spot, and I force a smile. “I’m gonna be.”

She nods again and starts to twiddle her thumbs. “You have therapy today. That’s good. Right?”

I purse my lips. “Yeah, if I don’t cancel.”

She frowns. “Why would you cancel? That seems like it would be counterproductive.”

I sigh and pull in line behind a red Nissan Cube. “Yeah, well I’m not feeling super productive right now.”

Entrapta’s shoulders fall. “I’m sorry, I... I don’t know what else to say. This is… new for me.”

I smile a little. “Don’t worry about it. How was school today?”

“Oh! It was fantastic! Today my physics students were presenting their Rube Goldberg machines! Obviously, it would be difficult for them to transport the machines they assembled from their homes, so most of them had videos that they presented and—” Her hands, which had been flying around while she spoke, stilled. “Are you… sure you don’t want to talk about Adora?”

“I’m sure. Tell me about physics.”

“Great! So, the assignment was to accomplish a simple task with a Rube Goldberg Machine, which I’m sure you know is—”

I listen to Entrapta ramble the entire drive home, and I feel like I can breathe again.

Chapter End Notes

How we feeling? We okay? Do we need some water?

What Did I Miss?

Chapter Notes

I'm BACK BABY!
I am genuinely sorry for my disappearance there. As you may have known, I recently moved. My move was INCREDIBLY messy. The moving van didn't show up for well over a month, my house wasn't ready for almost as long, I was sleeping in a hammock for weeks, and I haven't been able to find a new therapist or get into a doctor since I arrived. I also went a month without taking my meds. BUT I got them refilled by some miracle and have been taking them again. So I've been feeling a lot more like myself. Which means I've been writing again.

Truth be told I wrote the first half of this chapter weeks ago, but I got COMPLETELY blocked. Luckily I have some AMAZING beta readers who read through what I had and gave me the encouragement I needed to finish. Truly you're all amazing.

I will admit that this particular chapter isn't incredibly thrilling, but I think it's worthwhile at least for the character sitings. So, without further ado…

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora

Love is friendship caught on fire - Ann Landers

November 8, 2004

I used to know Catra better than I knew anyone else on earth. Or, I thought I did. I guess I probably didn't know her at all…

And maybe I should've figured that out sooner.

We were nine, and our favorite movie was *Barbie as the Princess and the Pauper.* We watched it at least once a week, and it was a whole thing. We'd dress up, sing, and dance along while it played on the brand-new flatscreen in my basement. It wasn't the first movie we'd done that with, but it was the first movie we didn't have to take turns playing the girl.

Catra dug through the laundry hamper of dress-up clothes that we kept in the playroom and pulled out the frilly pink dress I always wore as Analise. She shoved it into my hands, and I frowned.

I don't know where the dress came from, it had just always been in the bin. It was probably some hand-me-down from a cousin that my mom thought was "too much" for regular clothes. Not that I ever wore dresses anyway. But right then I really hated how it felt in my hand.

"Why do I always have to be Analise?" I asked, clenching the tulle in my fist.

Catra turned around, holding the blue dress from the bin. It was a lot less frilly, just a flower print knit, and it was bigger too. It would drag on the floor when Catra wore it. I was only a little taller than her back then, but the pink dress had started to pinch my shoulders.

Catra looked confused. "Because. She's blonde, like you."

I grimaced and crossed my arms. "So? That's a dumb reason!"

Catra groaned. "Well, it's not the only reason!" She smirked a little. "You're also both nerds."

My jaw dropped. "I am not a nerd!"

She laughed. "Yeah, you are!"

I stuck out my lower lip. "How am I a nerd?"

Catra turned around, going to the toy drawer, probably looking for my crown. "You're, like, obsessed with school."

I scoffed. "I *like* school, but I'm not obsessed!"

"You do all your homework."

"You're supposed to, Catra!"

Catra shook her head and turned back around. "Whatever. You're just like Analise. You're blonde and rich and smart."

Something about how she said that rubbed me wrong. I didn't like being blonde, or Catra reminding me that my family had more money than hers. It made me feel bad. And I knew she wasn't being mean, not on purpose, but being smart was starting to feel like a bad thing.

"But she always wears pink," I sighed.

Catra's eyebrows furrowed. "So?"

I looked down at the ground, feeling small all of a sudden. But not small enough to fit in the pink dress. "The pink dress is too tight. And blue's… blue's my favorite."

I didn't look up right away and Catra just huffed. "Fine." She ripped the pink dress from my hands and shoved the blue one at me. "You can be Erica."

I looked at Catra's face and it was twisted with hurt. She was biting her lip and scowling. And then I realized what she said.

"No!" I frowned. "I… I wanna be Analise."

Catra lowered her arms. "But you just—"

And yeah, I'd just, but the moment she'd said it I realized I didn't want to be Erica. Catra was Erica. Catra wanted to be a singer and had brown hair, and Madame Carp was just like…

Catra was supposed to be Erica. And I was supposed to be Analise.

"Can I just…" I sighed. "Can I wear a different dress?"

Catra watched me for a second, then turned back to the dress-up bin. She dug around, then pulled out the newest dress – the shiny red one. She held it out to me and rolled her eyes. "Happy now, Princess?"

I took the dress from her hands and smiled. "Yeah."

After that, we went back to the TV room and started the movie. I was feeling good. The dress fit better, it was still kinda short, but Catra was giving the performance of a lifetime and it was so fun to play with her.

It was the final scene of the movie and Erica had just come back from traveling to marry King Dominic. Catra turned around, reaching for my hands to drag me into position for our double wedding. When I didn't move right away, instead staring at Catra's hand wrapped around mine, she stopped.

"What?"

I nodded at the screen. "We're gonna do that, right? Get married on the same day?"

Catra rolled her eyes and tugged me forward. "Duh. If you can find someone who will marry you."

My eyes got wide. I tightened my grip on Catra's hands and completely missed my cue. "What?" My voice was high and nervous. "What do you mean?"

Catra bit back a groan. "Adora, it was a joke—"

"What if no one ever wants to marry me?"

Catra looked at me, completely unimpressed. “Not everyone gets married.”

I dropped her hands. “But I *wanna* get married!”

Catra’s expression shifted, and she bit her lower lip. “Why?”

“Well…” I started fiddling with the skirts of my dress, rubbing the silky fabric between my fingers, “my dad says that the smartest thing he ever did was marry my mom ‘cause he gets to spend every day with his best friend.”

When I met Catra’s eyes again she was scowling. “But I’m your best friend.”

I furrowed my brow, confused as to why she looked so angry. Obviously, she was my best friend. But what my dad was talking about, that was a different kind of best friends.

“It’s different, Catra.” I didn’t know what exactly made it different, but I knew it was different. It had to be.

“So,” Catra crossed her arms, “you’re just gonna replace me with some dumb boy?”

“No!” The thought of replacing Catra made my stomach turn. Especially with a boy. “Besides, I don’t have to marry a boy!”

Now she looked confused. “What?”

“Kyle has two moms,” I explained, shrugging my shoulders.

Catra’s mouth popped open and just hung there for a second. “And they’re… married?”

I nodded.

“Huh… So then,” Catra lowered her arms, “we could get married.”

I furrowed my brow and frowned. “I guess. But you’re supposed to be in *love*, Catra.”

“I know that!” she scoffed.

“Well, then I can’t marry you!”

She looked… I don’t know how to explain how she looked. But the look is seared into my memory, and I knew I’d messed up.

Then she was glaring at me bitterly. “Fine. I didn’t wanna marry you anyway.”

She turned away from me and walked down the hall back toward the bathroom.

“Catra—” I trailed a step or two behind, and then she bolted. She ran to the bathroom and slammed the door behind her. I heard the click of the lock.

I hurried over to the door and tried to twist the handle. “Catra!” It wouldn’t budge. “Catra, what’s wrong?”

I was met with silence.

I groaned, collapsing against the door. “Catra, are you mad?”

I waited, listening with my ear pressed against the door. She said nothing, and after a second, I kinda lost it.

I slammed my fist against the door. “Catra! Talk to me!”

“Leave me alone!”

“What’s wrong?”

“Just go!” Her voice was loud. She was right on the other side of the door. “Find a new best friend!”

“Catra,” I pleaded, sinking to the floor, “come out! Please!” I bit my lip to hold back tears. “I’m sorry I made you mad!”

There were several seconds of total silence and I could hear my heartbeat in my ears. Then, practically whispering and choking on

tears, Catra said, "I just don't understand why you want a new best friend…"

I pressed my hand against the door and shook my head furiously. "I don't!"

"Well, you don't wanna marry me."

I sat with that for a second, trying to figure out how to explain it. But I didn't know how. Because when I really thought about it, it wasn't that I didn't want to marry Catra. I'd never thought of it before. But how was I supposed to marry Catra? She was my best friend. And yeah, my dad said that my mom was his best friend, but Catra and I were… we were different.

"Do you wanna marry me?" I murmured, trying to sort through all the thoughts in my head that were making my chest ache.

"No!" she cried, and for some reason that hurt. "I just…" then I heard muffled sobs on the other side of the door and I could feel my heartbeat in my fingertips.

"Catra," I shoved all my confusing thoughts and feelings aside, deciding then and there that it didn't matter what my dad said about marriage – nothing was as important as mine and Catra's friendship. Nothing. "We are always going to be best friends."

I listened hard as Catra's breathing evened out. "Promise?"

"I promise."

Slowly, Catra opened the door and I rushed to my feet. I wrapped her in a hug and buried my face in her hair.

She hugged me too, her fingernails digging into my back.

I forgot about that day for a long time, but eventually I realized I'd been wrong. Not about Catra and I being different – we were. We were the best friends that had ever existed. But I was wrong about not wanting to marry her.

And… I think I broke my promise.

December 17, 2021

The walk from the lunchroom back to my truck takes an eternity. I'm stopped over and over again by random students asking for a picture or autograph. I turn them all down, but try to do it politely, smiling and giving them some excuse about having somewhere to be.

But I don't have anywhere to be.

I'm replaying the last five minutes, trying to break down every word that came out of her mouth, the way her eyes would flash, and her jerky movements. It all feels like a nightmare.

I'm almost to the doors, having finally made it back to the front office when I hear my name in a voice so unique and familiar that my aching heart leaps.

"Adora! Hello!"

I turn my head and walk out of the front office, wearing a lab coat with her thick purple hair in pigtails, is Entrapta. *The* Entrapta. And she's smiling at me.

It takes everything I have not to tackle her with a hug.

"Entrapta!" I come to a stop. "Hi!"

She gives me a little wave but doesn't move closer. "What are you doing here?" she asks.

And just like that, the urge to hug her is gone.

"Adora…" I hear Catra's voice in my head, *"what are you doing here?"*

"Um…" I glance at the doors, "just…" And I don't know what to say.

"Did you come to see Catra?"

I grimace, and before I can respond, Entrapta's nodding. "That was a course of action I considered you taking. But I didn't give it much thought, it didn't seem congruent with the data."

I bite my lip. "What data?" I whisper, but Entrapta doesn't hear me.

"Human behavior has always been harder for me to predict than I'd like, but I thought I was getting pretty good. This truly is a fascinating turn. I had been concerned my data was incomplete, but Catra was only so forthcoming. I'd love to discuss this in greater detail, but I have to go. My ride's probably waiting."

"Entrapta—"

"Bye, Adora!" She waves and walks right past me, muttering about how the hallway is more crowded than usual, and I just stare at my reflection in the office window glass.

"I'm—I'm sorry, Adora." Catra's voice is clear and trembling in my memory. *"For everything."*

I thought I knew what she meant back then, clutching my phone to my ear, sitting in that empty, cold apartment.

I probably should've figured out sooner that I was wrong.

The drive to my parents' house is almost twenty minutes in the afterschool traffic, but I don't turn the radio on. It's already too loud – memories cutting themselves into pieces and playing over and over again, past and present trying to talk over each other. I missed something, somewhere, and now my brain is digging through everything trying to find it.

By the time I pull into the driveway, I'm drying tears.

I drag myself out of my truck, gripping the door so I don't slip on the driveway that hasn't been shoveled. I'm guessing that's gonna be my job. I wonder for a second if Mara ever invested in a snowblower when I hear my name shouted from the front porch.

I turn to see Razz, and my broken heart swells. She's wearing a thick pink sweater dress, thicker coke bottle glasses, and has about ten rings on each hand. She's waving at me, jumping up and down, and beaming.

"Oh, Adora, dearie," she cries, yelling back into the house, "come quick! Mara's home!"

I laugh, throwing the door of my truck closed, and jog, carefully, to the porch. "Grandma, I'm Adora."

She throws her hand. "Yes, that's what I said." Then she reaches out, wrapping me in a hug. "Welcome home."

Her grip is tight, especially for arms as frail as hers. I don't realize I'm on the verge of tears until I look down and realize I can't see her because she's blurry. But the hug is healing. For the first time in an hour, I feel like I can breathe.

Razz tsks, pulling back and pinching the side of my stomach. "Dearie, you are too thin! What have they been feeding you in Bright Moon?"

I chuckle and smooth down my shirt. "Well, I'm an adult, so I feed myself—"

"No wonder! You can't cook," she says, grabbing the end of my coat. "You must be hungry. Come in, come in! Grandma Razz has brownies in the oven."

I roll my eyes but follow her inside. She doesn't let go of my coat and it's so much like being a teenager again. She used to drag Adam and me around like this all the time. I expect the reminder

to hurt. But it doesn't. Neither do the couches that never got replaced or the pictures on the walls. They all feel… good. They feel like coming home.

We make our way to the kitchen and find Mara standing in front of the oven with a pan of brownies in her hands. She sets them down and picks up a toothpick. She must hear us coming because she glances back, and a smile lights up her face when she sees me.

"Adora! Hey! Was wondering when you were gonna finally get here, kid."

She sticks the toothpick in the brownies, then gives it a quick inspection. I scoff, and Razz drops my coat. "I'm not even late."

"True," Mara says, tossing the toothpick into the trash, "but you're usually early."

I bite my lip and try not to think about my little detour. "Yeah, well, a cross-county drive in December? I hit some snow."

She scoffs. "In that truck of yours? I highly doubt that would give you any trouble."

I cock my head. "Um, hauling a U-Haul?"

"Bah!" Razz waves her hands in the air and Mara holds back a laugh. "She's here now! That is what is important."

Mara rolls her eyes but smiles. "I'm happy to see you, kid. And happy to have you back."

I return her smile. "Thanks. I'm… happy to be home."

She must notice my hesitation and she cocks an eyebrow, but I turn my attention to Razz. "So how long do I have to wait for these brownies?"

"Twenty minutes," she says, "just enough time for you to shovel the driveway!"

Twenty minutes and one shoveled driveway later, I'm sitting at the small kitchen table with Razz and Mara, eating brownies. I've already had two and I'm pretty sure I'm going to get cut off soon. But when I reached for my third Razz didn't say anything.

"So," Mara eyes me, suspicious, "when was the last time you talked to your brother?"

I stiffen. "Um… a few weeks ago." I force a smile. "Why?"

"Well, strangest thing," Mara takes a sip of her milk, "he called just before you got here and asked me if you were moving back home."

I shove the entire third brownie in my mouth.

It wasn't that I *intended* not to tell Adam about my plan to move home. Really, I meant to tell him. Eventually. I just planned on telling him after it was too late for him to stop me. Because he would've tried to stop me.

Adam had spent years trying to get out of Thaymor. And he'd gotten close – he'd made it to Elberon, but despite being home to a major university, it was still just another small town in his mind. He would've done anything to go to Bright Moon like I had, and he wouldn't have looked back.

"I forgot," I say, my voice muffled by brownie, and Mara rolls her eyes.

"He's coming over tomorrow, you can explain yourself then. I figured he can help unload the U-Haul. Though you'll probably have to bribe him with pizza."

I nod. “Glimmer and Bow are getting in tomorrow morning. We can make a whole day out of it! And yeah, I’ll get pizza. It’s the least I can do.” I sigh, meeting Mara’s eyes. “And I’ll call Adam. Tonight.”

Mara reaches out and covers my hand. “Thank you.”

After all that, Razz starts to ask me about my friends from Bright Moon who are coming to visit and I try to explain Glimmer and Bow as simply as possible. She says they sound like “a lot” and I tell her she’s right.

“Cyra’s a lot as well I suppose, but such a dear. Oh, we must call her Mara. It’s been too long.”

My heart shatters and I grip the edge of the table.

“Mara,” I breathe through my teeth, “you have a new girlfriend, right?”

“Oh! Yes,” Razz narrows her eyes, “she’s mean…”

“Mom!” Mara protests and I can’t help but smile a little. Mara rolls her eyes and leans forward on the table. “Actually, you, um… you know her already, Adora.”

I cock my head. “I do?”

“Yes…” She sighs and rubs her forehead. “Her name’s Hope and she’s a counselor…”

It takes me a second, it’s been about eight years, but once it clicks, my jaw is falling to the floor. “Oh my god! Mara!”

So, Mara starts to explain how she ended up dating my adolescent grief counselor. And Razz chimes in multiple times to express her disapproval.

We sit at the kitchen table for hours, talking about this and that, Razz’s Bunko friends, Adam’s impending engagement to his

girlfriend Teela, and what career opportunities lay before me now that I've quit volleyball. But Razz doesn't bring up Catra again, thankfully, and eventually, she decides to go to bed.

I should've known Mara wasn't going to leave it alone.

"So," Mara taps the table, not meeting my eye like she would do when she had a question she knew was going to make me uncomfortable, "did you go see Catra today?"

I take a deep breath and drop my head to the table. "How the hell do you do that?"

"Eh, it's a gift." Her tapping stops and turns to quiet scratching. "What happened, kid?"

I take a deep breath. I don't want to go back to those moments, to the way I felt when I lived out my very worst nightmare. Because that's what it was – my worst nightmare. There were days I doubted, days I would let myself be consumed by fear, and on those days, I'd come home to a Catra who hated me, a Catra who wanted nothing to do with me. It was my worst-case scenario. And now I was living it.

Still, I lift my head. I can feel tears burning my eyes. "She wouldn't even look at me at first. I thought… I'm so confused, Mara. I thought we had a deal, a *plan*, but she was so mad! She didn't want to see me at all. And then she kept… throwing it in my face!" I wipe the tears that have started running down my cheeks. "I don't know what she—it doesn't make sense! I thought she was waiting for me…"

Mara frowns and reaches across the table, taking my hand in hers. "You thought she was going to wait eight years?"

"I did!" I scowl. My heart drops in my chest. "I thought…"

… she wanted me.

Mara squeezes my hand. “Hey, it’s gonna be okay. Right? You had a plan. And maybe it didn’t work out the way you thought it would, but that doesn’t mean it’s totally lost.” She smiles. “Just don’t give up on her. Catra…” she sighs, and her eyes drop to the grain of the table, “she’s been through a lot since you left. But if there’s anyone who can get her to open back up,” Mara meets my eyes again and hers are steady and sure, “it’s you, kid.”

I manage a smile and try to let myself believe that.

Chapter End Notes

Thank you for reading! If you liked it comment! Kudos! Maybe even subscribe!

Next chapter things are gonna get… intense. And I’ve already written 3/4 of the chapter! So it should be up soon!

Have a great day! Eat turkey and remember that colonialism is terrible!

The Family We Shared

Chapter Notes

So if you've never watched a single Barbie movie... you're going to miss out on some of the emotional weight of this chapter. But that's okay. Because there is other stuff that will be coming for you, I promise.

The candy windows that they talk about having in Thaymor are a real thing that they did in the city I grew up in every Christmas. They were dope as hell and one of my earliest memories was staring through the glass at a five foot tall nutcracker made completely out of hard candy. I honest to god thought it was a fever dream until I asked my mom about it a few years ago. ('Cuz the mall that they did it at originally closed but they started it up again at the new mall they built in the same place and I was like "wait a second…") Anyway, look up pictures of the ZCMI candy windows, they're kinda magical.

Really this Yule festival is just me picking and choosing all my favorite winter festivities and throwing them together. Because why the hell not?

I can't think of anything else I need to say… so have at it!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra

"Your absence has gone through me Like thread through a needle. Everything I do is stitched with its color." – W. S. Merwin

April 20, 2012

It was kinda glaringly obvious that Marlena and Randor always wanted to be "cool" parents, and they actually weren't terrible at it. Which meant all of their rules were like, "Of course you can use the car Friday, but you have to pick your sister up from her volleyball game this week," and "Yes, Catra can spend the night, but you have to finish cleaning the basement before she comes over." Overall, doable.

Nothing like Shannon Weaver.

"Why would Marlena Grayskull want you to darken her doorstep this weekend? And what on earth makes you think you deserve to go?"

It took some negotiating, and the frequent reminders that I would be out of her hair for an entire Friday and most of a Saturday before she gave in. But she did eventually give in.

Which is why I was walking with Adora off the bus that had just brought us home from the Regional Volleyball Championship game. A game that the Thaymor Billy Goats had won in an embarrassing landslide. I nudged Adora's shoulder. "So, did the mighty She-Ra manage to clean the basement before absolutely dominating Elberon in tonight's game?"

She rolled her eyes. "I mean, I wouldn't say… dominate. I just, I did my part. The whole team did—"

"Your dad was screaming 'that's my freakin' daughter!' the entire game. And starting 'She-Ra' chants. That the entire crowd joined in on. He basically did my squad's job all night."

Adora's smile grew from bashful to proud. "Okay yeah, I guess I did pretty good. But!" She straightened, "I did clean the basement." She beamed, like that was more impressive. "You packed your stuff, right?"

I smacked my duffle bag that hung over my shoulder. "Obviously." I looked back at the parking lot, scanning it for the car she and

Adam had gotten for their 17th birthday. "Now where's—"

"Adorka! Catrina!" I sighed, my eyes falling on a mop of disheveled blonde hair. Adam was leaning against a champagne-colored car, the make and model of which I never bothered to learn, with his arms crossed, beaming. "Your chariot," he stepped to the side, extending his arms, "awaits."

Adora took two or three long steps up to his side and punched him hard in the arm. I snickered and Adam yelped. "Ow! What was that for?"

"Adorka? Seriously?" she seethed, yanking open the back door, holding it open for me.

I slid into the back seat, watching, amused, as the two of them bickered.

"Oh, come on. Nobody heard! Besides, I'm your brother, if I can't take those kinda shots, you're gonna get a big head. Especially after a game like that."

Adora blinked. "You came?"

He scoffed and rounded to the front of the car. "Duh. I'm not an asshole, 'Dor."

It seemed Adora didn't have anything to say to that. So she opened the passenger seat, threw her bag on the floor, and slammed the door shut. Then she climbed in the back, next to me.

I never took it for granted that Adora sat next to me when Adam would drive. She could've easily sat up front. I knew that. She knew that. But she sat with me. I don't know why she did. Maybe she knew she would've felt bad leaving me all alone. But I liked to believe she just wanted to sit with me. It wasn't likely; Adora did so few things because she wanted to, but I chose to believe this was one of them.

I forced a yawn, choosing to pretend I was tired so I could rest my head on Adora's shoulder. She didn't say anything, then after a minute, she wrapped her arm around my waist. I was the farthest thing from tired then.

Adam asked Adora something about some girl on the team – Teela, I think – and I let myself get used to the feeling of Adora's volleyball jacket underneath my cheek and her hand on my waist. I wondered if Marlena and Randor would pick up pizza on their way home from the game, and if they would get barbecue chicken. I let myself enjoy the quiet moment where everything was right and good.

And then it shattered.

"Catra." Adam's voice was hard, serious, and I lifted my head and opened my eyes. I met his gaze in the rear-view mirror for just a second before I noticed the flashing blue and red lights on his face. "Get down. Now."

I didn't question him. I dropped to the floor.

"Adam," Adora's voice was tight, "what are they doing here?"

Adam pulled the car to a stop in front of the house, and I watched him from the floor. His jaw was tight. "I don't know."

Adora reached down, searching for me, and finally putting a hand on my head. I looked up at her face, but she was watching out the window. Her face was as hard-set as Adam's. I'd never seen her look like that – like she was going to tear the world to shreds. "Do you think Shannon called them?"

I looked back and forth between the twins and they shared a look. No one hated my mother quite like they did.

"I—I don't know… I don't think so! She knows I was at the game, and she knows I was staying over! She's a bitch but unless she got stupid drunk—"

“I’m going out there,” Adam cut me off, and his voice was stern. He was doing that thing, that older brother thing. It didn’t matter that he was only eight minutes older – he was going to protect his sister.

And, I guess, me.

“Adora, Catra, stay in the car. I’ll come back for you. Don’t come out otherwise.”

“Adam,” Adora swallowed, “is that—”

“Please, Adora.”

Adora bit her lip, but she nodded.

And then Adam opened the door. The police sirens weren’t on, but the late spring chill filled the car in a much more ominous way. I watched Adora’s face as she watched him. I didn’t know what was happening, and I wasn’t about to ask her to narrate, but based on where she was looking I guessed the cops were near the door.

I wondered if Marlena and Randor were out there…

“Hey, Adora?”

She didn’t look back at me. “Yeah?”

“Is your mom’s car here?”

She furrowed her brow and glanced at the driveway. “No—” then she looked back to where she’d been staring before, and her eyes went wide. “Adam!”

She threw open the car door and ran towards the house.

Luckily, I guess, she threw the door shut behind her. And I couldn’t handle not knowing anymore.

I crawled across the floor of the backseat, reaching up and grabbing the armrest of the passenger side backdoor of the

world's junkiest car, and lifted my head just high enough to see Adora run the final feet to reach her brother, who was sitting with his knees pulled to his chest on the cement walkway a few feet from his front porch.

"What the—"

"Adam?" Adora cried, loud enough I could hear her through the glass. She put her hand on his shoulder and turned to the cop nearest them, throwing her finger in his face. "What did you do to him?" she shouted.

The cop didn't even wince. Instead, he slowly reached out and put a hand on Adora's shoulder. I reached for the handle. And then he said something, something that ruined everything.

Adora's eyes went wide, and she crumpled. Her legs gave out beneath her, and she fell to her knees.

And I was running.

I was on her in seconds. I had my arms wrapped around her and was curling her into my body. I tucked her head into my neck and ran my hand up and down her back. For a second, she was frozen. Stiff and lifeless like she was dead. I threaded my hands through her hair and ducked my head to press a kiss to her cheek.

"Adora," I breathed, "Adora, please. Talk to me, honey. What's wrong? I need you to say something…"

Slowly, she grabbed at the top of my uniform, her fingers tugging the thick fabric. "Catra…" her voice cracked on my name, but she said it, and my heart, which had stopped, picked up again.

"Yes, Adora, I'm here. I'm here and I'm not going anywhere."

And then she shattered.

She started sobbing, choking on them, and barely getting a breath in between. Her grip on me tightened and she buried her face in my neck. Tears streaked down her face and wet my skin.

I lifted my head and stared down the cop who'd spoken to her. "What did you say to her?" I yelled, fury filling my body. How dare he do this to my Adora! How dare he *hurt* her!

Then I felt a hand on my back, and I looked to find Adam. His other hand joined mine on Adora's back, stroking, providing comfort, and there were tears in his own eyes. He bit his lip and met my gaze. "Mom and Dad got in an accident," he whispered, and my breath caught in my throat.

No. No, no, no, no, no.

"They're…" his face crumpled, and he leaned into his sister, pressing his head into her neck. "They're gone."

I swallowed, trying to fight the tears that threatened to break from my own eyes. It wasn't my turn to cry. Marlena and Randor weren't my parents. They weren't mine to mourn.

But Marlena and Randor were the closest thing to parents I would ever have. Good parents anyway. They paid for my cheerleading and let me have guitar recitals in their living room. They fed me good meals and bought me birthday presents. They… loved me. And fuck, I couldn't fathom living without them.

So I cried. I cried and held Adora and Adam as they cried on the sidewalk leading up to the Grayskull's front porch until our knees were sore.

Eventually, I managed to get us all inside. I called Duncan, Adam's best friend, and asked him to come over. He got there in twenty minutes. Next, I called Mara and Razz. The police volunteered to notify them, but I thought it would be a little better coming from me. When I actually got Mara on the phone, I don't know why I

thought it would be better for *me* to tell her that her older brother died, but I wasn't about to make Adora or Adam do it.

She took it as well as can be expected, I guess. She decided she would tell Razz in the morning and promised that they'd come by about midday and that they'd figure out what to do then. She also promised me that they wouldn't uproot Adam and Adora. She said they were so close to the end of high school; she didn't want to make them move. I basically started sobbing in relief when she said that. I hadn't even realized I'd been thinking about it, but, apparently, I'd been terrified.

After all of that was done, an officer said that he would spend the night to look after us. He said he'd just sit in the front room all night, and that if we needed anything, he'd be there. I didn't feel the least bit comforted by that, but I wasn't about to fight with a cop.

So, I took Adora's hand, pulled her off the couch where she'd been sitting while I'd made my phone calls, and took her to her bedroom.

I realized that I'd left my bag in the car with my pajamas but when I went to grab it, she stopped me.

"Please don't—don't leave. Just, wear some of mine?"

I bit my lip and nodded. She dug through her drawers and found me a large t-shirt and a pair of shorts that were probably too tight on her. Then she turned back to her drawers and pulled out another pair of pajamas. I recognized them immediately. It was her favorite pair of sweatpants, and a large sweatshirt that she'd gotten from volleyball the year before that said SHE-RA in big block letters along the back.

Her mom had gotten her the pants. And her dad had insisted that she put her nickname on the sweatshirt instead of Grayskull.

Her tears started to run again, and I reached out and put my hand on her arm.

“Can…” she took a shuddery breath. “Can you help me?”

My heart leapt into my throat, but I nodded anyway. While I unzipped Adora’s jacket and pulled her uniform off over her head, I reminded myself that right now was not the time to sexualize my best friend.

Not that there was ever a time for that…

“Do you wanna keep your sports bra on?” I asked, turning around and reaching into the drawer I knew held the tank tops she wore as undershirts.

She shook her head and I gave a quick nod. “Okay, turn around.”

She furrowed her brow but did as I asked. When she was facing away I lifted her bra up over her shoulders and head. I threw it on the floor with the rest of her discarded clothes and then quickly tugged the tank top down over her arms and chest.

She giggled, like actually giggled, and my hands stilled on her waist where I was smoothing the fabric.

“You’ve seen my boobs before, Catra.”

“From a distance!” I snap back, and I can feel the warmth in my cheeks. “Now do you want my help or not?”

She sobered immediately. “Yes, please.”

Using my hold on her hips, I turned her around, causing her to giggle again. “Okay.”

We pulled her sweatshirt on, took off her pants, and got her into her sweatpants. Then I pulled back the covers and let her climb into the bed.

She immediately turned over to look at me, waiting.

“What about you?” she whispered, and I rolled my eyes.

“I have to get changed, Princess.”

She nodded, clasping her hands and tucking them under her pillow. She watched me attentively as I pulled off my skirt and switched them for her shorts and traded my top for her large t-shirt. When I finally pulled the pom-pom from my hair and let it down, I met her gaze to find her biting her lip.

I tried not to let my imagination get away with me.

I lifted the covers and climbed into the bed beside her. After a moment, I reached behind her head and tugged the hair tie out of her ponytail.

“You’re gonna be bald by the time you’re forty if you keep sleeping in your ponytail. And like women aren’t supposed to go bald…” I muttered, throwing the hair tie on the nightstand. When I turned back, Adora’s eyes were brimming with tears.

“Oh,” I breathed, but I reacted instantly. I reached out and pulled her to me. I tucked her into my chest and started to stroke my hand through her hair. “Baby, hey, it’s okay. I’m here. I’m here…”

Her tears picked up in intensity, quickly becoming sobs, and I did everything I could to console her, which let’s be honest, wasn’t much. I’m not the comforting type. But I rubbed her back and kept whispering to her that I was there and that it was okay to cry but that she was gonna be okay and other stupid sweet nothings that I will probably forever be ashamed of.

After several minutes, she was breathing regularly again and she had wrapped her arms more gently around me. “Catra?” she breathed.

“Yeah?” I murmured, feeling closer to sleep than I would’ve thought I could.

“Can you… can you sing for me?” She sounded so embarrassed to even be asking… I was almost embarrassed to give it to her.

But I would. Of course, I would.

“Sure. Any requests?”

She shook her head, and I sighed. Because I could only think of one song.

“And you’re always free to begin again, and you’re always free to believe. When you find the place where your heart belongs, you’ll never leave…”

Adora laughed quietly, and I was still thrown to hear it. Was she even supposed to be able to laugh right now? Then she started singing with me, a harsh little whisper, but still singing. And fuck, it made me smile.

“You and I will always be, celebrating life together. I know I have found a friend forever more. Love is like a melody, one that I will always treasure. Courage is the key that opens every door…”

We kept singing the song, and we sang it again and again until Adora eventually drifted off to sleep.

December 20, 2021

Scorpia and Perfuma should be here any minute, and I’m trying not to do that thing where I stare out the window and wait for their car to pull up, but it’s either that or stare at my phone and think about the text messages I haven’t received. Really, driveway-watching is the lesser of two evils.

But it’s definitely still an evil.

Entrapta walks in, a screwdriver and something mechanical to tinker with in her hand. She glances up for all of a second. “Are you going to the festival?”

“Kinda have to.” I drop the blinds I hadn’t realized I was holding and shrug. “I am performing.”

“Oh,” her brow furrows. She looks down between her legs as Melog saunters into the room. They leap onto the couch, moving towards me. “Do you…” Entrapta continues, “want me to come?”

I smile at her and shake my head. Melog buts their head into my arm and I lift my hand to scratch their head. “Don’t worry about it. The music’s going to be really loud. But I’ll take pictures of the candy windows for you, ‘kay?”

She beams at me. “Okay! Thanks!” She turns to walk away then stops. “I… I do plan on going to the New Year’s Gala with you. I just… I need time to prepare for—"

I nod. “I know, Entrapta. Don’t stress about it. If you’re really that worried, I’ll have Scorpia record my performance on her phone so you can watch it.” Then, without thinking, I pull my phone from my coat pocket.

“Great!” Entrapta cries, and I stare at the screen, at the utter lack of notifications, and curse under my breath.

“Are you… expecting a call?”

I lift my head at Entrapta’s question and my stomach flips.

“No!” I almost shout, causing Melog to literally run away from my side, and then I wince. “I mean, no more so than usual. I just—I kinda thought more people would wanna talk to me about the Yule festival. It’s a big deal in this town. And me performing at the opening ceremonies? I mean, that’s—”

“Were you expecting Adora to call?”

All of a sudden, I feel the urge to throw Entrapta in front of a bus.

“No, Entrapta. And even if she had, I wouldn’t have answered.”

She purses her lips. “Hmm… interesting. I am surprised she didn’t call – she seemed likely to on Friday. But then again, I did not predict her returning to Thaymor at all. Obviously, there is something here I’m not seeing. I’m going to need you to recount exactly what happened when—”

“Entrapta,” my voice is low, a warning, “I am not—”

Then my phone buzzes and my heart leaps in my throat.

I look down to text.

🌺 Flower Power 🌺 - We’re here!

I glance out the window to see Scorpia’s shiny dark gray Subaru and breathe a sigh of what I’m gonna say is relief.

“Sorry to cut this short, Entrapta, but my ride’s here. Gotta go.” I slide past here and nearly run out the door without looking back.

“Oooh!” Scorpia coos, looking down at the map in her hand, “the next window is *Princess*-themed! And it’s just two stores down!”

I roll my eyes. “Yeah, Scorpia, I’ve lived in this town my whole life. I know what stores do the candy windows.”

Perfuma smiles and puts a hand on Scorpia’s arm. “Such a unique and lovely tradition.”

I had to give her that. I wasn’t sure where it started, but my entire life, the candy windows had been a Thaymor Yule Festival tradition. Every year, several of the stores downtown would participate in allowing local artists to make display pieces for their windows. The catch was these window displays were made

entirely out of candy. As the festivals went on, the displays got more elaborate, having to fit within the festival's theme. This year's theme was Storybook.

So far we'd seen a hot air balloon a la Around the World in 80 Days, a beanstalk sticking into clouds with giant's feet resting on top, and a heartbreaking rendering of Goodnight Moon.

Apparently, next was going to be Princess.

Which I guess counted as story book but it felt like a very limited view of the category.

As we walk up to the window, I'm looking through my phone at the photos I've taken for Entrapta, who really doesn't deserve them after the shit she was giving me earlier, but I'll be the better person. Then I hear Perfuma let out a little gasp and Scorpia literally says, "Wow!"

So I look up.

It's breathtaking. In the front left corner is a beautiful lake that pushes right up against the glass, and underneath the water you can see mermaids swimming. On top of the water, a large swan is taking flight, wings spread wide. Surrounding the lake is a thick wood and hidden in that wood, you can see brightly colored fairies and a beautiful unicorn poking their head out from behind the trees. In the back corner, towering high above everything, is Rapunzel's tower, with a long strand of beautiful blonde hair hanging down into the world below. And underneath the tower, digging into the dirt below is a little passageway leading to a ballroom with twelve pairs of colored shoes abandoned on the floor.

It's awful.

When I look at it, I just see every Barbie movie I ever watched with Adora. Rapunzel, Swan Lake, even the stupid Fairytopia Mermaid one. I remember laughing and pretending and playing with Barbies in fancy dresses.

And I feel sick.

"Let's go," I mutter, stepping away from the window and crossing my arms over my stomach.

Perfuma and Scorpia turn to look at me, and it says a lot about them as people that they're wearing completely different expressions. Perfuma looks mildly confused but mostly curious. Scorpia looks downright incredulous.

"But Wildcat! Don't you need a picture for—"

"I said let's go!"

Her expression falls and I start walking.

"Dear, I think something about the display upset her…" Perfuma murmurs, but still loud enough for me to hear.

"What? What could—"

"I don't know but we need to let her process that."

I take a deep breath and then let it out slowly. I come to a stop and hear them stop behind me. I'd kinda hoped they would keep walking so that I wouldn't have to turn around but I guess I can just… do that…

I turn on my heel and try to remember what my therapist told me. "*You can't expect others to understand why you're upset, or how to take care of you when you are. You have to tell them those things."*

"I'm…" I grit my teeth, there was a time in my life I swore I'd never say these words, but I find myself saying them all the time these days, "sorry. I shouldn't have reacted like that. Perfuma, you're right, the display upset me. It reminded me of some things from… growing up. And I needed to move on."

Perfuma smiles gently at me, but the look on Scorpia's face warns of an incoming hug.

I hold up my hand. "No hugs. I'm fine. I just want to move on to the next window."

Scorpia composes herself and nods. "Absolutely. Whatever you need, Wildcat. We are going to have a great night!"

I manage a small smile. "Great. Okay, well the next window is around the corner—"

I turn around and move to head right around the corner to the shoe repair shop that I know houses the next candy window. Instead, I run headfirst into a woman in the sparkliest jacket I've ever seen in my goddamn life.

"Hey!" I cry, nearly falling flat on my ass, "watch it!"

"Watch yourself!" she bites back and I take a second to look her over. Not only is she wearing a hot pink sparkly jacket, but her hair is pink, and she looks eerily familiar. The boy standing next to her, who's wearing a jacket with large brightly colored arrows pointing down in a rainbow, looks even more familiar. He's smiling, bright and awkward, and using a gloved hand to rub the side of his faded flat top.

"Sorry, she means sorry."

Sparkles sighs and crosses her arms. "Whatever…"

"Catra?"

I stiffen. *Fuck, fuck, fuck, fuck, fuck.*

I hoped to never hear my name in that voice again. Or I hoped to hear it days ago in a voicemail that I got to ignore until I was ready to face it. Or I hoped to hear it from the other side of my door while someone pounded on it begging me for just one

chance to talk to me and explain. Apparently I hoped for a lot of things, but this was not one of them.

Sparkles and Arrow Boy's eyes go wide. I bite my lip and look up over their heads. Sure enough, just behind them and to the right, sporting her dumb ponytail and a pair of bright blue earmuffs is Adora. She slips them off her head and smiles at me like she's never been happier to see someone in her life.

Then she shoots a glance behind me. "Hey, Scorpia! And… Scorpia's friend!"

"Hey, Adora!" Scorpia sounds cheery as hell, and I don't know how I feel about it. "I heard you were back in town. So great to see you. This is Perfuma! She teaches with me and Wildcat over at the high school. Elective social sciences mostly, stuff like psych and world religions, ya know?" Scorpia is beaming with pride. I don't have to take my eyes off Adora, who is not looking at me, thank god, I think, to know that. "And she's also kinda my girlfriend."

"There's no 'kinda' about it, sweetie." I can hear the smile in Perfuma's voice too. Everyone's just fucking smiling! "I am most certainly your girlfriend."

"That's awesome!" Adora says, and she sounds so… happy. I hate it. I hate that she can just stand here and be happy. I hate that I still hurt.

Why the *fuck* do I still hurt?

"This," Adora steps forward, up next to Arrow Boy, and gestures to him, "is Bow," then she points at Sparkles, "and Glimmer. Bow was my volleyball partner for the last several years and Glimmer's his wife."

Glimmer rolls her eyes. "I'm also your friend, Adora."

Adora smiles. "I mean, yeah, they're both also my friends."

Bow grins. “We’re the Best Friend Squad.”

I don’t realize that my entire body clenches until Perfuma puts a calming hand on my shoulder. Then I straighten, roll my shoulders back, and take a deep breath.

“Well, it’s been lovely, but we have about four more windows to see before the end of the night. So if you’ll excuse us…”

But no, Adora isn’t going to just let me go! “Actually,” she holds up a finger, “if I could talk—”

“Cyra, dearie!”

My heart falls into my stomach.

Razz bounds down the sidewalk, coming to stop right in front of me. She takes my hands in hers and pulls me down to look into her eyes. She pats my cheek and then gives it a slight pinch.

“Dearie, have you been eating? Ah! You and Mara! Too thin. But it is okay. It is Christmas. Time to fatten you up.” She claps my hands between hers and smiles. “Razz has been waiting for you, Cyra! I need someone to help me make a pie! But no one else will make pecan. Adora says it is gross and Randor is too busy with work. I need you. You love Madame Razz’s pecan pies, don’t you, dearie!”

I bite my lip, trying to hold back the sobs that are threatening to rip through my chest.

If this was any other Christmas, I would make a pecan pie with Razz. I’d make as many as she wanted, and I’d eat half of them. But I can’t this year. I can’t go over to the Grayskull’s on Christmas Eve or Christmas Day. I can’t go to any Yule Festival activities with them and I will be spending New Year’s Eve by myself.

Adora has taken the closest thing I’ve ever had to a family from me.

And she doesn't even know.

"Razz," I start, my voice shockingly level, "I don't think—"

"Hey, Cat!"

I look up, again, to see Mara coming up from around the corner. She's smiling and holding hands with a woman.

A bald woman, with a very serious expression, who looks…

Oh. My. Fucking. God.

"Hope?" I screech, dropping Razz's hands and rising to my full height.

I can tell I've rattled her a little because her eyes get just a touch bigger, but she composes herself infuriatingly quickly.

"Hello, Catra. How are you?"

I narrow my eyes, glancing between her and Mara. Mara looks confused. Then I look at Adora. Adora looks guilty.

Very guilty.

I turn back to Hope. Hope, my therapist. My therapist who knows my every single thought about Adora. My therapist who *apparently* personally knows Adora.

"How do you know Mara?"

Hope bites her lip. It's actually Adora who answers.

"Hope was my grief counselor, after… well, you know. She met Mara back then. But they didn't reconnect until recently, apparently. I'm…" she scrunches her nose. "I'm still getting used to it."

And everything gets so much worse than I could've possibly thought. Because she's known Adora the whole time. She's known

Adora the whole *fucking* time.

I swallow and roll my shoulders back. I brush my hand through my hair and force a smile. "Well, Hope, feel free to cancel my next appointment. I won't be needing your services any longer." I narrow my eyes and tighten my jaw. "And I know a lawyer. A good one."

I don't. I don't think I even know a fucking lawyer. But she doesn't need to know that.

Then I turn to the side of the group that had migrated to the street and wave my hand. "Excuse me, Sparkles, Arrow Boy, I have places to be."

They're kind enough to move and I walk through the group of people I kind of never want to see again and into the street.

"Where are you going, Wildcat?" Scorpia cries out.

"Literally anywhere else!" I shout back. "Don't follow me!"

"But…" I hear Razz's broken cry and it's enough to make me stumble, "what about the pie?"

And even though it's not the dramatic exit I crave, and I'm in the middle of a street downtown, I can't help but stop. Because it's Razz. So, I turn around, for a split second, and nearly scream, "Mara, help your mother make a pie for fuck's sake!"

Then I stomp off. And believe it or not, I *actually* think I'm not gonna be followed.

My mistake.

"Catra!" And it's that voice, the worst of all the voices. The voice that I haven't heard except in dreams in eight years.

I ignore it. I march down the street, and maybe I expect that she'll get the message. She doesn't of course. She just gets closer.

“Catra! Catra, wait!”

I feel her hand on my shoulder and I startle and pull away. “Don’t touch me!” I hiss.

The look on her face almost makes me feel bad. “I’m—I’m sorry,” she chokes out, “I didn’t mean to—”

I sigh. “Yeah, I know. Whatever.” I cross my arms. “What do you want, Adora?”

She tries to smile but it’s a lot more grimace-y. “Just… five minutes. Please? I’m… confused.”

I narrow my eyes. That’s been what haunted me all weekend, from the moment Adora showed up in my classroom. Truly it’s been what haunted me since I saw Adora win her gold. She said she was coming home. She said she’d come back. What on earth had Adora so convinced I was still expecting that?

“Fine, you have five minutes.”

Her smile shifts, from a grimace to something soft and sweet. Her hands clench in front of her like she wants to reach out for me. “Catra,” she breathes, like she loves the way my name sounds in her voice. “I miss you.”

It takes me a second to process that, but when I do, I cock my head. “That’s what you’re gonna waste your five minutes on? Bullshit?”

She scoffs. “What? Catra! I—why would you say that?”

My narrowed eyes shift into a scowl. “Because if you missed me, you would’ve come home on your breaks. You have four of them a year, you know,” I poke her in the chest, feeling bold, “one for every season. You would’ve called on my birthday. You would’ve kept your promise—”

She grabs my hand and when I look up into her eyes, they're angry. "Are you *kidding*? Catra, you were the one who said it was too hard. You were the one who didn't want to see me! You told me to stay away!"

I blink and for a second I'm replaying an eight-year-old conversation in my head. And with it everything clicks into place.

"—Don't see each other?"

Adora is the victim of four little words and finishing a sentence.

Or maybe I am.

Fuck, it would be funny if it weren't such a damn tragedy.

But now… now I guess I have to decide something. Am I going to tell Adora the truth? Am I going to tell the most beautiful, wonderful girl I've ever known that I gave up on her the moment she left me, or am I going to let her believe that eight years really was just too long and that somehow, she failed me?

Take a guess.

"What did you think was gonna happen, Adora?" I almost laugh. "Did you really think, after not talking to me for eight years, I was just gonna be here waiting for you? I mean, come on," I pull my hand out of her grip and roll my eyes, "am I supposed to believe golden girl Olympic medalist Adora Grayskull didn't fool around while she was gone?"

She bites her lower lip, and I can tell from the way she looks down and her cheeks burn that…

"Seriously?" I cackle, but inside my heart is on fire. I feel giddy. I feel adored.

I feel sick.

"I—I thought you loved me," she whispers.

I pull on everything. I pull on every ounce of hurt I've stockpiled over the years. The way it felt to watch her drive away. The shortest phone call in existence. A missed Thanksgiving. A trip to Salineas that never happened. The stickers I had to scrape off my dashboard. The songs I could barely sing. And now the family I couldn't even see.

She'd taken everything from me.

I thought she loved me too. But people who love you don't hurt you like that.

"Yeah," I breathe, fighting back tears, "so did I."

I ignore Hope's voice in the back of my head reminding me that people only know how to take care of you the way you tell them to, and that Adora had done *exactly* what I'd asked.

Chapter End Notes

What did you think?

I feel like you have thoughts. Do you have thoughts? Feel free to share them in the comments! I love to hear thoughts!

And yes Mara is Randor's sister. This choice was made because 1) Then Mara's last name is also Grayskull. And 2) Mara and Randor both have brown hair. Also naming your daughters Mara and Marlena feels like… a lot? Like naming your sons James and Jamison. Not that you can't just… you maybe shouldn't?

Anyway, that was a tangent. So, lemme know what you think. Not to sound like a YouTuber but kudos, comment, subscribe!

The Things I Lost

Chapter Notes

> Hello! And welcome back! This week is gonna be fun. This, I believe, is our longest Adora chapter so far. I will have a lot more to say in the endnotes so make sure to read those for some fun facts. Anyway, enjoy!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora

Nothing burns like the cold – George R. R. Martin

July 3, 2012

There were a lot of things that really sucked about your parents dying. But for me, other than the them being dead part, the worst was therapy. I *hated* my grief counselor. I hated that she wanted me to call her Hope and not Dr. Lightly. I hated that she spoke in a cold and flat monotone all the time. I hated that I had to spend an entire hour with her every Tuesday. And that particular Tuesday, I hated that I was there, in her waiting room, instead of with Catra.

Catra and I had gotten into a fight that morning when she dropped me off. We were talking about 4th of July plans when she said that Scorpia had invited her over to her house for a barbecue.

"*But—you always come over to our house!"*

"I didn't say I was going, Adora, god! I just said she invited me. Am I not allowed to be invited *to things anymore?"*

It only got worse from there.

By the time I got out of the car, Catra was going to Scorpia's for the 4th of July.

So, there I was, seething, with my arms crossed, in the most uncomfortable chair I'd ever been in, replaying every single second. Catra was just being a stubborn brat. She did that a lot. Any time anyone disagreed with her, she'd lash out. But she was always wrong. And especially this time. Yeah, because there was no way I was—

My thoughts came to a halt as Dr. Lightly—Hope called my name.

I followed her back to her room and took a seat on the couch opposite her wheely chair. I thought it was weird she sat in a wheely chair and I had a whole couch but I didn't know much about therapy and stuff. How was I supposed to know what was normal? She asked me a few questions – how I was feeling, how school was going, if I'd been sleeping okay, stuff like that. I answered them all with a simple "fine".

And I thought about Catra.

Dr.—Hope cocked her head to the side and gave me a puzzled look. "Something is bothering you."

I crossed my arms. "You got that, huh?"

She wasn't ruffled. My mom would've been ruffled. "I did ask you how you were feeling, and you said fine. If that was not the case, why did you not say so?"

I groaned, leaning my head onto the back of the couch. "Because it's… it's not relevant, okay?"

There was a pause. "How is it not relevant?"

I threw my arms to my sides and stared hard at the ceiling. "It has nothing to do with my parents, or grief, or any of the stuff we're here to talk about. I just—I got into a fight with a friend. So I'm not really in the mood for all this—" I waved my hands

around, "—stuff. I just want to go home, curl up, and mourn the friendship I probably just ruined because I couldn't keep my mouth shut, m'kay?"

Hope gave a very languid nod. "Mourning," she said, slowly, "is quite relevant to the 'stuff' we're here to talk about."

I almost cracked a smile.

"We can talk about your fight, Adora. We can talk about whatever you want."

I bit the inside of my lip. "What if I don't want to talk?"

"Then we can sit in silence. But that is for you to decide."

I nodded and took a deep breath.

And then I told her about my fight with Catra. I told her about how Catra said Scorpia was having a barbecue and she'd been invited. I told her that I thought for a second Catra was saying she was going to this barbecue and got upset. And then Catra got defensive. And I got accusatory. And then we both got mean.

"I said I thought she was asking for permission to bail on hanging at my place tomorrow and she got mad. Then she said even if she was gonna bail, she has other friends, and she doesn't have to follow me around everywhere I go." I sighed, guilt welling up in my chest.

I shook it off and pushed a loose strand of hair behind my ear. "But it's Scorpia! And Scorpia has a crush on Catra! And I told Catra that and she said, 'So? Lonnie had a crush on you!', which," I roll my eyes, "she didn't. And when I said that, Catra scoffed and went, 'Okay, and Huntara *doesn't* want to fuck your brains out.' She was being sarcastic, in case that—"

I bit my tongue, and I could feel my face heat up, from anger and embarrassment. "Oh," I looked back at Dr. Lightly and grimaced. "Sorry…"

Hope smiled, looking genuinely amused for the first time that I could remember. “You’re allowed to use whatever language you need to express yourself here, Adora. Although I ask that you avoid inappropriate slurs.”

“Won’t be a problem.” I gave a quick nod, then rung my hands together. “Should… I keep going or…?”

“Yes, do.”

“Anyway, she said that—that thing about Huntara, which is a total exaggeration by the way. Huntara just hit on me at a party this one time but, doesn’t matter. What does is that then Catra said it didn’t matter that Scorpia had a crush on her! Which is just—” I scoffed, “it obviously does! And I told her that! I told her she’s leading Scorpia on and that that’s wrong and she just didn’t care.”

Hope frowned. “She didn’t care?”

I huffed. “Okay, no, she just didn’t think she was. Leading her on, I mean. She said they were friends and Scorpia knew they were just friends. Apparently, she invited Entrapta to come over too, so it was just a friend hang, or whatever, but still! She’s spending all this time with her. And it’s going to make Scorpia think that Catra… ya know?”

Hope nodded. “Well, could Catra like Scorpia? Is that completely out of the realm of possibilities?”

My stomach dropped and my heart went quiet.

“Huh?”

Hope tapped her notepad with her pen. “Could she ever be interested in Scorpia?”

I decided - based on the not being able to feel my stomach or hear my heart thing - that this line of questioning wasn’t worth pursuing. “Maybe. I don’t know. But that’s not the point. The

point is, Catra is a stubborn brat, and someone is going to get hurt!"

Hope pursed her lips, almost like she was trying to hold back a smile and I remembered the other reason I hated therapy.

Therapists think they know *everything.*

After a second of tapping her pen, Dr. Lightly leaned forward and met my gaze. "Who could get hurt, Adora?"

I sighed. And this was all the evidence I needed to prove they had no idea what they were talking about. She hadn't even been listening.

"Scorpia, Catra—"

"Catra," she cut in, "would seem to be relatively safe in this scenario."

I arched an eyebrow. "Yeah, that's what you'd think. But if she hurts Scorpia at all, she'll feel bad. And she'll carry that around forever. Not as guilt though. Catra's too stubborn to feel guilty for long." I sighed, looking down at my hands and thinking of the scars on Catra's. "But she'll carry it anyway, as this, like, reminder that she's a bad person."

"But," Hope drew my gaze again, "she's not a bad person, is she?"

I shook my head and realized my eyes were blurry with tears. "No. She's the best person."

"Adora," Hope scooted her chair forward just a bit so that I could see her eyes clear enough to make out the brown from the black, "are you the one who is going to get hurt?"

And then the tears started to fall. "I just… I don't want her to replace me or…" my shoulders started to shake, "move on. I couldn't survive that too."

Hope reached onto her desk and grabbed a box of tissues. She set them gently on the couch beside me.

"Take your time," she said, and I took a tissue and nodded.

After a minute, my sobs had passed, and I'd soaked through three tissues. "Sorry," I whispered, tossing the last one in the garbage can.

"Don't apologize for crying in therapy, Adora." She cocked her head. "But, if you will, answer me this – why?"

I blinked. "Why what?"

"Why would you not survive it?"

I rolled my eyes. Wasn't it obvious? "Catra is everything to me. My family is really small, Dr. Lightly. Sorry," I shook my head, "Hope. And it's small for a good reason. But Catra has been there since the first day of first grade and I don't want to *ever* know what my life would be like without her in it. She is my best friend and I… I just want her around. Forever."

Dr. Lightly nodded, making that holding-back-a-smile face again. I thought about punching it off her face. "So that is why it bothers you that Scorpia might have feelings for Catra? You're afraid that if they entered into a relationship, your friendship with Catra would suffer?"

I scoffed, loudly. "Well, if they 'entered into a relationship' Catra and I couldn't, could we?"

Hope's eyes widened a bit and she let a little more of that smile slip out. "Am I correct in my understanding that you just said you want to be in a romantic relationship with Catra?"

"What?" I furrowed my brow. "I didn't…" But then I replayed my words in my head. And I replayed them again and again. And I swallowed, realizing that I meant them.

"Oh my god." It hit me like a volleyball right to the gut. It was so obvious. So *stupid* obvious. I was always staring at her, even when she wasn't talking. I thought she was the most beautiful girl in the world. I was always touching her, putting a hand on her shoulder, or wrapping my arm around her. I gave up the equestrian team for her. I let her call me *Princess.* I mean, god, I'd decided when I was eleven that I wanted her to be my first kiss. That wasn't a normal friend thing! And I hated Scorpia. No one hated Scorpia!

"I'm in love with Catra," I breathed, and no words had ever felt more right in my mouth.

Hope smirked, tapping her pen on her notebook once more. "Adora, would the same time next Tuesday be suitable? Or would you like a later appointment? I have an 11 o'clock available."

Adam was the one who picked me up from my appointment, not Catra. I'd be lying if I said it didn't break my heart a little.

"What'd you say to her anyway?" Adam asked me, pulling out onto the street. "She basically threw the keys at me when she got back."

I sighed. "Something stupid."

"Well, yeah." He scoffed. "I figured that."

I shot him a glare out of the corner of my eye and pulled out my phone. After about five minutes, I had a halfway decent text.

You were right. I was overreacting. I'm sorry if what I said was controlling or patronizing. You're allowed to do whatever you want, Catra. I understand why you don't want to come over tomorrow, and I'm not mad. I'll save you some pie. 💙

Right as Adam pulled into the driveway, I got a response.

Catra 😾 - Of course I'm coming over tomorrow, dummy. Like I'd trust you to save me pie.

My heart swelled, and I nearly danced to the front door.

I loved her so much.

December 20, 2021

"Are we seriously going to an outdoor concert?" Glimmer asks, rubbing her arms like she's freezing through her puffy coat. "In December!"

I sigh, willing myself to look up from the ground and answer her, when Bow does.

"It's one of the town's oldest traditions!" he beams. "It's in this bandshell at the park. There's an ice sculpture garden at the park too! And a lake where people go skating! So cool."

Bow has lived in Bright Moon his entire life. I don't think he's ever even seen snow before. So far, he's loving his Thaymor Yule.

Glimmer is *less* enthused.

"Okay, but why would they have a concert in the park? Isn't that like, bad for the instruments?"

"The stage is covered in space heaters," Mara says, and I try not to flinch at the sound of her voice. "The musicians are nice and toasty. Some of them even wear shorts."

Glimmer scowls. "Great."

"Oh, come on, Glimmer," Bow nudges her, still smiling. "There's only three acts this year, and they all sound great!" He holds up the little flier he'd gotten earlier in the night at the first of the

candy windows. “There’s the Thaymor High Trillers, which is like their top a cappella choir—”

“They are actually quite good,” Hope chimes in, and I can’t help the glare I shoot in her direction.

She’s Catra’s therapist. Her *therapist.* She’s supposed to be helping her, protecting her. And instead, she let this happen!

Or she *was* Catra’s therapist.

God. I’ve ruined everything.

“Then there’s this local ABBA cover band, The Dancing Queens! That’ll be fun! You love ABBA.”

Glimmer rolls her eyes. “Yeah, and I’m sure I’ll love seeing them butchered by a bunch of tone-deaf washed-up wannabes.”

Razz tsks. “Casta, you have to be more open-minded, dearie!”

Glimmer’s eyes go wide. “How do you know—”

Then Bow interrupts whatever she’s about to say with an audible gasp.

We all go quiet and look at him. After waiting several seconds, I finally ask, “What?”

He looks up from the flier and bites his lip. “Nothing…?”

Glimmer reaches up and tears the flier from his hands. Then she gasps too.

“Oh, fuck.”

“What?” I ask, insistent now. I reach for the flier but Glimmer ducks out of my reach. I’m about to chase after her when Razz laughs.

“Oh my, Cyra is the third act, silly. I don’t know why they won’t tell you.” She reaches up to pat my shoulder then steps past me where I’ve stopped on the sidewalk, all the warmth leaving my body. “Your friends are strange.”

With bones of brittle ice, I turn on my heel to face Mara and Hope. “Did you know about this?”

Mara grimaces. “Maybe.”

“Mara!”

“Hey! In my defense, I thought you’d at least, I don’t know, have called her by now?” Her shoulders drop. “Seriously, kid.” She looks like she’s… disappointed in me, and it feels like my brittle bones are breaking. “What are you waiting for?”

I close my eyes and the ice around my heart hardens. “You…” I clench my jaw. “You don’t get to talk to me like that.” I look back up, shooting daggers at Mara, and then at Hope. “I’m not the only one who hurt Catra tonight, and frankly, what I did doesn’t border on illegal.”

Mara narrows her eyes, “Hey now, I didn’t—”

“Know that Hope was your niece’s grief counselor when she was 17 and probably knows stuff about her that you, legally, never should?” I force a tight smile. “I think you did.”

I turn around, leaving Mara sputtering and Hope silent, and march towards the park after Razz, Glimmer and Bow right behind me.

“Whoa,” Bow whistles, coming up on my right. “That was kinda intense. You okay?”

“I’m fine,” I bite out. I don’t even look at Bow. I know if I did, I would see in his face that he doesn’t believe me. And I’d see pity. Right now, pity is the last thing I need.

“Okay, but seriously,” Glimmer says, catching up on my right. “That was awesome!” I do look at Glimmer and she’s grinning. “The look on her face was classic. You totally tore her a new one. Are all of your family gatherings this dramatic?”

The smile that had been growing on my face drops. “Um… I don’t know. I didn’t make it to many.”

“Oh.” Glimmer’s expression shifts and she kinda looks sad. “What happened back there?”

I slow down and look up at the upcoming tree line. I can see the top of the bandshell from here. The main park entrance is on top of a hill that leads down towards the lake, with the tree and grass area to the north and the bandshell directly south. It’s nestled up at the bottom corner of the hill. And during the winter, the safest trek down is the long way around the east end.

Not that any of that matters. What matters is that Catra’s in the back room of that bandshell with her guitar getting ready to play in front of the entire town.

“I really messed up,” I mutter, coming to a stop at the park’s entrance. I look down at the bandshell and the gathering crowd. I don’t know if I should be here. I don’t think Catra wants me here. I don’t think Catra wants me in town at all.

And nothing I’ve ever felt hurts quite like knowing that.

Bow puts his hand on my arm. “You don’t have to talk about it if you don’t want to. But we’re here to listen.”

I try to smile at him. “Thanks, guys.” I start walking again and then towards the bandshell. I glance back and see Mara and Hope across the street, talking in what looks like harsh whispers.

Good.

I turn back to watch the path dug in the snow by numerous pairs of shoes. “I don’t really want to get into it right now, but I guess…

I guess she just said everything I was afraid she was going to say." I take a breath and cross my arms over my stomach. "And I… I don't know what I'm supposed to do now."

"Okay," Glimmer presses, "but what did she actually *say*?"

"Glimmer!" Bow whispers. "She just said she doesn't want to get into it right now!"

"Oh, come on! We can't let her stew in this!" Glimmer whisper-shouts back. "You know how she is! She's about two steps away from a spiral."

"I can hear you."

"Then you know I'm right!" Glimmer chirps. We reach the bottom of the hill, and she comes up beside me and puts a hand on my arm. "Adora, I just want to help. And I know you. I know you're going to tear yourself apart if you don't talk about it."

I bite my lip and Bow approaches on the other side. "She's right," he murmurs, putting a hand on my shoulder. "And we don't have to go to this thing, you know? If it's hard, we can just go back to your place and watch Christmas movies."

I almost smile. There's a part of me that really wants that. That wants to go home and pretend today never happened. But what Mara said really struck me. Why didn't I call Catra? Why wasn't I breaking down her door all weekend begging her to talk to me?

And what Catra said hit even harder. Did I really think she was gonna wait for me? For eight years? Why would she? Even if she'd loved me—

Even if she'd loved me.

I feel like I'm going to puke.

Why did I just let her leave that morning? Why did I leave that night? Why did I think that sending a couple of unanswered texts

a year was enough? Why didn't I call? Why didn't I come back for breaks? Why did I go back to Bright Moon in the first place?

But why did *she* leave? Why did she let *me* leave? If she's so mad, why didn't she respond to *any* of those texts? Why didn't she call? Why didn't she visit me during breaks? Why didn't she ask me to stay in Thaymor?

I feel like I know the answer, and it's making me sick.

"You're spiraling," Glimmer says, and I look up from the ground into her lavender eyes.

"Sorry," I murmur, and she shakes my arms.

"Don't apologize, just…" she takes a deep breath, "tell us what's wrong?"

I nod, stepping over to the side of the path, close to the backside of the bandshell. I lean up against a tree and Glimmer and Bow stand in front of me. Bow puts a hand on my shoulder and Glimmer takes ahold of my hand.

"She…" I swallow, "she said—" I can't even get the words out. If I say it out loud, it'll be real. And I don't want it to be real.

So, I paraphrase. "She said that I'm an idiot." I take a shuddery breath. "That it was stupid of me to think she'd wait this long."

Glimmer scowls. "Did she not say she would?"

I shrug. "I mean, we never put a number on it, but eight years is __"

"You're not an idiot, Adora." Bow squeezes my shoulder. "But you and Catra may've had different understandings of what waiting meant. Or expectations for what it would look like or how long it would be."

I try not to roll my eyes. "Yeah, obviously."

Bow doesn't let my attitude deter him. "I think you should talk to her. Really talk. Explain what you thought, why you thought it, and take responsibility for any hurt you may've caused."

"What?" Glimmer nearly screeches. "Hurt she may've caused? Catra's the one who tore her to pieces in the middle of downtown!"

Bow wraps an arm around Glimmer and pulls her close to him. "If I've learned anything from you, and your love of Frozen, it's that people 'make bad choices when they're mad or scared or stressed'. Or," he shoots me a knowing look, "hurt."

Glimmer turns her head up to Bow. "What's that supposed to mean?"

"It means I love you," he says, placing a kiss on her nose. "Now come on, you think you can do this, Adora?"

I glance over at the crowd of people moving toward the front of the bandshell and my heart rate picks up. But then I think about seeing Catra perform again. I remember her singing in the passenger seat of my car while she decorated the dash with all kinds of stickers, stickers that reminded her of us. I remember her performing little concerts in my parents' living room that Mara and Razz would drive into town for. I remember her playing at my parents' funeral and hugging me so tight after that I felt safe enough to cry.

I want to feel something close to that again.

"Yeah," I straighten. "I can do this."

I can't do this.

I don't know why I thought I could do this. I don't know why I *wanted* to do this. This is torture. This is hell. This is heartbreak.

The second Catra stepped on stage, she promised a three-song set and from that very first chord, I've been reeling.

The first song is the one I heard her play that day in her classroom. At the time, I'd thought maybe, *maybe,* it was about me, but there's no way. It's honestly arrogant to think I could mean that much to Catra, especially after what she said today. There must have been someone else. Someone after me.

She laughed when she realized I hadn't been with anyone since her. She laughed because she'd gone and fallen madly in love.

I wish I could've felt more than just miserable knowing she got her heart broken, and I wondered who it was the entire rest of the song.

There's always the possibility that these songs aren't based on personal experiences at all and are just stories. She did that sometimes when we were kids. She'd say she was "stretching her muscles." I want to believe that. I almost believe that.

"This one," she says, brushing her hair from her eyes and mouth splitting into a wide grin, "is called 'Eat Crow, Bitch'."

My stomach drops and I remember.

"Don't worry, Cat," my dad said, giving Catra a firm hug, "someday that woman will eat crow."

"I have no fucking clue what that means, Rand. But thanks."

I groan audibly and Bow shoots me a funny look as Catra starts to sing.

"*I've been taking measured steps; I keep fire and rage contained. But what crosses your line is anyone's guess, blow your lungs to fan the flames."*

But then the song went on and the chorus basically destroyed any doubt in my mind.

"*I hardly love you now, and I think it's amazing how Everything I do is definitely about you. And you know me so well, I'll see you in hell. One of these days I'll finally say 'Thanks for doing nothing,' and you'll feast on crow… Bitch."*

It's honestly amazing how vulnerable Catra is willing to be on stage when she'll hardly admit to feeling *anything* in real life.

I thought that was going to be the worst of it, then every high schooler in the crowd starts to sing along to the bridge.

"*She don't need your sympathy, she has her high horse to keep her company. If he's not the best bedfellow, she can use her own sorry ass as a pillow."*

Catra is mesmerizing, strumming away on her guitar, beaming as she condemns her mother to a crowd of over a hundred of her freezing neighbors.

The song ends and she repositions the mic, getting ready for the next song.

Everyone gets quiet, like they know something big is coming. I start to feel dread pool in my stomach. Then she plucks a few strings and I recognize the start of the tune. My heart seizes in my chest and she leans forward. *"Hey Princess,"* she almost sighs, breathing into the mic and staring straight ahead above the crowd. I stop breathing. *"Stick to unicorns."*

Her hands start dancing, and the music is fast and furious and full of hurt.

"Wanted to be your knight, in shining armor. But I was the dragon, for your locked tower. Wanted to be your true love's kiss, but I had poison on my lips."

By the time we reach the bridge, I'm shaking.

"Did I scorch the earth? Did I scorch the earth? Did I scorch the earth? Did I scorch the earth? Did I leave a mark, a burn, a

bruise, did I devastate and ruin you?"

And I can't take another second.

I turn and force my way through the crowd of people that have cuddled together for warmth, ignoring my friends' cries. But I can't ignore Catra's voice. Not when it breaks like it does as she sings, *"And I shouldn't want that, but I do. 'Cause maybe I was ruined too."*

I throw one last glance at the stage and see her as her eyes land on me. For a split second, she looks sad. But that second ends pretty quickly, and she's back to working the crowd, taking them through the chorus again.

I break for the tree line and nearly run to the nearest one. I fall against it and slide down into the snow.

"Adora!" Glimmer cries. In seconds, she and Bow are by my side. Glimmer slides off her gloves and feels my forehead. Bow reaches for my wrist and checks my pulse. I wince at the cold of both of their hands.

Glimmer huffs. "I can't tell if she's feverish. My hands are too cold."

Bow gives a little nod. "Her pulse is fine. A little higher than normal but—"

"Why are you always talking about me like I'm not here?"

They both sigh. "Sorry," Bow says, patting my hand. "We just got worried. What happened?"

I bite my lip, trying to figure out if I can tell them without telling them. "She…" I push up on my arms, "she used to call me Princess."

Glimmer's eyes are huge, and Bow's lips are so pursed they're nonexistent.

I take a deep breath and move to stand. “I have to go. Can you guys get a ride back with Mara and Razz?”

“What?” Glimmer stands too. “Why wouldn’t we come with you?”

I give her a soft, sad smile. “I have to go somewhere. Alone.”

Bow makes a face. “Adora, I don’t know if that’s—”

“I promise, I’ll be fine.” I brush the loose hair out of my eyes. “I share my location with you. If you really wanna know where I am, just show Razz a picture of the map.”

Glimmer scoffs. “Well, if it’s that easy why don’t you just tell us where you’re going?”

I actually smile now. “Because you’d insist on coming with me. But I really need to do this by myself.”

Glimmer’s mouth pops open, but Bow puts a hand on her shoulder, silencing her. “Okay, Adora. We trust you.”

I take them both in my arms and give them a quick hug. “Thanks! I’ll see you tomorrow.”

“Sure! Great!” Glimmer cries, and I laugh as I run up the hill toward my truck.

Half an hour later, I’m on the doorstep of a small little gray house with black shutters and a black roof. There’s a Christmas tree shining through the front window and a hot red Camaro in the driveway. Next to the front porch is a snowman dressed with the local university’s colors, and two snow angels marked with the letters T and A.

After a second of blinking back tears because this is the first time I’ve ever been on this porch, I knock.

When the door finally opens, I can’t hold back the tears anymore.

“Hi, Adam.”

“I guess I have no right to be mad you didn’t come help me unpack my U-Haul on Saturday, huh?” I force a chuckle and Adam snickers, handing me a beer.

“I’m an athletic trainer, ‘Dor. That means I work most Saturdays.” He sits down on the couch across from me. “But yeah, you really can’t hold it against me.”

I nod hesitantly and look around. It’s a nice house. Small, but nice. It looks like Adam, but all the best parts about him. And Teela too. Well, as far as I know her, that is.

“Is Teela here?” I ask, tapping the side of my bottle.

Adam nods. “Yeah, but she’s in bed already. She’s going in early tomorrow so we can come down to make pies with Razz.”

I wince. He notices.

“What?”

“Nothing.”

He sighs and rolls his eyes, leaning forward in his chair just like our dad used to do when he had something serious he wanted to say. “Adora, what’s going on? It’s not like you to just show up without even sending a text first. Hell, it’s not really like you to just show up!”

Tears prick at my eyes. “I… I can go—”

Adam reaches out and takes my hand in his. “No, ‘Dor, that’s not… that’s not what I’m saying. I’m sorry. That was outta line. What I mean is, I can tell you’re upset and you’re here, so I know you want to talk to me about it.”

I give a soft little nod.

"So, talk."

I swallow. Then I lift the beer to my lips and take a long swig. Then I lower it and just swallow again.

"It's… it's about Catra."

Adam takes a deep breath and lets it out slow. "Yeah, I was afraid of that."

I furrow my brow. "What? Why?"

He shrugs, leaning back into the couch. "She called me."

I blink, then look down at the grain of the coffee table, then blink again. "She… you two… talk?"

"Adora," I look up to see Adam frowning, kind of angrily, "Catra was my friend too."

Was. Past tense. Not because Catra was gone or because they weren't friends anymore, but because *I* wasn't her friend anymore.

I huff, a wave of anger rushing through me. "So, what? Catra gets to make pies with my grandma, hang out with my aunt and brother, and see my therapist? How is that fair?"

Adam's scowl lightens. "What do you mean?"

I laugh, feeling a tad hysterical. "It's like we got divorced! And she got everything!"

Adam takes a deep breath and leans forward again. I hate that it reminds me so much of our dad. I hate how much it makes me miss him.

"Adora, you were the one who left. And didn't come back—"

"But I did!" I slam my beer on the coffee table and rise to my feet. "And she was the one who said she didn't want to see me, or go with me—"

"Whoa, whoa, wait…" Adam holds up a hand. "Go with you?"

"Yes!" I cry.

"You asked Catra to go with you?"

I throw my head back. "Ye-he-hes!"

"When?" he asks, eyes narrowed.

I roll my head. I've had literally one sip of beer, so I know I'm not drunk, but, and maybe it's just talking to Adam, I feel some kind of liberated. "Winter break, freshman year. And—"

"Was this before or after she applied for school?"

I shake my head. "I don't know. She never told me she was applying. But," I groan, "Adam, you're not listening!"

"Sorry, sorry." He sits back in his seat again. "I'm listening."

I take a steadying breath. "I get that I'm the bad guy," I say, putting my hand to my chest. "Okay? I get that I fucked up. I'm an idiot! I was stupid and naïve and *dumb*!" My hands start to shake. "But what else was I supposed to believe? I couldn't—" I choke on my tears, which have just started running down my face. "I couldn't lose Catra. I—I couldn't. So, maybe, I tried to fix things and 'imagined' a future for us. But I am not the one who gave up on that future and I'm *sick* of being treated like I was!"

Adam stares at me for a second, but his eyes aren't full of pity. They're full of hurt.

"Why did you stop coming home?"

I sigh. "Catra said—"

“You still could’ve come home,” he crosses his arms. “To see Mara, Razz, me…” His voice breaks on the last word and for the hundredth time today, I’m reminded of the hurt I’ve caused. “I really missed you, ‘Dor.”

I drop my gaze to the floor and run my hand up my forearm. After several seconds, I go and sit next to him on the couch. I wrap my arm around his and lay my head on his shoulder.

“I really messed up,” I breathe, and he chuckles.

“That’s not an answer.”

I huff and elbow him in the ribs. He pinches my arm and I yelp.

“Fine,” I settle back into his side, “you win. But you’re not gonna like it.”

“Hit me.”

I bite my lip, delaying the inevitable a second longer. “I couldn’t risk it.” I can feel his eyes on the top of my head, but I don’t look up. “Seeing her. I knew I’d quit. I almost dropped out my freshman year because I missed her so much. The only thing that kept me going was volleyball.”

Adam lets out a quiet laugh. “Love of the game beat out love of the lady?”

I scoff. “No.”

“Then what?”

I shrug. “I couldn’t come home until I got a gold medal. Not permanently anyway.”

For a second everything is quiet, and I wonder if I’ve made him mad. “Seriously?”

I frown. “Yes.”

“So,” he lifts his hand to pinch the skin at the top of his nose, “this whole time you were working your ass off just so you could come back to *Thaymor*?”

My frown deepens. “It sounds dumb when you say it like that.”

“That’s because it is dumb!”

I lift my head. “I was working my ass off so I could come back to Catra!”

Adam’s gaze is boring into mine like he’s looking for a lie, but he won’t find one. I would never lie about this. And I’m a shit liar anyway.

“You really love her,” he mutters, “don’t you?”

“With all of my heart.”

He nods and turns back to stare at the Christmas tree that’s sitting right by the front window. I put my head back on his shoulder and look at it too. It’s beautiful, and I know that’s because Teela is really big on color coordination. But she still has half a dozen of Adam’s homemade ornaments from childhood up on the tree, most of them with his toothy grin staring back at you.

“What made that gold medal so important anyway?” Adam asks, shaking me from the brink of sleep.

“Hmmm?”

“The gold medal,” he repeats, “why was it so important?”

“Oh,” I look back at the tree and find an ornament with both Adam and me on it. It’s a wreath made from green puzzle pieces. Our faces are covered in ice cream and we’re reaching for the camera. It was after my first volleyball game. That day, my dad had proclaimed that I was destined for greatness. He called me his little Olympian. And when I asked my mom how I would get to the next game, that was all the way in Elberon, she promised she

would take me. And that she would be at every single volleyball game I ever had.

“Mom and Dad,” I breathe, settling into his arm.

“Oh.”

“Yeah.”

We’re quiet for a little bit longer but I’m awake now, memories playing in my head on a highlights reel.

“Are they why you and Teela are still in Elberon?” I whisper, and from the way Adam stiffens, I already know the answer.

“Yeah.”

“Do you…” I bite my lip. “Do you think they’re proud of us?”

Adam almost laughs. “I don’t know. But,” he pokes my arm, “I’m proud of you, ‘Dor. If that counts for anything.”

I smile and poke him back. “I’m proud of you too.” I yawn and close my eyes. “You’re such a good big brother.”

Chapter End Notes

So...? Whatdya think?

Some things that might interest you? Adora mentions having a small family - this is in part due to the fact that Marlena is no longer in contact with her family. She left home at 18 to go to college and never went back. She grew up in an incredibly toxic and abusive household and she got out as soon as she could. This is part of why she could see the signs in Catra and why she took so much care of her. She knew that she couldn't do anything as direct as calling social services, there wasn't physical evidence of abuse, she looked, but she did everything she could so that Catra felt loved.

Only two people in the world have ever called Adora 'Dor, and they are Randor and Adam. Randor does this because it is the part of his name that he shares with his daughter, and Adam does it because it's a habit he picked up from his father. He takes after him in many ways.

Adora has seen her family since leaving, they've come to see her in Bright Moon and were there when she won the gold at the Olympics. They just didn't storm the sand like Glimmer because they're respectful. And even though Adora was on the volleyball team with Teela she still often feels like she doesn't know her that well because she doesn't know her as her brother's girlfriend.

I THINK that's everything I wanted to say. Oh! The line - "I hardly love you anymore," changes on the third chorus to "You hardly love me anymore," in "Eat Crow Bitch" and I thought you'd like to know that.

Giving a Fuck Hurts

Chapter Notes

Before I do anything else I just want to say thank you to all of you who are reading right now. Thank you for staying with this fic. Thank you for reading my fics at all. It means the world to me. I love writing more than anything and that I get to do it like this, with so many people rooting for me, is truly so special. I don't take that for granted. And I know this one has been hard, but thank you for trusting me to make it right.

Now as Renee says in the Twilight Saga: Eclipse, masterful film that it is, "Enough with the heavy."

So in this chapter I reference a treat that has a vice grip on the midwest. If you've never had one I truly feel sorry for you. Basically you take a pretzel, a slightly melted Rolo or Hershey kiss, place it on top, and then press it flat with an M&M. They're fantastic and I don't know why. I barely touch on them but I wanted to give a more thorough explanation here for those of you who wouldn't recognize the reference on sight.

This is kind of a short chapter, but it delivers on the feels I promise.

Um... CW: Shadow Weaver.

ANYWAY! Have fun!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra

It seems to me more than ever I am a victim of introspection – Sylvia Plath

December 31, 2012

I keep my expectations low, that's my whole thing. And I tell myself that's practical because if I keep them low, I'm not gonna get disappointed. But it doesn't work; I get disappointed anyway. Because no matter how low I keep my expectations, my life manages to find a new low.

So, when Adora and I walked into that high school gym our senior year for the New Year's Eve Gala, in spite of everything that had gone right so far, I wasn't expecting much.

But it was kind of amazing.

Every surface was covered in snowflakes, nice ones made of plastic and glass that shimmered in the light. Mounds of white felt made fake snow piles around the floor where tables stood. There were lights, fake icicles, and white pine trees. There was a DJ in the corner, music filling the room, and snacks along the nearest wall. The room was buzzing with energy, and everyone was dressed to the nines.

Adora took my hand and gave it a squeeze. "Wow," she breathed, "It's even better than last year."

I looked her over, the gold shimmer around her eyes, the red dress draped over her figure, and I smiled. "Yeah, it is."

She turned her head and smiled back at me. "Come on," she said, tugging on my hand and taking off in the direction of the refreshments, "let's go find our friends."

We found them pretty easily, and sure enough, they weren't far from the snacks. Entrapta was gushing over the miniature cupcakes and these little pretzel squares with some melted chocolate candy and a single M&M pressed on top, and Kyle was holding her plate while she piled it high. Lonnie and Rogelio were behind them, surveying the room and talking about various peoples' outfits. Sea Hawk, Duncan, and Adam were discussing the morality of spiking the punch, and other pranks they could pull

instead. Scorpia was listening to them, probably just to ignore me, nodding her head and saying, "uh huh, uh huh," like she was following along with their discussion about how flammable felt is.

Adora was kinda just basking in it. She kept looking around and smiling. Then she looked at me and held out her hand. She pulled me close, and her smile softened. "I'm really happy you came with me tonight."

I glanced around, but all of our friends seemed distracted, so I leaned into her. "Me too."

Then, in the boldest move I think I've ever pulled, I tightened my grip on her hand and pulled towards the dance floor.

"Come on," I grinned, "let's dance."

Her face got pale. "Um… dancing?"

I laughed out loud. "Yes, dancing. Why do you think people come to these things?"

She grimaced. "Catra, I'm not a very good—"

I reached back with my other hand to reinforce my grip. "Don't worry, Princess. I'll lead."

I don't know what about what I said convinced her, but her smile was back, arrogant as ever, and she let me pull her out to the floor. I don't remember what song was playing, but I remember dancing with Adora. We danced to song after song. I moved with a freedom I never had before, and I think she did too. We were just us. It didn't matter that there were a bunch of people around. What mattered was me and Adora.

And then a slow song came on. I remember that one painfully well.

We came to a stop, lowering our arms. Adora crossed one over her stomach to hold the other. For a second, she stood awkwardly, unsure what to do.

"Don't worry, Princess. I'll lead."

I held out my hand.

It was Snow Patrol's "Chasing Cars".

She stepped closer to me and put her hand on my shoulder. I put mine on her waist, and we started spinning in slow circles. I looked up into her clear gray-blue eyes and I thought about how I wanted to stare into those eyes for the rest of my life. I thought about how much I loved them.

"If I lay here, if I just lay here, would you lie with me and just forget the world…"

I'd promised myself weeks ago that night would be the night. I'd promised myself that after we kissed at midnight, I was going to tell her I loved her. I was going to tell her she didn't have to say it back, but that she deserved to know.

"I don't quite know, how to say, how I feel…"

Adora was dealing with a lot. For fuck's sake, her parents had died. She was being raised by two entirely different people. She was trying to keep her grades up and keep the volleyball scholarship she'd all but been guaranteed a year before. The last thing that should've been on Adora's mind was me.

So yeah, I wasn't expecting Adora to say it back.

"Forget what we're told, before we get too old, show me a garden that's bursting into life…"

And even if she could, I understood why Adora wanted to keep our relationship a secret. But that didn't mean my feelings had to

be. At least not from her. Not when all I wanted to do was scream them from the tops of buildings at everyone passing by.

"I need your grace, to remind me to find my own…"

So, I was going to tell her.

And I was terrified.

It wasn't like me, at all, to express a feeling like that. It had been years since I'd told someone I loved them, and the last time hadn't gone very well. I still had nightmares about it, about the way she looked at me when I'd said it, like she was sick. And what she'd said…

But Adora wasn't going to do that to me. Adora was my best friend. Even if she didn't love me the way I loved her, there was something about me she loved. Something.

"All that I am, all that I ever was, is here in your perfect eyes they're all I can see…"

"Catra," she breathed, pulling me out of my trance, the song nearing its end, "you…" She took a deep breath and placed a hand on my cheek. "I just want you to know that I—"

"If I lay here, if I just lay here, would you lie with me and just forget the world…"

And then the song ended, and the sound of microphone feedback cut Adora off.

Up on some sort of makeshift stage stood Principal Prime, whose younger brother Hordak was actually in the graduating class from the year before us. He smiled and a chill ran up my spine. He always freaked me out. "Hello students, alumni, and faculty. Thank you for coming to this year's New Year's Eve Gala! We have had quite a lovely time this evening, have we not?"

A loud cheer rang out amongst the crowd and Principal Prime chuckled. "Good. Well, without further ado, here is Ms. Windione, to introduce this year's Snow King & Queen."

The crowd clapped happily and Spinnerella, mine and Adora's English teacher, stepped up to take the mic from Prime. She forced a smile at him, then turned to the crowd and relaxed. "Hello, everyone! Who's ready to meet your 2012 Snow King & Queen?"

There'd been a huge debate a few years before about whether the Snow King and Queen should be for the passing year or the upcoming year, and it never *really* got settled. Spinnerella and her wife Netossa, one of the school's history teachers, still fought about it to this day.

The crowd cheered and Spinnerella herself clapped after setting the microphone in its stand. She nodded over to the side of the stage and out came Netossa, with two pillows holding the Snow King & Queen's crowns.

I elbowed Adora in the ribs. "Whatdya wanna bet it's you and Sea Hawk?"

"What?" she shrieked, drawing the attention of several of our neighbors. "No way! Sea Hawk, maybe, but me? Why me?"

I cocked my head. "Do you want me to be honest with you?"

She narrowed her eyes. "Always."

"Pity points. Dead parents."

She gasped. "How *dare* you!"

I cackled and she smiled a little, which meant I didn't cross the line. "But you're also hot and popular so…"

She snaked an arm around my waist. "You think I'm hot?"

I rolled my eyes, surprised by how obvious she was being. We were in a crowded room, and anyone could see… "I did not say—"

"And our Snow King is—"

She pulled me closer. "That's so embarrassing for—"

"Adam Grayskull!"

Adora and I both froze, standing up straighter and following the spotlight that landed on a shell-shocked Adam. He was standing on the edge of the dance floor, with some girl I didn't recognize with auburn hair. After several seconds of him just not moving, the girl put her hands on his shoulders and gave him a gentle shove towards the stage.

"Shit," I whispered and Adora swallowed.

"Pity points…" she muttered, as Adam reached and climbed onto the stage. "You don't think that means—"

"Congratulations Adam! Now, without further ado, our Snow Queen is… Adora Grayskull!"

Adora winced and I stepped out of her reach as a giant spotlight shone directly on her from the stage. She gave an awkward little wave. "Um… Hi?"

"Hi!" Spinnerella laughed. "Come on up Adora!"

Adora looked back at me like she was begging for help, but what was I supposed to do? Grab her hand and run?

I did consider it for a second, but by the time I'd built up the nerve, Adora was making her way to the stage.

She got there right as Netossa was putting the crown on Adam's head. He seemed to have figured it out in the seconds the spotlight was on his sister, because he was standing tall with his hands behind his back, and he was smiling. His smile was tight,

sure, but I was probably one of the few people who knew him well enough to notice.

Adora must've noticed too. She tried to mimic him. She put her hands behind her back and her feet shoulder-width apart. But when she had to hunch a little so they could put the crown on the top of her head, she kinda deflated.

Once they got that crown on her head though, she looked…

Well, she looked like a princess.

"Can we have a round of applause for your Thaymor Yule Festival's Snow King and Queen?" Spinnerella cheered, and the entire room burst into applause.

I probably cheered louder than anyone.

After Spinnerella got us all to shut up again, Adora looked about ready to dart off the stage, but Spinnerella put a hand on her shoulder. "Now, traditionally, the Snow King and Queen would share a dance," Adam and Adora both grimaced and everyone laughed, "but because you two are siblings, we're going to allow you to pick your partners. So, go grab someone and then bring them back up to the front so everyone can see."

Immediately Adora's eyes fell to me, and I nearly booked it out of the room. I've always been faster than her, I could've gotten away. But I stayed put, held in place under the weight of her eyes.

She ran to me, grabbed my hands, then pulled me out to the front of the room where everyone could see.

Then "Stolen" by Dashboard Confessional started to play over the speakers.

I was thoroughly fucked.

She pulled me close, and we started dancing like we had been before this whole Yule royalty thing had started. She smiled at me and dropped my hand for a second to adjust her crown.

"This is ridiculous," she laughed. "Pity points will get you far in life, huh?"

"Before the gold and the glimmer have been replaced, another sun-soaked season fades away…"

I opened my mouth to laugh, even to agree, when I was struck by something.

No. No, they won't.

I looked over Adora's shoulder to see Adam dancing with who I now realized was Teela, that girl on the volleyball team he'd been asking about the night of Randor and Marlena's accident. And yeah, maybe she was only dancing with him because of that accident. Maybe Adam and Adora only got to be Snow King and Queen because of that accident, but I doubted it. And I was sure that eventually, Teela would've given Adam a chance. He would've gotten this dance.

"Invitations only grand farewell, crash the best one of the best ones…"

Adora was going to go to UBM in the fall on a Volleyball scholarship. She wasn't sure she had it in the bag yet, but I was. And that had nothing to do with the accident. There were no pity points there.

Adora was going to be an Olympic gold medalist, and no one gave out gold medals because of pity, especially in volleyball.

Pity points meant nothing in the big picture, and I would know. I was swimming in them.

"And from the ballroom floor we are in celebration, one good stretch before our hibernation…"

I was the girl with the bad adoptive mom, the dead bio mom, and the missing dad. No one liked me all that much, and even though Randor and Marlena hadn't been my parents, it was obvious that they'd been important to me. They weren't even mine, I'd just been a leech in their perfect lives. I was pathetic, I was headed down the long winding path to nowhere. I wouldn't even be able to afford community college next year.

And everyone who knew I wanted to be a musician knew that was a pipe dream, even me.

"Our dreams assured and we all, will sleep well, sleep well…"

I looked into Adora's beautiful eyes and searched them for the doubt that was eating away at me, but I didn't find it. Not even a little.

Because Adora's an idiot.

And she needed to leave Thaymor. She needed to leave and never come back.

"You have stolen my…"

"Hey," she whispered, her smile falling and her hand resting on my cheek. "Are you okay?"

"You have stolen my…"

I returned her smile, pushing my thoughts away and choosing to be in the moment with her for just a little longer. I had time to think about loss another day. But I would only get one more night with Thaymor's Snow Queen.

"You have stolen my heart…"

"Yeah," I shrugged, "I just… I wish they could've seen you in a crown."

Tears came to her eyes and, for a minute, I felt guilty. Then she leaned in and kissed me on the mouth, right in front of everyone.

"I watch you spin around in your highest heels, you are the best one, of the best ones…"

It was gentle and sweet, but it felt like a promise. And then everyone started to cheer.

"We all look like we feel…"

I kissed her back, and I decided not to tell her I loved her.

December 24, 2021

"She's this way," Starla says, voice low, waving me forward with her hand. I step around the check-in desk, grabbing the vase of daisies I brought with me off the counter.

For the tenth time, I wonder if I should've just brought poinsettias or some other more Christmas-appropriate plant, like maybe a wreath for her bedroom door. But that's stupid, it's Christmas Eve. It would only be up another day. Maybe I should've brought cookies. Or a pie? No. I've never made a pie by myself. I don't even know what kind she likes. Does she even like pie? Or cookies?

Should I have brought wine?

I almost laugh. I wonder what her doctors would think of that.

I wonder why I'm so damn anxious about it anyway.

We enter the dining room and Starla leads me across to the far corner by a large window where the early morning sunlight is pouring into the room. She stops at a table there and leans over the shoulder of the woman sitting there.

She has long black hair pulled back in a braid, large green eyes, and fair skin. Her hands, which sit crossed on the table, are wrinkled and scarred. She eyes me with curiosity and looks down at the vase in my hands.

"Shannon," Starla smiles at her, "you have a visitor."

My mother nods, and I pull out a chair. I set the daisies on the table. She tilts her head and the softest smile I've ever seen plays with her mouth. "I like daisies," she murmurs, "I find them cheerful."

"Yeah," I let out a slow breath, "I know."

She turns to look at me again, and she looks like she's waiting for something.

"Merry Christmas, I guess."

She nods. "Merry Christmas to you too." She smiles, but it's forced and stiff. I recognize it from when she used to say "thank you" to the Grayskulls for taking me places and giving me shit. It meant, "thanks, but no thanks." Because she didn't want it. She didn't want me to wish her a "Merry Christmas" because she didn't want me to have one. She didn't want me to have anything. She never did.

"Seriously?" I scoff, crossing my arms and leaning back. "Unbelievable."

She drops the fake-as-shit smile. "I'm sorry—"

"You should be," I hiss, leaning forward. "I am all you have. I am the only person in the entire goddamn world who gives a shit about you anymore, and you can't even wish me a 'Merry Christmas' and mean it."

I stand and shove my chair back into place.

"I don't—"

At the sound of her voice, the voice that may very well be responsible for the loss of every good thing in my life, I stop and turn back. "Why did you take me in? Why bother? I mean, if you didn't—why not just—gah!" I brush my hands back through my hair. "Did you ever love me?" I cry, my voice breaking. "At all?"

When I finally meet her eyes, there are tears in them, and the feeling in my stomach is violent.

"I'm sorry, child but… I don't know who you are."

My breath catches in my throat and everything kind of stills.

"Oh." I straighten, smooth out my coat and my hair, and force a tight smile. "I'm sorry I wasted your time."

"You do," she starts, pointing a long bony finger at me, "look quite a bit like—"

"I'm not," I say, turning around. "Enjoy the daisies and Merry Christmas."

I make it out to my car before I start really crying.

I don't know what I expected. The doctors said her Alzheimer's was progressing rapidly now. It was honestly kind of miraculous that she'd held on to memories of me this long. And it shouldn't hurt. It shouldn't.

But it does.

She ruined me, and now she doesn't even remember me. It's like it meant nothing. Like *I* mean nothing.

My phone buzzes in my pocket and I pull it out. I read the number and sigh as I recognize the nursing home's landline.

"Hello?"

“Hi, Catra?” Starla asks, voice chipper as ever. “This is Starla with Heart Blossom Nursing Home?”

“Yeah, I know who you are, Starla.” Without a thought I reach under my sweater and grab the chain that always hangs around my neck, then start to fiddle with the charm. “What’s up?”

“Well…” she makes a nervous little noise, “Shannon is concerned that she really upset you. She wanted me to call and tell you she’s grateful for the daisies, and that she’s sorry she didn’t recognize you.”

I bite my lower lip to hold back a fresh wave of tears.

“Great.”

“Are you okay?” Starla presses, and I can just picture her twirling the phone cord. “I’ve seen it before, the day mom or dad forgets who their kids are, and it can be really hard.”

I take a deep breath and decide that it’s best not to rip into Starla for butting into my business. She’s a nice girl, and she honestly does have more experience with this than I do. Maybe she has something actually smart to say.

“Yeah… I’m feeling a lot.”

“I would advise that you spend the day with family,” she says, and I almost laugh, “remember good times, and try to be grateful for what you still have.”

I nod at no one and purse my lips. “Sounds like a plan.”

“Oh!” Starla perks up, “one more question. Shannon keeps asking about ‘Elizabeth’? She says she’s her—”

“I don’t know an Elizabeth.” I say, drop the necklace, and immediately hang up.

Chapter End Notes

Some fun facts:

Spinnerella's last name is a reference to that scene in "An Ill Wind" when Entrapta says "Isn't that the windy one?" 😁 Well, I thought it was funny.

Prime is the school principal when Catra and Adora are in high school but by the time Catra is a teacher, Hordak has taken over and Prime has retired. Which is a blessing for all as Hordak is much less strict and really just a little weird.

I think about the line "I watch you spin around in your highest heels, you are the best one, of the best ones..." from "Stolen" every damn day of my fuckin' life. It's a plague and I hope you suffer a little now too.

Like! Comment! Subscribe! Tell me what you're thinking! The next chapter is already well underway. And next chapter, we actually get some Catradora interaction...

Things I Thought I Had to Do

Chapter Notes

> So I meant to post this much earlier today but I took a really big sleep after work and the anxiety that had been coursing through me like a current for the last twenty-four hours finally ebbed so I crashed and slept straight til I had to go to work again. So I'm gonna post it in the middle of the night!
>
> Adora wears a masquerade mask in this chapter for a minute. It's inspired by this one! https://www.deviantart.com/elementalillusions/art/High-Elf-King-199069208
>
> I, personally, think this chapter ends on a softer note. But I've been told I'm not great at judging these things. Anyway! Enjoy!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora

"I had an inheritance from my father, It was the moon and sun. And though I roam all over the world, The spending of it's never done." - Ernest Hemingway

October 28, 2013

I remember that I woke up before my alarm, and I didn't want to go back to sleep. That may have been the first time in my life that ever happened.

It was Catra's 18 th birthday, and I was so excited for her.

Even though Catra had always been in the same grade as I was, she was one of the youngest kids in it. The birthday cut-off for

enrollment in kindergarten was December 1 st , rather than September 1 st like I'd heard it was in other states. And when you think about it for more than five seconds, September 1 st obviously makes more sense, but I was grateful we lived in one of the weird states because it meant I got to meet Catra. And if Catra had gone to college, it would've meant she got out of her mom's house that much sooner.

But Catra didn't go to college. At least, not right away. So, she was stuck with Shannon until the day she turned 18.

I already knew the plan, and how little a part I had to play. Mara and Razz were going to help shuttle Catra's stuff to her new apartment, that she'd had lined up for weeks. Adam was going to take her to the DMV so she could get her driver's license, and her birthday present. And then at the end of the day, they were all going to force her to sit down while they sang "Happy Birthday," and fed her cake. Chocolate with raspberry filling.

I was so excited. I just wanted to call her and listen to her narrate her entire day. I wanted to make her laugh while she stood in line at the DMV and listen to her as she unpacked. I wanted to talk with her about furniture and make plans for when I came home in —

Then I wasn't excited anymore. I clenched my fists, and the alarm went off on my phone.

Still, it was going to be a great day.

I didn't know Bow super well, but I knew he was a good athlete and an even better teammate, so when he'd asked if I wanted to work out together in the mornings, I couldn't think of anyone I'd rather have spot me.

We'd been at it for an hour, and I kept glancing at my phone. It was almost seven in Bright Moon, which meant it was about nine in Thaymor. That wasn't too early, was it? I could call, just really

quick, to tell her happy birthday, and then I could call her back later when I had more time.

Or when she had more time. Because she was the one moving out today. She was probably doing that right about then, putting all her stuff in the back of Mara's car. I hoped she was also telling Shannon off for being a terrible mother.

I never asked. And she probably didn't have time for a phone call yet…

"What's going on?" Bow asked, tapping my knee. He was holding my feet down while I did sit-ups, and I'd completely lost count.

"Just thinking," I sighed. "Probably too much."

"What about?" he asked, being supportive like, I was learning, he always is.

I sat up and shrugged. "It's my girlfriend's birthday. I'm trying to decide when to call."

"Oh!" he beamed, "I didn't know you had a girlfriend!"

I blushed, so hard I could feel it in my neck. "Yeah… her name's Catra."

He put a hand under his chin, propping himself up on his knees. "That's an adorable name! Do you have a picture?"

I nodded, reaching to my side where I'd left my phone. I didn't even have to pull up a picture. Catra was my lockscreen. She was in her Halloween costume from the year before – Catwoman – and standing with her arms crossed by my front door looking completely disinterested. Just like Catra.

Bow immediately cooed. "Oh! She's so cute! With the cat ears!"

I grinned. "Yeah. It wasn't that easy to convince her to wear them, but it was so worth it."

Bow melted a little, grinning at me. “How long have you been together?”

I paused, and the realization hit me like a truck. “Oh my god. A year today!” I grabbed Bow by the shoulders. “I forgot our anniversary! How could I forget that? I’m a terrible girlfriend! I have to get her something! I mean obviously, I have to get her something, that’s what you do on anniversaries, but I forgot so—”

“Whoa, whoa!” He chuckled. “I’m sure you’re fine. I mean, you got her a birthday gift, right?”

I nodded but bit my lip. “Yeah, with my brother.”

Bow winced.

“That’s bad, isn’t it?” I groaned. “Shoot! Okay. Game plan…” I waited for something to come to me. Anything. But not a single helpful thought entered my big, dumb, stupid head. “I don’t have a game plan!”

“Adora,” Bow put a calming hand on my shoulder. “It’s okay. You’re gonna have to ship it, so it’s gonna be late no matter what. We have time to figure this out. Breathe.”

I took a deep breath in sync with Bow and tried not to spiral as I thought about what I was supposed to get Catra to show her how much I loved her.

I probably could’ve called Catra in between working out and my eight am bio class, but I needed to shower and to think about present ideas. By the time I got to bio, the best I could come up with was a candle. And not even a decent or cool candle, just a candle that smelled like vanilla, which was what she told me I always smelled like.

But that felt arrogant. Which was another thing she said I was, and I didn’t need to fuel that fire.

After bio, I ran to the library to pick up a book I needed for my lit class, and I should've called her then, but I didn't because now I was stuck on a scarf or a beanie since it was almost winter and she was always stealing mine, but I liked that she would steal mine. And gloves were no good because if I got her new gloves they wouldn't be stretched out and we wouldn't be able to share anymore.

Before I knew it, I was in art. It was the one elective I was taking that semester and it was easily my favorite class.

Catra always said that my doodles were "next level". She used to tear them out of my notes at the end of every semester and quite literally put them in a "scrapbox". She kept a bunch of stuff in there – notes we'd passed, pictures my parents took, the hospital bracelet from when I got my appendix removed, anything she said she wanted to remember. I'd told her time and time again all that stuff would make an excellent scrap *book* , but she always said, "I'm not a middle-aged mother of twin blondes, Adora."

And then my mom would whack her upside the head if she was standing close enough.

In my art class though, I learned that Catra was right, my doodles were "next level", and I was actually pretty good for someone with "no technical skills" as my professor put it. I was excited to learn, and I felt like I was improving each day.

But it was a long class. Two hours. And I was itching to call Catra.

I looked down at my phone. Class started in three minutes.

But it was about noon back home. Catra was probably getting lunch right now. I could call her later.

After I got out of class, I sent Catra a text.

Happy Birthday Babe! 🎉 Are you free to talk right now?

She didn’t respond right away but I wasn’t gonna panic, so I went to the library to work on the art project we’d just been assigned, some perspective thing I can’t remember. And I waited. And I waited.

Finally, my phone buzzed.

I ripped my phone out of my pocket.

Bow 🎀 - Hey! Do you wanna get lunch with me and Glimmer?

I sighed.

Only if you help me come up with a present for my girlfriend.

Bow 🎀 - Deal!

Bow was shockingly bad at coming up with gift ideas. His girlfriend Glimmer, who reminded me quite a bit of Catra but in a much pinker package, was better.

“Oh!” Bow bounced in his seat, “what about one of those ‘of the month’ clubs? They have them for everything these days!”

I shook my head, feeling the impending doom creeping up on me. “Catra knows what she wants. She doesn’t like random strangers deciding for her.”

Glimmer raised an eyebrow. “So why are we worrying about a gift for her then?”

“Well, I’m not a random stranger!” I groaned, dropping my head to the table. “And by getting her a good gift, I’m proving that I know her, because I know what she wants!”

A couple seconds of silence passed and I resigned myself to a gift certificate for a mani-pedi, which isn’t half bad, when Glimmer

spoke up. “Okay,” I peeked to see Glimmer nodding with her hand on her chin, “that actually makes sense.”

“It does?” Bow looked at Glimmer confused, and honestly a little scared.

She sighed, patting him on the shoulder. “Yes, but don’t worry. I’m more of a ‘words of affirmation’ person.” She turned back to me, a determined look on her face. “Okay, so what does Catra like?”

I sat up. I could do this. I knew Catra better than I knew myself and I could talk about her all day. “She likes movies and television shows, and reading, really stories I guess is what I would call them. And she loves music. Like, loves music. She’s an amazing guitarist and plays the piano and sings—”

Glimmer cocks her head. “Does she collect vinyls? Like vinyl records. That’s like a thing now, right?”

I shrugged. “I don’t think so? I mean, it could be a thing, but I don’t think she collects them. She doesn’t have a record player, that’s for sure. She does still have a ton of CDs and a CD player. Oh, and she has an iPod.” I smiled, remembering how excited she was when I gave it to her. It was a random Thursday in January, right after I’d gotten my new iPod Nano. It was blue and thin and beautiful. My old iPod Classic just seemed so lame after that. My dad had been the one who mentioned Catra might like it though, and from the size of her smile I knew he was right.

“Well, who’s her favorite band? Or singer?” Glimmer asked, trying to keep my attention.

“The Horde. But she already has—”

“What?” Glimmer shrieked. “She’s *Horde Scum* ?”

I rolled my eyes. “My girlfriend is not *scum,* but yeah, she’s a fan. She already has all their—”

"That is so *funny* !" Glimmer laughed, loudly, and Bow shook his head. "What? Bow! That's like the most 'angsty' thing a girl can do! That or… what's that one band called? The one that broke up earlier this year and everyone freaked out?"

I bit my lip. I knew the answer, but I wasn't about to feed Glimmer's critiques of Catra by telling her something I knew because I saw my girlfriend grieve over it.

"Are you done?" Bow asked, and Glimmer deflated.

"Fine." She turned back to me. "She has all their CDs already though?"

I nodded. "Yes."

Glimmer sighed. "Well, I would say concert tickets but those would cost—"

I stood up, reaching across the table and grabbing Glimmer by the arms. "That's brilliant!" I gave her a little shake. "She'd love that!"

I dropped her and then grabbed my bag from where I'd set it on the chair next to mine. "Okay! I'll see you at practice, Bow!"

"Wait!" Bow held out a hand. "You're going to the Masquerade tonight right?"

I blanched. "The what?"

Glimmer groaned, putting her hand to her head. "Jocks. The Athletic Department is holding a Masquerade tonight."

I bit my lip. "And that's a type of… party?"

Glimmer groaned and Bow chuckled. "Yeah," he said, reaching into his bag and pulling out a full-color flier on glossy paper. "It's a huge donor event. They want as many of their star athletes as possible to show up."

I looked up to see them both staring at me with pursed lips. “That means you,” Glimmer said.

I grimaced. “I wouldn’t say I’m a—”

“Adora,” Bow crossed his arms, “you’re the poster child of the volleyball team. You are literally on the season calendar posters.”

I sighed. “Why didn’t anyone tell me about this?”

“Coach has mentioned it at every practice for the last month.” Bow cocked his head. “You have a hard time paying attention unless you're moving, huh?”

I narrowed my eyes at him and threw my bag over my shoulder. “Don’t psychoanalyze me.” I sighed. “What time is this ‘masquerade’?”

“Seven,” Glimmer linked her hands under her chin. “And it’s black tie. Do you have a nice dress?”

I groaned, dragging my fingernails down my face. “No! Why would I have that?”

“I have six,” Glimmer said, like it was some kind of accomplishment. Then Bow put a hand on her shoulder.

“Do you have a suit, Adora?”

I shook my head. “No. Always wanted to get one, never really put in the effort.”

Glimmer sighed, straightened in her seat, and clapped her thighs. “Well, we don’t have time for a suit, it would need to be tailored, but we can pull off a nice dress. Bow, tell Coach that Adora might not make it to all of practice.”

My jaw dropped. “I can’t miss practice! We have a game on Wednesday against—”

"Trust me, Juliet is gonna want you ready for this masquerade. There are big donors coming, Adora, *big.* And volleyball is basically what UBM is known for. That and our accounting school…"

I scoffed. "You're on a first-name basis with Coach?"

Glimmer smirked. "Oh, Adora, there's so much we don't know about each other yet."

I looked back at Bow, who was watching Glimmer warily. But he didn't move to stop her or interrupt her scheming.

"Okay…" I murmured, watching as Glimmer's eyes got big and eager. "I guess if it's that important I could go. But I have to run back to my dorm and buy the tickets first. Then I'll meet you at the WILK? In an hour?"

Glimmer was beaming. "Sounds great!"

I took a hesitant step away from the table, watching my new friends anxiously. Then Bow threw up his hand.

"Wait! Question!"

I sighed. "Yes, Bow."

"If you're having this hard a time getting her a gift for your anniversary, what are you gonna do for Christmas?"

Glimmer turned her burning gaze on me and I felt myself blush.

"Christmas is—Christmas is covered."

Glimmer narrowed her eyes. "What are you getting her?"

"Okay! Bye, guys! See you in an hour, Glimmer!" I yelled, running away from our table and out the door.

When I got back to my dorm, I realized that I had gotten a text from Catra while I was at lunch. I opened it eagerly, but immediately deflated when I read it.

Catra 😾 - Hey, Entrapta and Scorpia kinda just showed up. We're hanging out right now, and probably are gonna get dinner. I'll call you when we're done.

I grumbled as I took off my jacket and threw it on the bed. Of course Scorpia and Entrapta got to hang out with her on her birthday. Sure! That was fine!

Entrapta could've gone anywhere, but Fright City Tech had the best science programs, and it wasn't even a day's drive from Thaymor. Maybe a little longer on the train Entrapta probably took, but she would do it without a second thought if someone told her it was important to Catra. And Scorpia, who probably would've moved mountains to see Catra on her birthday, was even closer at University of Elberon. Literally, just a town away.

And it wasn't that I was jealous. Or bitter. But dammit, I wanted to be there. I wanted to see Catra's face as she walked into her new apartment for the first time. I wanted to hear her laugh when Razz made some weird comment about Adam's hair and legs being too short for his mouth. I wanted to take her grocery shopping and help her choose new appliances like a toaster. And I wanted to kiss her goodnight on her new front step. Or kiss her so much she just let me stay.

I wanted to move mountains for Catra.

But I was stuck in Bright Moon.

Bright Moon… right where everyone else wanted me to be.

But I wanted to go home.

I sat down at my desk and pulled out my laptop. "Well," I breathed, typing "The Horde tickets" into the search bar, "maybe I can move *one* mountain."

“I look ridiculous.”

“I styled you,” Glimmer said, waving her hand, “so that’s impossible.”

I lifted the skirt of my deep blue dress, then let it drop. “You sure this,” I raised a hand to brush the gold mask she’d somehow convinced me to wear, “matches this?” I twisted one of the curls she’d made in my hair around my finger. I hated wearing it down…

She nodded. Her own mask was pink and purple, lined in silver, and shaped like butterfly wings. “With the gold dusting on the dress and the cape, it matches perfectly.”

I groaned, tracing up the gold feathers along the side of my mask until I reached the top of the tall wing. “I look like a Valkyrie.”

Glimmer beamed. “Exactly. Now you get it!”

“That’s not a good thing!” I hissed, adjusting the mask over my eyes. “And I can barely see in this thing!”

“No one can see,” she said, lifting her mask and scanning the crowd. “That’s part of the fun.”

“I’m not having fun.”

“Once we find Bow,” she stood up on her tiptoes and I crossed my arms, “we’ll all go out and mingle and you’ll have a lot more fun.”

I frowned. “I hate mingling.”

She sighed. “There’s food.” I perked up a little at that. “And dancing…”

My frown returned. “I don’t dance.”

Glimmer grinned, " *I know you can!"* she sang, rocking side to side as she did.

I stared at her as she did. I knew the reference immediately, but (and I couldn't believe I was thinking it) it was not time for High School Musical. It was time to get this night over with.

"You have one hour. That's it." I held up a finger. "One. Then I'm leaving."

Catra had texted me about an hour before, telling me Entrapta and Scorpia were staying for a movie, but that she could talk if I wanted to. I wanted more time than that though, so I told her to go hang out with them and I'd call her when they were done. She said that would probably be around 9:30. So I was planning to call at 10. Scorpia was known for long drawn-out goodbyes.

I knew Catra had work the next day but not until 8, so she wouldn't need to go to bed until about 11:30. An hour and a half. I would get an hour and a half.

I wanted the whole day. Dammit, I wanted forever.

But I could make do with an hour and a half.

And these donors could make do with an hour.

"Oh!" Glimmer jumped and started waving at a man in a dark brown suit and an owl mask, "there's Bow!"

Bow made his way to us and just as he did, a waiter with celery sticks filled with something chicken-y passed. I stopped the waiter, took three of the celery things off the tray, and said, "Bring me three of everything you serve. Cool?"

He nodded, and I turned to Bow and Glimmer. "Okay, let's go."

It was one of the worst moments of my life. And that bar was set pretty high, even back then.

I almost ran out of the banquet hall. When I made it into the bright white hallway, I immediately pressed call, and my eyes searched the wall for the nearest clock.

10:01.

I'd missed it.

I'd *missed* it.

My stomach dropped and a wave of shame fell over me. I'd had one job, all day, one thing that I *needed* to do, and I failed. I completely, totally, utterly failed.

The phone rang and rang, and for a second, I thought she wasn't going to pick up at all.

"Hello?" Catra said, her voice groggy and thick. My guilt doubled. I'd woken her up.

"Hey," I murmured, stepping outside, "Happy Birthday, Babe!"

I heard a rustling on her end of the line. "Adora, my birthday ended three minutes ago. I don't—"

"Not here," I picked at the fabric of my skirt. "I mean… in Bright Moon, it's still your birthday…"

After a second, she chuckled. "Still, cutting it kinda close there, Princess."

I frowned and grabbed a handful of the dress in my fist. "I know. And I'm so sorry. I—"

"It's fine," she yawned. "I get it."

I shook my head, even though she couldn't see me because I'm a giant dork. "No, it's not fine. I should've called you hours ago."

“You had a busy day. I had a busy day.” I could practically see her shrugging. “I understand.”

I furrowed my brow and rubbed the dress between my thumb and finger. “Catra—”

“You texted me,” she said, “and you’re calling now. It’s fine.”

I gave a small nod and let go of the skirt. “Okay…” I took a deep breath and decided to change the subject. “Do you like your present?”

She laughed, loud and full. “I can’t believe you gave me a car!”

I grinned. “A used car! Don’t give us more credit than we deserve.”

“Yeah, but you love that car,” her voice softened, “I don’t wanna take it from you…”

I shook my head, and my loose hair hit me in the face. “No. You have to. Swift Wind deserves more love than Adam can give. I’m trusting you with that.”

She scoffed. “Does that mean I have to call it Swift Wind?”

“ *Him,* ” I reminded her, “and yes, you do.”

“Adora, it’s a car.”

“He’s a valiant steed!”

She snickered, and the sound filled me up more than anything else ever could.

“I got you something else,” I muttered, slowly walking toward a bench that sat outside the building. I kicked my legs, letting my skirt fall back down and brush against my legs. Dresses could be kinda cool. Kinda.

“Adora—”

I didn't let her reprimand me. "Did you realize today's our anniversary too?"

"Oh…" I imagined the cute little look on her face and the gentle blush that would fill her cheeks. "Huh. I guess it is."

"So, this is technically an anniversary present. But I got us tickets to go see the Horde."

"Adora!" she squeaked. "You didn't."

I laughed, feeling lighter than I had in days. It was amazing how good Catra made me feel. I'd taken it for granted my whole life. I never would again. "Yes. But, the tickets are for their show in Salineas…"

There was a moment of silence. "How's that supposed to work, Adora?"

I grinned. "I'm glad you asked! Tickets, like plane tickets, to Salineas are always really cheap from Elberon. We can fly down, spend like three days there, and then fly back! It's this summer, so I'll be home. It'll be amazing!"

There was another pause. "Adora—"

"Catra, you never got to go on vacation as a kid. Let me do this for you. Let me show you the world."

She laughed. "Aladdin? Really?"

I grinned. "It's a great song."

"It's fine." She snickered, and I felt warm. Catra warmed me from the inside out. I was outside in a sleeveless dress in October, and I felt toasty.

"So, when are you coming home for Thanksgiving?"

I grimaced and closed my eyes. I knew I was going to have to tell her eventually, sooner rather than later too, but I'd kinda hoped the day would never come.

"I'm… not coming home for Thanksgiving."

"Oh." Catra took a slow and easy breath. "Okay."

"It's just…" I shivered. "UBM only gives us a five day break for Thanksgiving and we have an away game that Tuesday so I couldn't leave 'til Wednesday, which is a full day in the airport, and then I'd have to leave Saturday because I have a game—"

"It's okay, Adora." I heard a rustling and wondered what she was doing. "I get it. It's not worth it."

And that, the way she said that, the way it was worded and the things I felt like it meant… I hated all of it.

"Catra—"

"Hey, I'm really tired," she murmured, yawning just to prove her point. "Lots of shit happened today. Can I call you later?"

Tears formed in the corners of my eyes. "Of course! Sorry for keeping you up."

"It's okay."

"Goodnight," I almost whispered. "I love you."

"Love you too," she said. To this day, I will swear she hesitated.

December 24, 2021

I'm sitting in my car watching Catra's townhome from across the street like a total creep. According to Entrapta, she's "out". When I asked Entrapta if she'd tell her I came by, she said she would, but that she didn't think Catra would do anything with that

information. Instead, she advised that I wait outside in my truck and watch for Catra to come home.

So here I am.

It's been a little over an hour and I'm starting to wonder if coming here at all was a bad idea. For several reasons, one of them being that I'm sitting in my car across the street from my ex-girlfriend's house, (it still hurts to think of her that way), basically stalking her. I knew it was a bad idea the second I thought it. Then Adam told me it was a bad idea. And Glimmer and Bow told me it was a bad idea. Mara said it was basically a suicide mission.

But Razz… Razz said it was good. Razz said it "will heal."

Hope didn't have a comment.

But it isn't going to matter what anyone thinks or doesn't think if Catra never comes home.

I wonder where she is…

Right as the thought pops into my head, a champagne-colored car pulls up the street. I watch, a little surprised, as it pulls into Catra and Entrapta's driveway.

And a feeling of bone-deep warmth washes over me.

I watch her get out of the car and immediately realize something's wrong. Her shoulders are tense, her hair is mussed, and even from this far away, I can tell that her nose is red.

Catra's been crying.

I almost get out of my truck and run across the street, but I hold myself back. I'm probably the last thing Catra wants if she's been crying. Based on the last week, I might even make it worse.

After a minute of her wiping at her eyes with her gloved hands, she reaches into the backseat to pull out a couple of wrapped

boxes and makes her way to the front door. Once she's inside, I sit and I wait. I count to sixty, three times, and then I count to sixty another two times. And theoretically, that's five minutes. I waited a whole five minutes!

I wish someone would be proud of me for that.

I hop out of my truck and cross the icy street. It's like the plows haven't been down this street yet, even though it snowed two days ago. There isn't even salt down…

But Catra and Entrapta's driveway is clear, having obviously been shoveled, or more likely snowblown, and salted. I make my way up and towards the front door.

When I reach the door, I lift my hand to knock and then I freeze. I stare at the door. I don't remember how I gathered the will to knock a few hours ago. It seems so daunting now. Maybe it's because I know Catra's here this time. Or because I know she's upset, which is a variable I didn't plan for. Or because the drive and impulse that sent me to this porch in the first place have completely faded.

Whatever it is, it's there and it's blocking my way.

So I close my eyes and I think about Catra. Just Catra. The way she makes me feel, even when she's angry at me. Because no matter what is going on or happening, Catra makes me *feel.*

And I think about why I came here. I think about how it's been eight years and that's way too long to go without seeing your family.

I knock.

I wait all of three seconds before the door is pulled open to reveal Catra wearing a deep maroon turtleneck sweater, a beautiful Christmas tree covered in rainbow lights and bulbs, and a modest living room where a beautiful black and brown tabby cat stands perched on the coffee table.

I smile. “Hi—”

Catra glowers. “How did you get this address?”

My smile drops and I hesitate. “Don’t be mad, but Adam gave it to me. Could we just—”

Immediately, the door comes flying back towards my face. But I act quickly and throw my foot in the door jamb.

“Fucking traitor! Tell your brother,” Catra yells and she struggles against me to close the door, “that he can go to hell. In fact, every last one of you can!”

“Even Razz?” I grunt. Catra has always been shockingly strong for her frame.

That catches her off guard though and she loses an inch.

“Adora, I will call the cops. I swear to god, I will.”

“Just—I just have one question! Please!” I cry out, the desperation coming through in my voice.

The struggle comes to a standstill.

“What’s your fucking question?”

I take a deep breath and close my eyes. It’s like I can feel Catra on the other side of the door, waiting for me.

But she’ll only wait so long.

“Will you go to the cemetery with me?” I almost whisper, hopeful and needy.

She starts pushing the door again.

“That’s not a fucking question, Grayskull, that’s a *favor* . And there’s no way in hell—”

But I'm not ready to give up yet.

Maybe I'm a selfish asshole, and also now, apparently, a trespasser, but I can't live without Catra anymore. Any capacity I can have her in is better than not at all. And I may be dumb, but I'm not an idiot. Catra has always pushed people away to see who cares enough to fight her on it. I thought I had before, but I was wrong. If I walk away now, I may as well be walking away forever.

And god, I miss my mom and dad so much right now.

"Please, Catra! I haven't seen them in 8 years and…" I take a shaky breath, fighting the very real tears that are pooling in my eyes.

"And whose fault is that?"

"Mine!" I choke out, and her pushing stops again. "I—" my voice is thick and I hate that I sound so weak, "I don't want to go alone."

When she speaks again her voice is softer, almost kind. "Have Mara or Adam go with you."

I shake my head and shake tears onto my cheeks. "Catra, I—I want you to go with me. You've always gone with me. Please. It doesn't have to be today. Just… just think about it?"

After several seconds of silence, Catra growls. "Move. Your. Foot."

So I do. And the door slams in my face.

I stare at the bright rainbow wreath on the front door, and the pieces of the broken heart that I've been carrying around for the last week tremble. I don't know what I expected. I definitely didn't expect to be going to the cemetery today – though I left the entire afternoon open, just in case – but maybe I thought… Maybe I thought I'd have an answer?

"Move. Your. Foot." is probably a no though.

I sigh and turn to head back to my truck.

Then the door is thrown open again and Catra steps out in her coat and boots, with gloves on her hands and one of those earmuff bands wrapped around her head.

“Come on,” she huffs, stepping past me onto the steps, “I’m driving.”

I don’t say a word almost the entire drive to the cemetery. I’m pretty sure I’m going into shock. But I can’t remember the symptoms of shock. I think not talking is one of them. Or is it talking really fast? Maybe it’s talking, but slowly and slurring? No, that's a stroke…

I do look around the car though, and notice how he’s aged. It hurts when I realize that the stickers Catra had so meticulously put on the dashboard are gone. She completely ripped every memory of me out of her life.

And here I was, forcing myself back in.

This was a bad idea.

“I’m sorry,” I murmur. We’re about a block away and if she drops me off here, I can just walk. “I shouldn’t have come over like I did. You can just drop me here and—”

“God, Adora, can you not?” She tightens her grip on the wheel. “I’m coming, okay? End of discussion.”

I nod, and bite back the smile I know shouldn’t be on my face right now.

“I—” she sighs, and I realize that I don’t have to turn my head to look at her because I was already staring, “I usually try to come around Christmas anyway.”

I nod. “Oh.”

She rolls her eyes. “I’m already here, Adora. Just, be normal for once in your goddamn life.”

I nod again. “Okay.”

She sighs and pulls up against the curb just outside the cemetery. “Come on,” she mutters, putting the car in park and turning it off, “let’s go hang out with your dead parents.”

I let my smile out this time. “Okay.”

We make our way to the winding path on the east side of the cemetery and start down it, heading towards the back. That’s where the newer graves are, and even though my parents were buried almost a decade ago, not many people choose Thaymor as their final resting place. We take a left at the first fork and then a right at the next. Then I count to five, and I realize when Catra snickers that I'm literally pointing at the headstones as I count them.

I shove my hand back in my pocket and Catra shakes her head. “Don’t be embarrassed, Princess. It’s just funny.”

“What is?” I ask, my stomach fluttering. She called me Princess.

She shrugs and we come to a stop. “Just… for someone who is so good at finding her way, you sure do get lost easy.”

I bite my lip. Catra ignores my gaze and leans forward to wipe the snow off the top of my parents’ headstone.

“Well, we’re here.” She meets my eyes and, for a second, I’m lost in her jewel-toned gaze. Then she purses her lips. “You gonna apologize?”

I blink. “Oh, um, sure. I just—I thought you didn’t want—”

She rolls her eyes and her entire head. “Not to me, dumbass. To them.”

I turn and look at the shiny black headstone with my parents’ names carved into the rock.

“Oh.”

“Yeah.”

I step forward and put a hand on top of the stone. It’s cold and hard, and nothing like the people it’s supposed to represent. They weren’t smooth and shiny like this, they were rough edges and warm and they glowed.

I read their names again, Randor Adam Grayskull & Marlena Leigh Grayskull. I trace my fingers over the gray letters. And then I read the quote they’d had inscribed.

“How lucky I am to have something that makes saying goodbye so hard.” – A. A. Milne

I wonder, for probably the hundredth time, if a part of them knew they were going to die young. When it came time to plan the funeral, everything was ready, and most of it was paid for. My parents’ will was thorough, covering everything you could possibly think of. Even Catra.

Though she’d fought us every step of the way.

“Why didn’t you go to college?” I ask, turning to look at her.

She crosses her arms. “I did.”

“No, I mean,” I shake my head, “why didn’t you go with me?”

She huffs. “I did not come here to be interrogated, Adora. Just tell your parents you’re sorry you suck and let’s go.”

I frown, but I nod. Then I reach into the inside pocket of my coat and pull out a shovel.

And my medal.

"What the fuck?" Catra cries, watching as I get on my knees and start digging through the snow right at the base of the headstone.

"What?" I grunt, scooping away the snow and clearing enough space so I can actually dig into the ground.

"Adora!" Catra falls to her knees beside me. "Someone will steal that if you leave it here!"

"I know," I huff, pushing her hand away as she tries to take the shovel. "That's why I'm burying it."

"The ground is frozen, idiot!" She almost laughs, and when I look at her she's holding back a smile. "You won't be able to dig deep enough to bury it!"

I frown, looking at the medal in my other hand. "It's… it's not that big."

Now she does laugh. "It's the size of your hand!"

"Nuh-uh." I hold it closer for her to see. "It's only a little bigger than my palm."

She shakes her head. "The ground is still too hard right now."

I hold up my little metal shovel. "But I have this."

She bites back another laugh and my whole body is filling with warmth. "Adora, that shovel is going to get bent out of shape if you try digging with it right now. It's too fucking cold, okay?"

I sigh, falling back from my knees onto my butt. "So I have to wait?"

She nods. "'Til March at least."

I groan and throw my shovel into the snow at my feet. The warmth dissipates and I feel frustrated and cold all over again.

"Great," I huff, lifting my knees and crossing my arms. "I should've just come here right after the stupid games."

Catra stands and brushes off her knees. I can feel her looking at me, and I just wait for her to speak. "And why, exactly, are you trying to bury your Olympic Gold Medal with Marlena and Rand?"

I lift my head. "Why do you think?"

She cocks her head. "Because you're crazy?"

I roll my eyes and lift the medal up towards her face. "This, *this* , I got it for them. You know that."

She blinks a couple times, and glances back at the stone. "Adora, what would you have done if you never got the gold medal?"

I shrug, pulling the medal close and tracing over the finer details with my gloved hand. "I don't know. Come home with whatever I could." I sigh. "I wasn't going to last much longer. I think I could've lived with being a disappointment if…"

If it meant I could've come home.

I look up into Catra's horrified gaze and frown.

"What?"

Slowly, she takes a step toward me, then lowers herself to sit beside me in the snow. "Adora," she whispers, "what on earth makes you think you would be a disappointment if you didn't have a gold medal in your hands right now?"

I swallow and stare straight ahead. I can feel tears in my eyes, and I don't want to look at Catra while I cry. It'll just give me more reason to.

“They did everything for me, Catra.” I shiver and the cold of their absence seeps deeper into my bones. “My mom was at every game. My dad cheered louder than everyone. And they… they *believed* in me. I was “She-Ra” and “future Olympic gold-medalist Adora Grayskull” to all of my parents’ friends. This is what they wanted for me,” I squeeze the medal in my hand, “and I did it. I… I just want to believe I made them proud.”

Catra reaches up, grabbing me by the chin, and turns my head to face her. “Adora…” I shut my teary eyes and try to pull away, but she won’t let go. “Adora, listen to me.”

Finally, I open my eyes and see that Catra’s been crying too.

She moves her hand to cup my cheek and shakes her head. “You idiot,” she whispers, reaching up to hold my other cheek, “Your parents didn’t do those things because they *wanted* you to be a gold medalist. Fuck, they wouldn’t have cared if you played volleyball at all!” She digs her nails into my hairline and it’s grounding. “They did those things because they thought that’s what *you* wanted. They were trying to be supportive.”

I nod my head. “I know that. But I was good, and they had expectations—"

Catra shakes her head. “Do you think your mom and dad bought me guitar and piano books *expecting* me to become a famous musician?”

I frown. “No, but you weren’t—”

“Don’t you dare take away the only parents I ever had who loved me, Adora.”

I shake my head furiously. “That’s not what I meant, Catra. I—”

“Do you really think that love is conditional on things like gold medals and—” She swallows, cutting herself off. “It’s not. When someone loves you, they love you because you’re you. That’s all they want from you, is to be *you* . And maybe, if you’re a greedy

fuck like I know your parents were, they want you to be happy." She sighs. "But they'll love you either way."

I sniff, tears running down my face fast. "Okay. I… okay."

She releases my face and sighs deeply. Then she loops her arm through mine and turns to rest her head on my shoulder.

"Fuck, Adora. I would've told you that years ago if you'd just asked."

A small flare of heat coils in my stomach. *How could I have asked when you never answered any of my texts?*

But she's warm against my arm and I don't want her to let go just yet.

"Can I ask you a question?" I mutter, and the cold, snowy silence of the day almost swallows the sound.

She sighs, "Sure, what the hell."

"Are—" I try to swallow the tears in my throat, "are you happy, Catra?"

She lifts her head and meets my gaze with a burning mismatched one of her own. "As a clam," she murmurs.

Everything inside of me swells and shatters.

"Are you?" she asks, frowning a little.

And I nod, forcing a smile. "Of course," I lie, and wonder if I ever will be again.

Chapter End Notes

Adora has anxiety and will not, I repeat, will not call someone without texting them first. (Except in cases of emergencies.)

Um... hmm... I can't think of anything else I want to say. Just kudos! Comment! However you want to interact with this fic! I'm on twitter & tumblr and all I do all day is hyperfixate on She-Ra. Anyway! Thanks for reading!

Hi, My Name is Catra and I'm an Adoraholic

Chapter Notes

Hello and welcome back to my fic! I would've had this chapter up sooner but I kept putting off writing it because I was too daunted by *shivers* action description. This week's a fun one though, and honestly probably the most fun you're gonna have for a while. A few things -

1. Meijer is a major grocery store chain in the midwest. Imagine if a Walmart had a baby with Kroger/Ralph's/Smith's/Fred Meyer.

2. She-Ra the Princess of Power, the 1980s children's television program, exists in this universe, but for our purposes the only names that are the same are Catra, Adora, and Adam.

3. There is a ring mentioned in this chapter. This is a picture of it. https://dealcrafty.myshoplaza.com/products/latest-creative-crown-925-silver-natural-white-sapphire-diamond-ring-elegant-princess-engagement-wedding-ring-anniversary-gift-birthday-banquet-jewelry-size-us5-12?variant=ea52edf3-4e9d-42ba-9dc3-7785c4f9d5a8&epik=dj0yJnU9UnM1UURYeTU3R3AydHpQNl9pb1NyWTkxdjRSeVdWMlMmcD0wJm49ejdUT2xUbmgyeTNOTXJIbXRsSm9QZyZ0PUFBQUFBR09xTDM4

And that should be all of it! Thank you for reading. I really appreciate your continued interest in this fic. I hope I can continue to give you a story you'll enjoy.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra

"Growing apart doesn't change the fact that for a long time we grew side by side; our roots will always be tangled. I'm glad for

that." – Ally Condie

December 21, 2013

When I heard the knock at my door, I was sure it was Scorpia. I've known Adora my entire life, and she has knocked with the same three little taps that entire time, but I still thought it was Scorpia.

Perfuma would probably say that means something.

But when I opened my door, there was Adora, smiling her thousand-and-one watt smile, wearing her old beanie, gloves, and ratty coat, with her long blonde hair in a braid.

"Hey!" she said, throwing her arms wide and stepping forward to swallow me in a gut-wrenching hug. She tucked her nose into the crook of my neck and pulled me as close as she possibly could. Then she breathed in, rubbing her hand over my lower back. "I've missed you so much."

I stood there, kinda frozen, staring straight ahead. I didn't have a thought in my head, and after a second, she seemed to notice.

She pulled back but kept her hands on my waist. "Are you okay?" she asked, a frown wrinkling her perfect mouth that I hadn't kissed in months. And then that was all I could think about – that I hadn't seen her, held her, kissed her, or even touched her in months. It was like a drumbeat in my brain, shaking me to my core.

"Yeah," I breathed, finally forcing some sort of smile, "I just… I was kind of expecting someone else?"

Her brow furrowed. "I told you I'd be home today…"

And she had. She'd told me weeks before. But I was kind of hoping she wouldn't come home at all.

“Yeah, but…” I trailed off, looking her over. I grabbed at the strap flung over her shoulder and glanced out the window. It was still early. Very early.

“Did you come straight here from the airport?”

She blushed a little bit, squeezing my hips. “I—maybe…”

“Adora!” I groaned, ignoring the fluttering in my stomach. “You didn’t even say ‘hi’ to Razz?”

She shrugged, looking down at the floor. “I made Adam drop me off. I figured…” she blushed, “you could go home with me.”

I bit my lip. I knew what I should’ve done. I should’ve told Adora that Scorpia was coming over and we were going to the park to see the ice sculpture trail unveiling that morning. I should’ve pulled myself out of her reach, told her that I’d give her a ride home, and that I’d see her later. I should’ve given myself space to breathe.

But she was there, and she was smiling like I hung the stars or some shit. She’d come home just like she said she would.

So, instead of all the stuff I should’ve done, I wrapped my arms around her neck. “Okay,” I whispered, and her smile just grew. Then she leaned forward and kissed me square on the mouth.

For a second, I let myself forget that she was leaving in two weeks. I let myself kiss her like I would get to do it every day for the rest of my life. I wrapped my arms tighter, pulled her in closer, and broke the promise I’d made almost a year before.

I was supposed to let Adora go, but I was holding her tighter than I ever had before.

That day, I texted Scorpia and told her that Adora had surprised me and asked if we could reschedule. She was willing, obviously,

and even said Adora could come along. So after the festival's opening ceremonies that evening, Scorpia, Adora, and I went to see the ice sculptures in the park. I stole Adora's hat off her head when my ears got cold and she kept shoving her hand in my gloves.

The next night, Adora wanted to see the candy windows. The night after that, she wanted to go ice skating. And then it was Christmas Eve, which meant baking with Razz, going to see a movie at the local theater, sharing a giant tub of popcorn with Adam and Adora for dinner, and a brand-new pair of pajamas.

I'd always been reluctant to spend Christmas Eve with the Grayskulls – I wasn't their kid, why would Marlena and Randor want to deal with me? – but every year, whether I came over that night or not, there was a pair of pjs for me. I couldn't escape them.

That year, Adam, Adora, and I all got matching red gingham. Adam was the one who made us all put them on for a picture.

That was the first year though that I actually got to spend the night on Christmas Eve. Before, Shannon had always dragged me home because "Christmas was supposed to be spent with family."

Which was stupid. It wasn't like we had any traditions, unless you count her getting black-out drunk and falling asleep watching *It's a Wonderful Life* on TV as a tradition. And every morning I'd wake up to exactly one gift under the tree. Usually some toy or memorabilia aimed at a kid about four years younger than me – like a Hannah Montana singing microphone when I was 15. But, honestly, I was pathetically grateful to get a gift from her at all.

But that year I spent the night in Adora's arms.

The next morning Adora woke up at about 6 am, because apparently the fact that we'd stayed up 'til two watching *A Christmas Story* the night before meant nothing. She dragged me out of bed and then ran into Adam's room.

“Adam!” I could hear her from the fucking hallway. “Wake up!”

“Are you fucking kidding me, ‘Dor?” Adam’s voice was a little quieter and angrier. “How early is it?”

“It’s Christmas! Time is meaningless. Get up!”

After about ten minutes, Adora had everyone gathered in the living room. Then she pulled on a Santa hat.

“Wait a second,” Mara arched a brow, “you get to be Santa?”

Adora gave a firm nod. “Adam was Santa last year. It’s my turn.”

“When do I get to be Santa?” Mara asked, sticking out her lower lip.

“Never,” Adam said, yawning as he did. “You are not a direct descendant of the original Santa, so you can’t wear the hat.”

I rolled my neck and closed my eyes. “What the hell? What do you mean ‘be Santa’?”

Razz chuckled. “Randor used to wear a Santa hat and pass out the presents under the tree one at a time. He was such a funny man.”

I smiled a little and looked over at Adora who was wearing what I guessed was the same Santa hat like it was a crown. “Okay, fair enough. Proceed.”

Adora started handing out presents, starting with Adam and cycling through us all, one by one until we’d gotten through all the gifts under the tree.

Every time she handed me a gift, I would shoot a death glare at whatever member of the family it said it was from, but they’d just smile back at me. For the two gifts that I got labeled “from Santa,” I just glared at Adora.

“I don’t know why you’re mad at me! I’m not Santa!”

“Didn’t we just establish that you are?”

Soon everyone was drowning in presents, sifting through them and the contents of their stockings. And it was nice. It was the nicest Christmas morning I’d ever had.

“Well, Mom,” Mara clapped her legs, “you ready to go make breakfast?”

Razz adjusted her glasses and tightened the new shawl Adam had gotten her. “My name is Madame Razz, not *Mom* .”

Mara rolled her eyes and stood up, nudging Razz with her elbow as she did. “Come on, *Madame Razz* . Let’s go whip up some waffles.”

They left and Adam shot a glance at Adora. I narrowed my eyes as she gave him a little nod and he stood up. He stretched his arms over his head and yawned again.

“Wake me up when breakfast is ready, yeah?”

“Seriously?” I scoffed, but Adora just nodded.

“Yup! Can do! See you in a little.”

I arched an eyebrow and Adam left the room.

Adora was fidgeting. She was tapping her knees with the tips of her fingers and looking anywhere but directly at me.

“Adora…”

She met my gaze and forced a smile. “Yeah?”

“What’s going on?”

She grinned a little more genuinely and reached into the tree. She pulled out a small, beautifully wrapped box and held it carefully in

both hands. “Oh look! I missed one!”

I sighed. “Adora.”

“It’s for you!”

I rolled my head and scratched at the crown. “Adora, you really—”

“I haven’t given you one yet.” I looked up to see she was frowning. “Didn’t you notice that?”

I laughed a little. “Weren’t you Santa?”

She scoffed. “‘Santa’ is Mom and Dad’s life insurance. Mara and Razz picked those gifts out. I mean, I helped, but they weren’t *from* me.”

I blinked. “You—I—why are you spending—”

“Stop it, Catra.” She sighed, standing up to cross the room. “It’s mine and Adam’s money and we can spend it however we want to. And I know how my parents would’ve wanted me to spend it.”

I swallowed, and she came and sat down next to me. She placed the small present in my lap. “Now can you just open this and be grateful?”

I bit the inside of my lower lip, but I nodded and went to pull at the ribbon on the package.

“You did a good job wrapping,” I murmured.

Adora chuckled and I pulled away the paper to reveal a small, blue leather box. “Thanks! Adam may’ve tied the ribbon though. He’s annoyingly good at that stuff.”

I laughed and opened the box. Inside was another box. A ring box.

It was red velvet, and I stroked my finger over the lid.

"Breathe," Adora whispered, and I did as she said. "It's not an engagement ring."

I laughed out loud and met her smiling eyes. "I didn't think that!"

"Liar."

I shook my head and reached for the seam where the ring box opened. "I didn't, but I did think—"

Then I opened the box, and my thoughts just kind of disappeared.

Inside was a ring, a ring in the shape of a crown. Well, a tiara really, but it was beautiful, covered in little shiny clear stones with looping curves and edges.

After a second of silence, Adora started talking.

"It's sterling silver and cubic zirconia, so it wasn't expensive. Okay, that's not true. It's white sapphire, so it was a little expensive. Gah, I learned how to pronounce cubic zirconia just for this and I couldn't even follow through with it. But I've been saving for it for a long time so don't worry! Please," she grabbed my hand, "just… don't worry."

"Adora," I swallowed, "it's—"

"I know, like, I'm the princess or whatever, so it doesn't make a ton of sense for you to be wearing the crown. But it's kinda like in High School Musical 2 when Troy gets Gabriella that necklace with a 'T' on it. Which, I know is kinda lame, but I thought this was less lame. And I have a better reason than he did so—"

I squeezed her hand, and she finally met my eyes. "What reason?"

She grimaced. "It's so you don't forget me. So, you remember our promise…"

I cracked a small smile. "So it's a promise ring?"

She dropped my hand and covered her face with both of hers. "Gah, I'm sorry. It's a lot. I shouldn't have—"

"I love it," I breathed, and she immediately lifted her head.

"You do?"

I nodded, smiling.

She perked up and scoffed. "I mean, of course you do. It's a great gift."

I grabbed her by the chin. "Don't push it."

Her smile softened and she wrapped her hand around my face. "I love you."

"I love you too."

And then I kissed her for everything I was worth. After she put the ring on my finger, I wore it every day for the next six months.

And I still wear it, every day, on a chain around my neck.

January 1, 2014

A week later, Adora was dropping me off after the New Year's Gala. It was funny; going as an alumnus rather than a student wasn't as weird as I'd thought it'd be. All our friends were still there, and it was still a great party. But this year when they announced Snow King and Queen, Adam and Adora didn't have to worry about dead parents securing their place.

Didn't mean they were safe or anything…

A little after midnight, right before I was going to ask Adora if we could leave, the DJ decided to play REO Speedwagon's "Keep On Loving You", and Adora, who'd been standing by the snack table talking to Lonnie about picking a major, burst into tears.

And then I was lost in a memory of Randor Grayskull singing along to the very same song on the radio with his booming deep voice driving all of us to the waterpark.

“A classic,” he’d said. “Probably my favorite song.”

“Yeah,” Adora had sighed, “we know.”

I walked up to Adora and wrapped my arms around her. “Do you want to go home?” I whispered, placing a kiss on her forehead.

She buried her head in my shoulder and nodded. I fished through my pocket, pulled out my phone, sent a quick text to Adam, who was probably having a breakdown of his own somewhere, and then ushered Adora out to the car.

When I got an all-clear text from Adam, he was with Sea Hawk and Duncan and was gonna get a ride home with them, I drove us home. Well… I drove us to my place.

I pulled into the parking lot of my apartment complex, parking Mara’s car in one of the visitor parking spots.

“You don’t have to walk me up,” I said, hoping she would contradict me. It was a selfish hope, but I had it anyway.

“No,” she shook her head. “I’m gonna.”

“Adora—”

“I’m going to spend as much time with you as possible, Catra,” she said, opening the car door and shooting me a serious look with her red-rimmed eyes.

My stomach fluttered.

For a second I just sat in my seat, until Adora rounded the front of the car and opened my door for me. I took a deep breath and stood, handing her the keys.

“I could’ve done that, ya know?”

She shrugged, smiling a little for the first time in what felt like hours. “Yeah, but you don’t always have to.”

I rolled my eyes and led the way to the stairs.

By the time we were on my landing, I was sure. I was going to kiss Adora goodnight and then I was going to send her home. She’d had a rough night, or a rough hour, and she didn’t need me pushing for anything right now.

But I was very aware that I was running out of time.

I’d decided before Adora had come to pick me up that night that I was finally gonna do it. I was gonna ask Adora about sex. We’d barely ever talked about it before, other than establishing that yes – we both wanted to have sex, and we wanted to have it with each other, eventually. But I was ready. I’d probably been ready for a while. But something had been holding me back.

Whatever it was, it wasn't holding me back anymore, and I was at least going to start the conversation.

Or… I was. Until Adora heard her dad’s favorite song at a New Year’s Eve Gala and had a breakdown in front of all of our friends from high school.

But if I didn’t do it that night, I wasn’t sure I’d have the chance again.

I think there was a part of me that thought if I could get Adora to have sex with me, maybe she wouldn’t leave again. Or maybe I just wanted as much of her as I could get before I lost her forever. I don’t know. But I knew I was running out of time.

When we reached my door, I pulled my keys out of my pocket and unlocked it. Then I turned around and gave Adora my softest smile.

“Thanks for going with me, Adora. I had a great time.” I grimaced. “I’m sorry it ended the way it did, obviously… but other than that—”

She laughed. “Why are you talking like this is our first date and we’re not gonna have another?”

I frowned. “I am not.”

She reached out for me, pulling me close by the lapels of my coat. “Yeah, you are. But it’s kinda cute.” She leaned in and kissed me gently on the mouth.

I pulled back. “I am not cute.”

She grinned even wider. “You’re so cute. You’re the cutest.” She leaned in, kissing me again. And I let her. I even kissed her back.

Without realizing it, I grabbed on to her coat. But I broke the kiss and murmured, “Stop calling me cute or you’re cut off.”

“From what?”

“This.”

Then I leaned back in and kissed her hard. And when her lips parted, I licked into her mouth.

Panting, she said, “You’re not cute. You’re very intimidating, and scary.”

“There ya go.”

The kiss got hotter and hotter until Adora had me pressed against the door jamb and a hand at the collar of my button-up.

I took a deep breath, filling my lungs with long-forgotten air. “You have to go,” I sighed, and Adora whined.

“Let me stay?”

And I did.

December 24, 2021

"Why are we at Meijer?" Adora frowns, looking up from her lap where she's been messing with her phone for the last five minutes. She's been silent since the cemetery, and I can't stand it anymore.

But why are we at Meijer? That is a great question.

Why the fuck are we at Meijer?

"I'm out of milk," I say, almost on instinct, throwing my door open and climbing out into the parking lot.

Adora leans over. "Do you want me to wait in the car?"

I cock my head to the side. "Do you want to wait in the car?"

She pouts a little and shakes her head the tiniest bit. "No."

"Then don't wait in the car. Fuck, Adora. You're an adult. You can't let what I think dictate every decision you make."

She glares at me but leans back and pushes her door open. "I do not do that."

I arch an eyebrow and watch as she moves to stand beside me. "Right. Let me rephrase – you can't let what *other people* think dictate every decision you make."

She winces and we start for the front doors. "I think I liked the first one more."

I snicker, and when I look back at her I see a soft smile on her face.

"Hey," I snap my fingers, "no. None of that."

“None of what?” she cries, but the smile that hasn’t left her dumb face tells me she knows exactly what I’m talking about.

“You don’t get to look at me like that.” I cross my arms over my chest.

“I’m an adult,” she says, and even though I’m not looking at her face, I can just picture the smug little smile on it, “I can make my own decisions about who I look at and how.”

I huff and wave at the greeter as we pass through the doors. “Whatever. Go find yourself some snacks and meet me at the registers in five minutes.” I hold up my hand. “Five minutes, Adora. That’s how long you have to decide.”

She pouts again. “What’s that supposed to mean?”

“It means I’ve seen you spend twenty minutes trying to decide between two different types of potato chips before.”

She bites back a smile, like she can’t believe I remember that. Which is stupid. Of course I remember that. Adora was my entire world for over a decade. If I let go of those memories, good or bad, I’d have none left.

“Got it,” Adora says, giving me a little salute, “five minutes.” She turns on her heel and walks toward the snack aisle.

And I head back towards dairy.

On the way I pass the liquor, and I make a slight detour.

“So…” Adora is looking at me with bright eyes, like a little puppy who’s finally being given attention, “you bought Kahlua.”

I glance at her out of the corner of my eye. We’re driving back to my place now, and Adora’s got a grocery bag full of snacks in her lap. When I gave her a hard time for grabbing gummy bears,

chips, Gatorade, and a pack of Reese's, she just sighed and said, "I couldn't pick, so I decided to grab them all."

When I went to pay for them though, she felt bad. I said, "I yelled at you in a cemetery. Consider it penance." But I knew part of the reason she didn't see me go to pay until too late was because she'd been so caught up in trying to figure out why I'd bought the worst liqueur of all time.

"Yeah," I reply, "and?"

"You hate Kahlua," she says, like she's certain. Like she has a right to be.

I roll my eyes. "You can't know that."

"You said it was an affront to coffee. And alcohol," she says, and she's smug again.

I know I have to shut this down quick, and I know there's only one way I can. I just wish I didn't have to hurt her.

"Yeah, well… people change."

She's silent after that.

Once we're back at my place, Adora climbs out of the car. She gives me a tight-lipped smile. "Thank you," she mutters, so quiet I can barely hear her, "for going with me. And… for what you said. I think… I think I needed to hear it." She laughs, but it's sad and strained. "Anyway. I'll see you around."

I sigh as she turns to walk towards her truck. "Wait."

She stops in her tracks and glances back. There's something anxious but almost hopeful in her eyes.

And goddamn I'm such an idiot for rewarding it.

"Come inside."

She turns back to me, sticking her hands in her pockets. “Catra, I don’t—”

“Just…” I take a deep breath, “come in. Unless you really don’t want to. Your choice.”

I turn and head to the front door. After about two seconds, I hear Adora follow after me.

Adora’s sitting on the couch, watching as I set the milk and Kahlua down on the kitchen island, and reach into the cupboard for a couple of glasses.

“What are you doing?” she asks, watching me pull out a shot glass and fill the tumblers with ice.

“Take a guess, Princess.”

She smiles at me, and it’s soft. Too soft. Dangerously soft.

I look down at my hands and grab the bottle of vodka I keep on the counter. I pour Kahlua, vodka, and milk into one of the glasses, then give it a quick stir with a knife. I look up again and Adora’s staring at the Christmas tree.

I wonder what she sees when she looks at it. Does she notice how none of the ornaments are homemade? Does she wonder what happened to every ornament I ever brought home from school and gave to my mother that didn’t end up on our Christmas tree?

I do.

I shake my head and turn around. I put the milk in the fridge and grab the bottle of grape juice from inside. I pour a… well a lot of vodka into the second glass, then add a splash of grape juice on top.

I lift my head and see Adora staring at me again. When our eyes meet, her face flushes, and my stomach does a little flip.

This is a bad idea. This is *such* a bad idea. And I know it. I walk over to the couch and hold the White Russian out to Adora. "Drink this."

She takes it from my hand and smirks. "You're bossy when you're tense."

I narrow my eyes. "I am not tense."

She nods, and puts the glass to her mouth, taking a long sip. "Mhmm."

I roll my eyes and walk around the couch. I fall into the seat next to her. Probably too close.

Definitely too close.

"You're insufferable."

She smiles.

I reach for the coffee table and grab the remote off the top. "We're just gonna watch some TV and drink in silence, okay? Can you handle that?"

She doesn't respond right away, and when I turn to look at her, she's tracing her finger over a scratch in her glass and frowning.

"Can I ask you something?"

I sigh. "Can I stop you?"

She looks up and her gaze is burning. "What happened, Catra?"

And I don't know what to say. So, I don't say anything.

"You said you wanted space but…" she swallows, "but then in town the other day, you were lecturing me like—like…" She shakes

her head. “Catra, you didn’t even answer my texts and that wasn’t something—”

“What texts?” I ask, straightening in my seat.

Adora looks confused, and more than a little annoyed. “What do you mean what texts?”

I furrow my brow. “I never got any texts.”

She scoffs and reaches out to set her glass on the table. “Catra,” she brushes her hand through the little wisps of hair that have fallen out of her ponytail, “I sent you a text every year on Christmas, and your birthday, and sometimes just to tell you—” she groans, and her cheeks are painted red with a blush.

I reach into my pocket and pull out my phone. I’m frowning and confused. I don’t know how she can possibly be right. I haven’t changed my number since high school. I only got a new phone a year ago and the guys at the phone store had a hell of a time transferring all my stuff over. But they did it, they promised me they did it.

I type Adora’s name into the search bar of my messages, but nothing comes up. Because I haven’t gotten any texts.

“Adora,” I hold my phone out to her, “I haven’t gotten a text from you in 8 years.”

Adora takes the phone from my hand and taps at it with her finger. The faint blue light reflects off her face and I can see every line in it, all the lines that time has carved…

“Catra… you blocked me.”

“What?” I cry, grabbing my phone out of Adora’s hands. I run my eyes over the screen. At the top it says “Blocked Contacts” and underneath is a list of four numbers. Two of them I don’t recognize. One is my mom’s old cell phone, and the other is… Adora’s.

And now Adora's laughing. She's laughing but it's not funny, and she obviously doesn't think it is. It's one of those dark, cynical laughs. The kind that's almost hysterical and broken.

"Oh my god."

I almost flinch. "Adora, I swear—"

"I called you," she says, and her eyes are on fire, burning blue and hot like the center of a flame, "Every night that first week. You never answered. I thought 'Oh, maybe *talking* falls under this whole not seeing each other thing.' So, I texted you. But you never responded to those. So I stalked your Instagram and Facebook, like some pathetic…" she shakes her head, "looking for some sort of sign that something was wrong. But everything seemed normal! You were fine. And because I'm a fucking *idiot!* " she yells the word, like it's the worst thing you can be. "I figured, 'Well she's getting my texts, she knows I'm thinking about her.' But you weren't."

She swallows and there are tears in her eyes. "You ran away from me, and—"

--and I can't take it anymore.

"I was breaking up with you."

She blinks, and a single tear runs down her cheek. I want to reach out and wipe it away, but my phone's still in my hand and I don't think I should touch her right now.

Or ever again.

"What?"

I take a deep breath and set my phone on the coffee table. "When you said, 'don't see each other,' and I agreed, I meant it like… like I was breaking up with you."

She's quiet. I watch as her tears disappear, her body deflates, and I feel sick.

"Oh."

"I'm…" I put my hand to my chest and press the ring on my necklace until it bites my skin. I wish I had something better to say, something better I could do. "I'm sorry."

But who cares? Why should she?

"I'm…" she breathes in, "I'm such an idiot."

There's that word again. But this time it's softer.

"Yeah," I sigh, "you are."

She laughs, and the sound makes me feel whole again.

I could ask her about it – how in the hell she thought the girl who never texted her back was still her girlfriend – but I'm not going to. I'm not going to dig the knife deeper.

"I never wanted to hurt you," I say, and she hesitantly meets my gaze. "And I hate that I did it twice."

She shakes her head. "It's fine, Catra. That's the risk, right?"

I force a smile and it feels like my teeth are going to break.

She gasps, straightening. "Wait, so you never got the Horde tickets?"

My brow furrows. "The what?"

"The Horde tickets." She frowns, her lower lip sticking out to make it all pouty. "I texted them to you. I also texted you our flight information. Or, well, your flight since I refunded my ticket but—I wanted you to go."

I grimace and my stomach drops. "Shit…"

The look in her eyes is so sad.

“You didn’t go to Salineas?”

“No,” I whisper and it’s like the last shred of hope she had is gone.

She leans back into the couch and stares at the menu that’s popped up on the tv. For a second she’s silent, and when she finally looks at me again, I feel like I hold the fate of the world in my hands.

“Why did you block my number?”

I bite my lower lip, and I choose honesty. Well, mostly.

“I don’t know. I must’ve done it the night we—I thought we broke up. I got… pretty drunk.”

She nods, then sits up and reaches for her glass on the coffee table. “I’d like to do that right now.”

I nod too and pick up the remote again. “She-Ra drinking game it is.”

“For the honor of Grayskull!”

I hold up my glass. “Drink!”

Adora laughs and lifts her drink to her mouth. It’s been about an hour and a half and she’s two drinks in. She downs the last of what’s in her cup and holds it out to me.

“Catra…” she whines, and there’s laughter in her voice, “I need a refill.”

I scoff, pushing her hand and her glass out of my face. “Get it yourself.”

"But you make them so good!" she pouts, leaning into my shoulder.

And this is a bad idea. I know it's a bad idea. But I can't seem to stop myself when I look at her face and see her smiling like she is.

I stand up and take Adora's empty glass. "Fine."

"Yay!" she claps her hands and beams at me as I walk back to the kitchen to make her drink.

I listen to the tv in the background and snicker when She-Ra turns back into mild-mannered Adora and her voice goes all wonky.

"I can't believe your parents named you and Adam after this garbage show."

"Hey!" Adora turns her head to glare at me as I walk back to the couch with her drink in my hand, "I named *you* after this 'garbage show'. Have some respect."

I sit back down next to her and sigh, handing her the drink and remembering the day she found me at recess, crying underneath a tiny tree, and decided I was going to be her best friend.

"Your name's Catrina! That's so cool! It's like Catra! Do you know who that is? She's this bad guy on this show that my parents watched when they were kids and my brother and I—"

She went on for about ten minutes, explaining the finer plot points, and asking if I wanted to come watch it at her house after school sometime. She also asked if she could call me Catra.

"She's my favorite character. She's a person but she talks like a cat. I love cats. Do you have a cat?"

"I actually forget my real name all the time now," I mutter, running my finger over the rim of my glass.

Adora gives me a funny look. “You mean Catrina?”

I nod. “My mom was the only one to ever call me that.” I shake my head. “Sometimes I feel bad that I don't use it.”

Adora furrows her brow. “Why?”

I shrug, and it’s like there’s a loud crack that reverberates in my ears. I can’t hear the show anymore. I can just hear the violent beating of my heart.

“It’s all I really have left of her.”

I wait for Adora to get confused, to ask who I’m talking about. Everyone else would’ve had to ask. But Adora knows, without having to try, she knows.

My name is all I have left of my real mom.

“Oh,” Adora breathes. “Yeah…”

I bite my lip. My heart’s been cracked open by this tiny confession, and I want to spill more of it out onto the floor in front of us. I want to pour all of it into Adora’s lap and let her have her way with it again.

But I can’t.

Adora’s not the only idiot here though.

“Her name was Elizabeth,” I whisper, stomach rolling. “I found out… recently.”

Adora’s brow furrows. “How?”

I almost laugh and roll my eyes. But when I meet Adora’s gaze again I can’t. “If I tell you something,” I grimace, “do you promise not to freak out?”

She nods and I take a deep breath. Adora puts her drink on the coffee table and turns a little to face me. I wish she wouldn’t do

that.

But she does and I'd be lying if I said it doesn't make me feel special.

"Shannon has Alzheimer's," I murmur, and listen for Adora's sharp intake of breath. There isn't one. "She's living at Heart Blossom right now. And, well, when she was diagnosed, the doctors reached out to me." I scoff. "The bitch has me listed as her emergency contact. Well, there was this whole thing where they asked about her medical history, and the doctor said that according to his records, her sister died of heart disease. Which confused the hell out of me because since when did she have a sister…"

She's quiet, and when I glance at her out of the corner of my eye her expression is so soft it turns my stomach.

"Catra—"

I laugh."Turns out, she did! And her name was Elizabeth. And she died from heart disease 8 months after giving birth to me." I scoff and shake my head. "I just… I'm tired, Adora. Legally I'm responsible for her. And I wish I could just… not care about that like she did all my fuckin' life but I *can't.*" I swallow. "I… I don't know how."

"Catra—"

"I went to visit her this morning," I confess, like it's some sin and Adora's a priest. "That's where I was before you came over. And…" I take a shaky breath, "she didn't recognize me. But she's been asking about my mom." I don't realize I'm crying until I choke on the words as they come out of my mouth. "It's not fair," I whimper. "It's like I don't matter, like I never mattered…

"She blamed me for killing her sister. I know she did. She told me that I would ruin you and Adam and that every dollar Randor and Marlena spent on me was a waste. She told me all I do is take. So…" I close my eyes to cut off the tears, "why do I care? Why am

I paying for a nice nursing home? Why am I taking her daisies on Christmas Eve? Why does it *hurt* that she doesn't remember me anymore?"

My breathing is hard and I'm shaking, but when Adora puts her hand on my cheek, I open my eyes and still.

"Because you're her daughter," Adora whispers, "and she was supposed to love you."

I break. Sobs rack my body and I lean into Adora's touch. She cups my face with both hands and lets me cry.

"It's okay that it hurts," she says, her voice the gentlest sound in the world. "But Catra," she lifts my head, forcing me to meet her eyes and stare her total earnestness down like the barrel of a gun, "she was wrong. She shouldn't have treated you the way she did, and you deserve so much more than what she gave you."

Her thumb strokes over my cheek. "If I have to spend the rest of our lives telling you this, I will – you matter. You're everything. And I'm so blessed to have had you in my life."

What am I supposed to say to that? There's nothing good enough, no apology or love letter that I could write would ever tell her how much her words… how much *she* means to me. So I only have one choice.

I kiss her.

Chapter End Notes

So... yeah.

The drink Catra made herself is a lil invention of mine because I project onto Catra and think vodka is the best of all the alcohols. It's just vodka and grape juice, whatever proportions you feel in your heart. I call it a wrench because I think I'm funny.

Anyway! That's all! I'll have another update soon.

I Would Rather Burn

Chapter Notes

> So, I think this might be the angstiest chapter in the entire fic. And that is all I am going to tell you. Have fun!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora

"Never say goodbye because goodbye means going away and going away means forgetting." - J.M. Barrie

January 1, 2014

It was so early that the world outside looked blue, but it was light enough that I could see Catra in my arms.

She had her head on my chest and her legs were tangled up with mine. I had one hand wrapped around her waist and the other tangled in her short hair. She was breathing slowly and holding onto me like I was a life raft.

And I had never felt more at peace in my entire life.

I pulled my fingers through her hair gently, trying not to wake her. I wanted to live in that moment. I wanted to stay there forever. I wanted Catra's naked skin against mine, warming me from head to toe 'til I died.

She was so warm, she was basically a furnace, and for a minute, I thought I would never be cold again.

But I ruined it. My damn fidgety hands ruined everything.

Catra stirred, turning her head so that her lips brushed against my bare skin. And yeah, maybe ruined was the wrong word.

She lifted her head and blinked her eyes open, squinting at me a little, and then the softest smile I'd ever seen took over her face.

"Hey, Adora."

I tightened my embrace, squeezing her closer. "Hey, Catra."

Then she giggled, dropping her head, and the sound tinkled like bells. My whole body tingled from the rush of warmth that coursed through me and I decided that was even better. Catra smiling at me, laughing with me while I held her was the best thing in the entire world.

"I missed you so much," I murmured.

And Catra frowned, just a tiny little frown, but it felt wrong in this warm, glowy moment. Then she reached up, put a hand on my cheek, and ran her thumb over my skin. "I missed you too."

I thought about that for a second – about going back to missing Catra. I thought about how school days felt so long, and volleyball was joyless now. Sure, I had friends, I had classes I liked and I had a goal, and those things sustained me. But surviving is not the same as thriving.

I didn't want to go back. I wanted to stay there, in that bed, in the blue light, warm, forever.

But Catra was what made the bed warm, and the blue light beautiful. Catra was what made Thaymor my home.

I'd promised her I'd follow her anywhere, and I wanted to.

Maybe… maybe she'd be willing to follow me.

"Come with me," I said, the words slipping out before I really thought them through. But as they sat there in the silence that followed, I became certain.

“What?” Catra whispered, and I realized she was stiff, but I just figured I’d startled her.

It was so obvious; this was the solution. How had I not seen it before? Catra didn’t belong here, alone, in Thaymor. She belonged with me, and she belonged in a big city where she could pursue her dreams. Bright Moon was a big city, even bigger than FZC. Bright Moon was where great musicians were discovered.

Bright Moon was waiting for Catra, and I could get her there.

“Come with me. To Bright Moon.” I smiled, leaning forward to bump my forehead against hers. “Please.”

Catra was stock-still in my arms and I noticed, but it was fine. She was scared, but she wouldn’t be. Not when she realized like I had that it was the perfect plan.

“We’ll get a place off campus,” I started, squeezing her waist. “Lots of people live off campus. There’s a ton of apartment complexes in the area and—”

“Adora,” she cut me off. “I can’t afford a place in Bright Moon. I can barely afford this dump.”

I shook my head and laughed. “Oh my god.” I kissed the top of her head. “It’s always about money with you.”

She pulled away from me, scowling a little. “Yeah, well, money is something you have to think about when you’re renting an apartment.”

I sighed, brushing my fingers through her hair again. “I have a scholarship and my parent’s life insurance. And I’ll apply for loans. You wouldn’t be doing it alone, Catra.” I reached up, kissing the side of her mouth. “We’ll figure it out. And we’ll be together, like we should be.”

Catra sat there for a second, quiet, and I watched her face carefully. I waited for the moment her expression would shift from

the stony, stoic one everyone else knew her for to the light and hopeful excited one only I ever got to see.

But it didn't happen.

Instead, she pulled away from me. She untangled our legs and stood up. She walked over to her closet and reached in to pull out a sweater.

"Catra?" I said, sitting up and watching as she pulled the sweater over her head. Then she went to her dresser and pulled out a pair of underwear and some leggings.

"Catra?" I threw my legs over the side of the bed. My heart was beating a little harder and the cold bit at my legs and chest. "What's wrong?"

She pulled on the underwear and leggings, and I stood.

"Catra, please talk to me?"

She stood there, looking down at the floor, not ten feet from me, fully clothed. And I was cold, and naked, with a racing heart and open arms.

"Catra," I pled, "look at me!"

Finally, she lifted her head. And it was that face, the stoic one, the one that was for everyone else but wasn't supposed to be for me.

"This was a mistake," she breathed, crossing her arms, and closing her eyes.

My heart stopped. "What—what do you mean?"

She took a step back and without thinking I took one forward.

"I mean we shouldn't have done… what we did."

And that hurt. That was a knife to the chest that snuck past my ribs and cut through all the flesh. But it didn't break my heart. I

could live through it.

"Oh." I swallowed, crossing my arm over my chest. "Did you not… I thought you wanted—"

She lifted her head, and her face was twisted. "Of course, I wanted to! That doesn't…" she growled and pushed the hair out of her eyes.

That doesn't mean I enjoyed it.

Another stab wound. But I would live.

"I'm…" I wiped at the tears that were pooling in my eyes, "if you didn't enjoy—"

"Fuck!" she cried, dragging her hands down her face. "Adora! It… it was everything I ever wanted it to be."

My heart started beating again. "Really?"

She took a deep breath and tipped her head back. And that didn't exactly match up with what she was saying, but I knew Catra wouldn't lie about this.

"Better."

I almost cracked a smile, but Catra would still barely look at me, and the wounds in my chest were still stinging.

"This was a mistake."

I took a step forward and that time Catra didn't step away. "Then what's wrong?"

She dropped her head and her jaw was clenched and her eyes were shining with tears. "This!" She pointed at the floor between us. "This is wrong. We can't—"

"What?" I nearly shouted, and it was like I broke the sound barrier. "You don't mean that—"

"Adora…" she crossed both arms over her chest, like she was hugging herself. "You didn't… you weren't…"

I walked up to her, grabbed her by the shoulders, and lowered my head so I could see directly into her eyes. "I know," I whispered, my heart hammering. I could feel everything falling apart around me, the sand slipping through my fingers. "I know I missed Thanksgiving. And I'm sorry, Catra. I'm so sorry. I just—volleyball. But I know that's not a good reason and—"

"Fuck!" She pulled away from me and shook her head. "That's… that's it though."

My heart started to crack. "What's it?"

For a second she was quiet, and in that quiet second, she finally looked at me. But her eyes were already so far away.

"I'm just going to get in the way, and I don't want to do that, Adora. I won't get in the way of your dreams."

She turned away from me, but I reached out for her. "No! Catra, you're not—" She kept walking and making her way through the apartment. "Catra!"

Then she was out the front door, and I was standing, alone, naked in her living room, colder than I'd ever been.

And my heart was cracked right down the middle, waiting to break.

I waited all day. I called her, only to realize she'd left her phone. So I called Adam, and Mara, and Scorpia and Entrapta. No one had seen her. Nobody knew where she was.

A little before the sun went down, I got a text from Scorpia telling me Catra was safe and okay. When I asked her if I could come over, she said, "I don't think that's the best idea right now…"

I told her to tell Catra I'd be waiting.

And that's where I was when she finally called.

I don't know what time it was – just that it was dark in Catra's living room. I was sitting on the couch, phone on the coffee table in front of me, staring right at it, willing it to ring. My hair was a mess, my makeup from the night before smeared, and I was wearing the only thing in the house that fit me – my red dress and the letterman jacket I left with Catra when I'd left for college.

I felt haggard and hideous and on the edge of my rope. I was maybe minutes away from driving to Scorpia's and demanding that Catra at least tell me to fuck off herself, when the phone finally buzzed.

I picked it up immediately, almost dropping it in my rush. It was Scorpia's name on the screen. Which I hoped meant—

"Catra!" I answered, my hands shaking.

"Hey, Adora," she murmured, and a sense of dread took over my body. I shivered.

"Are you okay?" I questioned, even though Scorpia promised she was. "Where are you?" I asked, even though I already knew.

"I'm okay," she breathed. "And I'm… I'm safe."

I nodded, then swallowed. "Are you coming back?" I said, even though I meant, "Dear god, please come back."

There was a pause, and I shivered again. I pulled my jacket tighter and caught a whiff of Catra's smell on the collar.

"Adora," she whispered, "I can't do this anymore."

That was the moment my heart broke. That was the knife that cut through and wrenched itself into the crack. That was the final blow.

I was going to die.

"No. No, Catra," my voice got thick, and I knew I was going to cry like a baby. "Catra, don't."

She sighed. "Adora—"

"I know I fucked up," I choked, my voice shaky. "I fucked up so bad. But I'll do better. I promise." I shook my hands, like I could make something appear that would just… fix everything. "I'll call more. I know I should – and I want to. It's just—"

"No, Adora." Her voice was firm and the panic building in my chest started clawing at my throat. "That won't fix things. It's… it's too hard."

I shook my head, and I forced a feeling of denial. This wasn't going to happen. I wouldn't let it happen. "I don't want to break up, Catra. Never." I took a deep breath. "I love you."

She sighed again. "I love you too," a glimmer of hope bloomed in my chest. "But Adora, how is this supposed to go?"

I squared my jaw. "Do you want to break up?"

There was a moment of silence, but when Catra spoke again her voice was thick with tears. "No, but—"

"Then we aren't going to break up," I said, like it was that simple. Like that would fix everything. And maybe it would've. Maybe if we'd just tried harder—maybe if I'd just tried harder…

"And I'm just supposed to, what?" There was venom in her voice then. "Hope you come home next Christmas?"

I ignored the sting that lanced through my chest, the knife going deeper.

"I *will.* I want to see you Catra," I clenched my fist. "Whenever I can."

I could hear her breath rattle. “Well… maybe that’s the problem.”

I stilled, her words hitting me with all the force of a hurricane. “You—you don’t want to see me?” I murmured. It was like I was hanging off a cliff and Catra was slowly cutting her way through the tangled tree roots that I was clinging to for dear life.

“Not if you’re leaving again,” she whispered, like it was a sin or something. Then she sighed. “And you’re going to leave again.”

“I—I don’t have to,” I whispered. But I knew what she was going to say. She’d said it over, and over, and over…

“You’re going back to Bright Moon, Adora.” Her voice was hard, leaving no room for argument. Then it got softer and sadder. “You have to.”

I knew she was right, but it made me so angry. Why couldn’t I play volleyball in Thaymor? Why did I have to go to the other side of the fucking country to have any chance at winning a gold medal?

“Then what are we supposed to do?” I hissed, my frustration leaking out. “I can’t stay, you won’t go—”

“Maybe…” she cut me off, and sighed, “maybe it’s for the best if we…”

I furrowed my brow, trying to figure out what she wanted me to say. If seeing me was the problem, if that hurt too much maybe we just… shouldn’t?

“Don’t see each other?” I muttered and waited for her to tell me no. Because it was ridiculous. How were we not supposed to see each other? We were supposed to be together forever, as stupid as that sounds now. I promised I’d come home every break. We were going to go to Salineas that summer. She was going to come to visit me in Bright Moon. We were going to make it work.

But maybe that was how we would have to make it work.

Catra choked on a sob. “Yeah.”

I bit down hard on my lip and nodded. “Okay.” I brushed my hand back through my hair that I never bothered to put up. “Whatever you need, Catra. Whatever makes it… easier.”

And I meant it. I would do whatever Catra needed. I would move mountains. And that was, I guess, my mountain. Because not seeing Catra? That was going to hurt. I was going to miss her every day. Her not being there was going to be the first thing I thought of every morning and the last thing I thought of every night. But this is what Catra needed. She needed space. She needed time apart. And I could do that, as long as I knew Catra would be waiting on the other side of it.

“I’m sorry, Adora,” her voice was soft and I clenched my jaw. “For everything.”

I shook my head. “Don’t—don’t be sorry. Just—” I paused, taking a deep breath and wondering if I could ask for it. But I wanted it, I *needed* it if I was going to survive that moment and every moment after. “Promise you won’t forget?” I breathed

She chuckled and it was wet and breathy. “About you? Never could, dummy.”

I swallowed and let those words sink into my chest, healing the cracked and broken heart inside. “I’m going to miss you so much.”

She took a deep breath. “Me too.”

I closed my eyes tight. “I love you.”

There was only a second’s hesitation, but it was there.

“Goodbye, Adora.”

“Bye.”

I hung up the phone and sat in that apartment, alone, for another hour. I cried and then I'd stop and then I'd start crying again. When I finally willed myself to get up to leave, I went to take off the letterman jacket.

Then I took a deep breath in and realized it didn't smell like me anymore. It smelled like Catra.

So, maybe just because it hurt, I kept the jacket on, and walked out of Catra's apartment and down to Mara's car.

Then I drove to my parent's house.

But not home. I wasn't going home. And I couldn't go home. Not until I could promise I would stay.

So, I went back to school. I went to practice every day. I would practice through breaks and drag Bow into every beach volleyball tournament I could find. I was going to win that medal and then I was going to go home. And I was never going to leave again.

I was such a fucking idiot.

December 24, 2021

I am such a fucking idiot.

I'm kissing her back. The second Catra's lips touch mine, I'm glued to her. My hand is in her hair and my body's on fire. I'm pushing in closer, and she's pushing back. She's pressed right up against me, her hand on my cheek and the other wrapped around my shoulder. And for a second, it's amazing.

Then Catra pulls back to take a breath and it's like being doused in cold water.

I want this. I want this so bad I can barely think. But I can't have this. Not yet.

So she leans back in, and I pull away.

“Catra,” I breathe, and shake my head. “No.”

My eyes flutter open and a second later, so do hers. Gold and blue widen just a fraction and she’s pulling away from me as her cheeks flush red.

She’s not flustered for very long. She turns away from me and her eyes narrow. Then she shoots a glare at me out of the corner of her eyes. “Seriously?” She crosses her arms. “Isn’t that why you’re here?”

I blink, pull back, and grimace. “What?

She stares at the coffee table, like she’s trying to burn holes in it with her eyes. “You’ve been trying to get in my pants since the moment you got back to town. Figured I’d cut through the bullshit.”

My brow furrows and my jaw drops. “Catra, that is not—”

“Whatever.” She turns her head away and brushes the hair out of her eyes. “You can go now.”

I glance at the door and consider it for a second. Theoretically, it’s the “right” thing to do. She basically asked me to leave. It was a bad idea to come here in the first place, literally everyone thought so. All I’m gonna do is dig myself deeper.

But I have to try.

I turn back and put my hand on her shoulder. “Catra, I want to kiss you. More than anything,” I sigh, and even though she refuses to look at me, she relaxes under my hand. “But I can’t.”

She turns her head back to stare straight ahead and bites her lip. Her brilliant yellow eye is the only one I can see but it’s pinched with hurt. “Why?”

I take a deep breath and lift my hand to place it on her cheek.

“Because…” she turns into my hand, “I still love you.”

She pulls away immediately, standing up and walking away from me. She’s shaking her head and crossing her arms.

“No, no, no…”

“Catra?”

She turns to face me, and her lips are turned down in a snarl. “That doesn’t even fucking make any goddamn sense.”

I stand, slowly, holding out a hand. “I—If I kissed you, it would mean something different to me than it does to you. And that’s not fair. To either of us.”

I take a step closer to her and she takes a step back.

“No, because you’re wrong.”

A small glimmer of hope sparks in my chest. “I’m wrong?”

She gives a curt nod. “You don’t love me.”

The glimmer of hope burns out, but a small wildfire catches in its place. “Yes,” I clench my teeth, “I do.”

Catra shakes her head and holds herself tighter. “No. No, you don’t.”

“Catra, I love you!” I cry, frustrated in the way only Catra can make me.

“Adora…” she whines, putting a hand to the side of her head, but I’m not going to stop. Not until she gives this to me. I’ve been denying myself what I want and what I feel my entire life. I’m not doing it anymore.

“Catra,” I hold out my hands, hoping she’ll take them, “I’m in love with you. I have been my whole life.”

She shakes her head again, and there are tears in her eyes. “No,” she whispers, “you’re not. You—you don’t love me. Not the way I —"

I reach out for her, putting my hands on her shoulders, and she doesn’t pull away. I lower my head and press my forehead to hers. “Why won’t you listen to me?” I breathe, my heart breaking in my chest.

“Because you’re lying!” she cries, grabbing onto my wrists.

“Catra—”

“Three minutes, thirty-four seconds.” She pulls away from me, and her face is all twisted up in a grimace. “Do you know what that is?”

My stomach turns.

“My birthday present,” she hisses. “You called me for three minutes and thirty-four seconds on my eighteenth birthday.” She takes a shaky breath. “I was finally getting out of that god-awful house, and Adam skipped his classes to take me to get my license, and Mara and Razz packed the back of their cars with my shit and… and you called me for three minutes and thirty-four seconds.”

I bite my lower lip. “Catra—”

“You… *forgot* about me.” She chokes on her tears. “I didn’t matter. All that mattered was your new friends and your new life and…” she takes a deep breath, “volleyball.”

I close my eyes. “I fucked up. I know. You, my friends, my family, you’ve all made that very clear. But I want to fix this. Please tell me we can fix this!”

Catra rolls her eyes and turns away from me. “There’s nothing to *fix,* Adora.”

“What are you talking about?” I throw my arms wide. “Of course there is!”

“We broke up!” she yells, and I’m angry again. I can hear my pulse in my ears and feel it in my hands.

“No,” I seethe. “I didn’t break up with you. I said over and over again that I didn’t want that. What on earth made you think that’s what I meant?”

She groans and throws her head back. “Because that’s what that means!” She looks back at me, glowering. “Everyone knows that.”

“Well, I didn’t!”

“Well, you’re an idiot.”

And that stings. It’s all anyone’s been saying about me lately. And maybe they’re right. Maybe I am an idiot. Maybe that’s all I am.

But I’m not a liar. And I’m not a coward.

“Why didn’t you come with me?” I ask, and she stills, turning around like she heard a gunshot.

“Adora—”

“Was it because you wanted to go to school?” I press. “You could’ve gotten into UBM, Catra. We could’ve—”

She sighs. “I didn’t want to go to Bright Moon, okay?”

I bite my lip and nod, brushing a loose strand of hair back behind my ear. “So… why did I have to?”

She frowns. “What?”

I shrug, but I can feel the tears starting to pool in the corners of my eyes. “You were the one encouraging me to go. I wanted to go to Elberon, to be close to you and my family, but you—”

“That’s the problem!” She throws up her hand. “You would’ve jeopardized your future! For what? Me?”

I furrow my brow and press a hand to my chest. “But we would’ve *had* a future.”

Catra shakes her head. “Adora, you were going to be a gold medalist and—”

My hands are shaking, and I feel frozen. “Why did I have to do that *alone* ?” I shout the last word. Every hour I missed her, every second I was gone, every day we were apart weighing it down until I could barely lift it.

And Catra is silent.

I stare into her two-toned eyes, and I wonder what she’s thinking. I used to be able to tell from just a look, but it’s been so long… her looks might be different now. They might mean different things.

And even if they don’t, even if she’s the same Catra she’s always been, she’s not gonna share herself with me anymore.

“You said you’d wait,” I whisper, breath hitching in my throat, “but you gave up so early.”

She closes her eyes and two tears run down her cheeks.

I shiver. I’ve made her cry, and I feel bad about that. I never wanted to do that again.

“It was never about the waiting,” she whispers, opening her eyes and taking a shaky breath. “I would’ve waited my whole life for you, Adora. But you weren’t going to come back.”

I bite back a fresh wave of anger and grief. "I *did.* "

She nods slowly, swallowing. "Eight years later. You just… forgot about me. For eight years."

I shake my head and move towards her again. "I didn't forget! God! Catra, you aren't listening to me!"

And she still doesn't listen. She looks out the window at the snow that started falling who knows how long ago and presses a hand to the center of her chest. "You know what's pathetic? I wanted you so much I thought it was gonna kill me. And you… you called me for three minutes and thirty-four seconds on my birthday."

I groan, smoothing my hair back. "I know! And I'm sorry, Catra, but you're not being fair! Please, let me make this better. I can fix this." I step forward, take her hand from her chest, and hold it between both of mine. "We can fix this."

She meets my gaze and tilts her head. Her eyes are dry but a little red and she just kind of smiles sadly. "Adora, I—I don't care."

I squeeze her hand, like I'm trying to make sure she's really there. "What?"

She takes a deep breath and squares her shoulders. "I promised myself I wouldn't care—that I don't care. You don't have to love me, Adora. I—I don't want you to."

I blink and let her hand slip out of my grasp. "You don't… care?"

She smiles, looking me up and down like some sort of assessment. "You're better off now. You're happy. Happier than I could've ever made you."

My jaw twitches and I shake my head. "You don't know that."

She bites her lower lip and reaches up to put her hand on my cheek. It's warm and soft and I never want her to take it away. "I… I promised myself I'd be good this time. I wasn't gonna be

angry or get jealous. I want to be happy for you, Adora. You got everything you wanted, right?"

I shake my head and cover her hand with my own. "No, Catra, I want you!"

She almost laughs, rubbing her thumb over my cheekbone. "I'm not good for you, Adora. And… you're not good for me."

For a second, I stand there in silence and stare into the eyes I can't read anymore, the eyes that won't let me in.

"You don't want me?" I murmur, and I can hear my heart shatter with the words.

She looks over my face one last time then pulls her hand away. "Go home, Adora."

Then she walks away from me, past the kitchen, up the stairs, and out of my life…

I climb into my truck, slam the door shut behind me, and I scream. I scream and my voice shakes and I slam my hands against the sides of the wheel over and over again.

After a second, I calm down and with shaky hands, I pull my keys out of my pocket. I turn the car on and pull forward onto the street. I can barely see through the tears in my eyes. I should call Bow, or Glimmer, or Adam. But I don't. I just pull out of Catra's neighborhood, and I drive.

I mean to go back to my parent's house, to the only place left that feels anything like home. But I take a wrong turn. And then another one. Before I realize what's happened I'm driving down Eternia street, just past the Dominos to the light at Skeletor.

I blink away the tears and pull into the Dominos parking lot.

I turn off my truck, pull my jacket tight, and step out into the lightly falling snow.

On the corner, up against the pole of the south-facing traffic light, is a little shrine. There's about three fresh poinsettia plants, a couple of those little rainbow pinwheels, and a little poster board that says "Go Billy Goats!" all surrounding a framed picture of my parents.

I step up to the shrine. Someone was here recently; the snow's been brushed off everything. I wonder if it was Adam or Mara. The picture of my parents is only a little sun-bleached, and I stare at it intently. They look so happy and so young. The picture's from right after they were first married. Before Adam and I. Before they had anything weighing them down.

I stare at the picture and the anger that left on my drive starts to boil inside me again.

Catra and I would never have that. We don't get to be carefree and happy. We don't even get to be in love. We lost that.

No, we killed it. Together. I starved it, and Catra strangled it.

But of course she did. What else was she going to do? Trust me?

I laugh and cover my mouth.

How could she? When it came to love, all Catra has ever known was hunger. Shannon Weaver has been starving Catra her entire life. She's lived on crumbs, impersonal cards for birthdays, and cheap and tacky gifts for Christmas. No I love you's, no sincere soft touches. She didn't know what it was like to feel cared for and wanted. Because Catra *wasn't* . And Shannon never let her forget it.

Which makes it all the more heartbreaking that it's all she wants. Catra will never admit it, but I know, all she wants is for someone to love her.

And I tried. I tried so hard. But she wouldn't let me.

Because after years of begging for it, Catra doesn't think she deserves it anymore.

I turn around, facing the far side of town where the nursing home is, and I clench my fists.

"Fuck you!" I yell with everything I have. "Fuck you for hurting her!"

I turn on my heel and point at my parents' photo, teeth clenched and blood pumping hard.

"And fuck you for leaving," I seethe. "Fuck you for not making sense and making me think I had to be special."

I stare hard at the photo, like maybe they'll respond. I want them to. I want them to apologize. They would. My dad would hold open his arms and invite me in and my mom would stroke my hair. They'd tell me they were sorry, that they love me, and ask me what they could do to make me feel better. Then my mom would ask me to look at her and she'd tell me that everything is going to be okay.

But it's not going to be okay. I've lost Catra, for good. Things are never going to be okay again.

I lower myself to the ground and sit on my butt in the snow. I take a deep breath and reach into my pocket. I pull out my medal and hold it up for my parents to see.

"I got this for you," I mutter, then rub my thumb over the front. "It, um… cost me a lot."

I look back up at their picture, tears in my eyes. "If I'd known that, I wouldn't have done it. But I hope I made you proud."

And for a second, it's like I can hear their voices on the wind.

We've always been proud of you.

I smile a little and set the medal down in front of their picture, and I wonder if maybe someday I'll believe that. If someday, that'll be enough.

Chapter End Notes



Ice is Also Great

Chapter Notes

Content warning, there is some *very* light suicidal ideations at one point in this chapter. It's a lot more of an errant intrusive thought, but if you're sensitive to that, just know.

We are so close to the end here and I know that feelings have been... heated as of late. I don't know what this chapter is gonna do, but I'm ready to find out!

It's kind of short. But it's important.

Enjoy!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra

"Sometimes people don't understand the promises they're making when they make them. But you keep the promise anyway. That's what love is. Love is keeping the promise anyway." – John Green

January 2, 2014

I don't remember what time it was, but the sun was still up. You couldn't see it because the clouds were so fucking thick and the snow was so heavy, but the world was bright gray and it hurt my eyes to look out the window.

So I stared out the window.

I felt lifeless and cold, like I was a hollow husk of who I'd been before. Adora always said I was like a furnace or something, but in that moment I couldn't imagine ever being warm again.

But I figured that might be the problem. Furnaces die all the time and I sure as hell felt dead. They get old, they wear out, parts break, the pilot light goes out…

That had to be it. There wasn't any fire left in me, not even the tiny little blue flame that I managed to carry through every emotional beatdown, bitter anxiety attack, and stifling self-esteem crisis I'd ever had. It had been snuffed out.

I lifted my hands to my mouth, breathing on them like I was outside in the snow instead of in my warm, heated apartment. But they felt numb and achy, and I wanted to stop the shaking.

It was almost funny. All that time I thought I was filled with fire, that I was being consumed by it from the inside out. But all it took was…

All it took was breaking a pair of tied hearts and the fire was gone.

I wrapped my arms around my chest, holding in the sobs that wanted to shake me apart.

Adora and I were the last victims of my raging, violent heart. The dragon inside me had taken from me again and again. It had taken friends, approval, affirmation, love, and now it had taken the only person who gave me any of that. It had taken Adora.

I took a deep breath, shaking a little with the weight of it.

It was for the best. Adora had a future out there. She was going to go to UBM. She was going to become a professional volleyball player. She was going to win a gold medal. She was going to get everything she ever wanted.

And maybe she thought she wanted me, but she wouldn't think that for very long.

Someday Adora is going to meet a great girl, I thought. *She is going to be beautiful, and funny, and charming, and all the stuff*

I'm not. She is going to be everything she deserves, and she won't hurt her. She won't have to.

I closed my eyes and tried not to picture what she looked like. I didn't want to know. I wasn't ready yet.

But someday… I'd have to come to terms with it.

I blinked, glancing over at my guitar. I looked back out the window then back at the guitar. It sat on the couch, propped up against the cushions, where I left it before the gala.

I stood slowly and walked towards it. I reached down and lifted it by the neck, feeling the poorly carved letters under my fingers.

I swallowed and squared my jaw, then turned down the hall. I walked into the bathroom and curled up on the floor next to the toilet, resting the guitar up in my lap.

Then I strummed the horrible and familiar chord that started a song I would always think of as ours.

" *In… ten years,"* I whispered, plucking the gentle tune I was hearing in my head, " *I'll pass you on the street and you'll be with someone prettier than me."*

I swallowed as tears filled my eyes and the weight of what I'd done fell heavy on my heart.

" *And I'll have to come to terms with that. Yeah, I'll have to come to terms with that."*

I choked on my words, and I realized that a small part of me really just wanted to die. But I kept singing. I just kept singing.

December 31, 2021

I don’t expect him to pick up. I’m actually a hundred percent sure he won’t pick up. So when, after two rings, I hear Adam Grayskull saying, “Hey, Catra,” I kinda panic.

“Adam! Hey. Um. Sorry. Uh—I didn’t… well, I thought—you weren’t…” I take a deep breath. “You weren’t supposed to answer, asshole.”

He chuckles. “Answering your phone when it rings is the asshole move? Good to know.”

I pick at a loose fiber on the arm of my couch and avoid looking out the window. It’s snowing outside and everything is bright and gray and it hurts to look at. “It is. Especially…” I swallow and close my eyes, “after what happened.”

“Hmm,” Adam mutters and I can just picture him brushing his hair out of his eyes. “What *exactly* are you referring to?”

I clench my jaw. “Don’t.”

“I’m just saying, a lot’s been going on. I don’t know if you know this, but my sister’s moving back to town.”

I frown. “Wait, Adora’s staying?”

Adam barks a laugh. “Yeah. She said her home is here, or some shit like that.” He sighs. “She always planned on coming back and staying.”

I nod slowly, my heart in my throat.

“Catra?”

“Sorry,” I say, wiping under my eyes and straightening in my seat.

“Catra,” Adam’s voice is softer, defeated. “What happened?”

I bite my lower lip and glance out the window. “Nothing.”

"Come on," he presses. "Adora came home Christmas Eve and she was a mess. Like snot on her face and hair falling out of the ponytail. And she kept crying. She wouldn't even play Santa in the morning."

I reach up and grab the chain around my neck. I pull out the ring that hangs off the end and drag it back and forth.

"Cat, I'm gonna tell you something I really shouldn't." He sighs. "But you have to promise not to freak out."

I swallow the thump in my throat that I'm certain is my heart. "Okay…"

"So, obviously there were presents for you under the tree. From me and T, Razz, Mara, Santa, you know."

I nod, my heart rate picking up as he spoke.

"But… Adora had a gift for you too. And when I pulled it out, an accident by the way, she started crying again. Teela basically had her arms wrapped around her all morning."

I close my eyes and shake my head. They're morons. Every fucking last one of them. But also, there's no way. I didn't do this. I don't have this kind of power. It doesn't make sense that Adora *fucking* Grayskull is this upset over me. I'm Catra Weaver. I'm the girl no one wants. I'm the girl who got left and replaced. My own mother never wanted me, why would anyone else?

I squeeze the ring tight in my palm.

"Why'd you guys even put my gifts under the tree in the first place? Actually," I shake my head, "why the fuck do you keep getting me gifts?"

Adam laughs again. "As Razz would say, 'Don't ask such silly questions, Catra.'" I almost smile, "But seriously? We were kinda hoping that Adora would get you to come over Christmas morning. That's a lie, Razz was hoping. The rest of us were pretty

sure you were gonna kick her to the curb the second she showed up on your doorstep."

I trace my finger over the shape of the ring. "I should've," I breathe.

"But…" Adam trails off, waiting for me to fill in the empty space.

I close my eyes. "I didn't," I whisper, like it's a dirty little secret. Like it's the worst thing I've ever done. Honestly, it might be.

"Yeah," he mutters, then clears his throat. I hear a door close on his end and wonder why he left the room he was in. Did Adora come in? Mara? One of Adora's friends? "Why?"

I blink back the tears that want to form in my eyes and swallow. "Um… is 'I'm an idiot' a good enough answer?"

"No."

I cough out a laugh. "What about, 'I'm a terrible person'?"

"Catra." His voice is stern and I still my hand, pressing the ring against my chest.

"I—" I choke on my words, and close my eyes, trying to ground myself. "Because she asked!" Tears flood my eyes again. "Because I wanted to. *Fuck* . Adam, all I've wanted, since the moment she got back, was to just… *be* with her again. I missed her. So much."

The tears start down my cheeks and I bite my lip and try to focus on the pain. "But it was selfish. I'm selfish. Adora—" I sigh, "she needs to let me go. You all do."

Adam is quiet for a second, like he's picking his words carefully, which is something I don't think Adam's ever done before. "Do you actually want to be let go? Or, do you just think that's the right thing to want?"

I glance down at the ring that hangs around my chest. That has hung around my chest every day for 7 years.

Maybe I should let go too. Maybe I should take off this ring. Maybe I should get a new guitar. Maybe I should throw away the Hannah Montana microphone my mom got me for Christmas when I was 15. Maybe I hold on too tight. Maybe that's why no one else ever holds on like me.

"Does it really matter?"

"I'd like to know," Adam says. "Like are we really too much, or are you doing that *thing* ?"

I frown. "What thing?"

He almost laughs. "Catra, you're like weirdly obsessed with your own morality."

My entire body clenches.

"Like, all our childhood you called yourself a 'bad influence'. But then whenever a teacher or parent said something like that, you would get so mad. Like, remember that time with Lonnie where you cussed her out and said she didn't have the right to make you 'feel like a shit person' or whatever?" He chuckles. "And then the Scorpia thing! Oh god. You told me like five different times that you weren't a monster for not being into her just because she liked you."

"I—"

He ignores me. "You are convinced you're a bad person, Catra. And sometimes you lean into it, but usually you are fighting your ass off to convince yourself and everyone else that you're not."

I cover my face with my hand. "This… this isn't about that."

"Yeah, sure." Adam sighs.

“Adam,” I push my hair out of my eyes. “I called for a reason. Can we get to that?”

“Yeah,” he groans a little, probably readjusting wherever he’s sitting, “what’s up?”

“Is Adora going to the New Year’s Eve Gala tonight?” I ask, timid and quiet.

There’s a pause. “I don’t know. I mean, Glimmer and Bow are here and Glimmer brought *at least* three garment bags in, so I’m guessing. But she might try and convince them to leave her here.”

“Are you going?”

“Of course.” He scoffs. “As a former Snow King, it’s like… an honor to attend.”

I bite my lip and nod. “Would… would you do me a favor?”

He lets out a long, slow breath. “Depends on what it is.”

“Will you,” I swallow, “will you *try* and get Adora there? Please?”

“Why?” I can hear the skepticism in Adam’s voice, and I don’t blame him. I basically took Adora’s heart and stepped on it. I wouldn’t want me within 20 feet of her.

“This is gonna sound dumb,” I say, leaning back into my couch, “but I want her to make new memories there. Ones that don’t involve me. Just to have a fun night out with her friends and to leave some part of her Yule festival intact. Ya know?”

Adam sighs, and he almost sounds disappointed. “Yeah, I know. I can do that. But Catra?”

“Yeah?”

“Adora’s gonna get over this, and when she does, one of two things is gonna happen. She’s either gonna move on and find

something or someone else to pine after or… well, you know what she's like."

My heart is cracking under the weight of his words, but I furrow my brow. "What do you mean?"

"She doesn't give up easy. Especially on you."

I don't have anything to say to that.

"Bye, Cat."

"Bye."

And then he hangs up. For a second, I sit in the silence, with my phone still up to my ear, and I realize that my fingers are once again wrapped around the ring that hangs from my neck.

It's like I'm frozen. I haven't gotten off my couch and I haven't stopped looking out the window. I didn't even realize I'd started until my head was throbbing from the bright light, but I didn't stop. I've watched the sky as it burned orange with the sunset, cooled in the twilight, and turned black with night. Now, I'm just waiting for fireworks.

I sigh and break my gaze from glowing white behind the clouds and glance at the clock. 10:45. They'll be announcing Snow King & Queen in an hour.

I almost laugh, my throat getting tight. I feel like an Ice Queen right about now – but like the Hans Christian Andersen one with the literal heart of ice.

I remember the night Adora was made Snow Queen though. I remember how Adora looked in her dress, with the butterfly clip in her hair. I remember how it felt to drag her onto the dance floor and make her laugh and smile. I remember the moment she put her hand on my waist and spun me around when "Chasing Cars"

started playing and the feeling in my gut when they sang, *"All that I am, all that I ever was, is here in your perfect eyes. They're all I can see."*

And then the music stopped, and Adora was called away from me.

I pull the ring up from around my neck. I've hardly left it alone all day. I don't know what's wrong with me. The metal feels cold against my fingers, but I can't leave it alone.

"It's so you don't forget me. So, you remember our promise."

I still my fingers. Adora made a promise – every Thanksgiving, Christmas, Spring Break, and Summer. She promised she would come home when she was done. She promised she would follow me anywhere. She promised she would always be my friend.

But she wasn't the only one who made promises.

I promised I wouldn't be jealous, or bitter, or angry; that I'd be good. I promised that I wouldn't care whether or not Adora loved me.

And almost ten years ago, I promised myself I was going to tell my girlfriend I loved her at midnight.

At least Adora keeps some of hers.

I sigh and lean forward to set the ring on the coffee table.

"I promise to love you forever. I promise my friend to be better. I see you, I know you, I like you, I owe you For giving me a home in this dark lonely world…"

I stiffen, the words coming back to me like a hot knife cutting through my mind.

I pull the ring back to my chest, unclasp the chain, and shove the offending trinket on my finger. Then I stand, brush my fingers through my hair and rush back to my bedroom.

Fuck, I better still fit in that suit.

Chapter End Notes

So... I'm a little scared to ask, but thoughts?

Thanks to my betas! You guys make me readable! And also, your enthusiasm really gets me going and puts words on the page.

Sing to Me Just One More Time

Chapter Notes

> So this took a little longer to get out than I wanted it to. I've been a little distracted planning my next fic, so I kept forgetting this one existed 😂 But don't worry! I remembered and I'm here with another chapter!
>
> Technically, this is the final chapter. The next one will be an epilogue.
>
> I know this has been one hell of a ride, but thank you for taking it with me. I hope, in the end, this story was at least a little enjoyable. And I hope that you like how it ends.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora

"I spent my childhood learning how to fear, and now I spend my adulthood learning how not to." – Gemma Troy

April 23, 2012

It hadn't even been three days since my parents died and they already wanted to put them in the ground.

I stood in front of the mirror on the back of my bedroom door and stared at my reflection. I was in a black pencil skirt and those see-through black tights. Catra had let me borrow some boots with a tiny heel and in each hand, I held a different shirt. One was a solid black button-down I'd gotten earlier that year, and the other was loose, and flowy, with black lace around the edges that my mom had picked for me when I was 14. It had been big then but kinda fit perfectly by the time I was a junior.

I didn’t really like it. But mom had loved it.

I sighed and started pulling the lace-lined shirt over my head.

Right after I got it down over my bra, there was a quiet knock on my door. I pulled the shirt the rest of the way down and stepped out from behind the door. “Come in.”

Slowly, poking her head in a little at a time, Catra appeared and stepped into the room. She smiled at me, the soft gentle smile that no one else ever got to see, and put her hands behind her back.

“Hey, Adora.”

I managed to smile back. “Hey, Catra.”

She just smiled for a second longer, then her eyes looked me up and down and her nose turned up in that cute little way it does when she hates something.

“So… that’s what you’re wearing?”

I glanced down at my outfit and frowned. “Yeah,” I muttered, crossing my arms over my torso. “Why? Is it—is it that bad?”

She sighed and stepped forward. “Well, first of all, Princess, if you’re gonna wear this top with a pencil skirt, you gotta tuck it in. Otherwise, it’s not doing you any favors.”

I reached for the bottom of my shirt and Catra took it from my hands.

“But…” her lip wrinkled in a frown, “I don’t think Rand and Marlena would want you wearing all black to their funeral.”

I furrowed my brow. “That’s what people wear to funerals, Catra. Black.”

She cocked her head, then dropped her hand with a flourish. “I, my friend, am wearing red.”

I blinked, taking in Catra’s clothing for the first time. She was in a dress, which was something I almost never saw. It was a tight, dark red sweater dress with long sleeves that reached down to about an inch above her knee. And right in the center of her chest was a large triangle-shaped peephole.

My heart rate picked up a little.

“Why are you wearing red?” I hissed.

She laughed. “Okay, remember when Evelyn got remarried?”

I blinked. Evelyn was my mom’s best friend. I did remember her getting remarried. And suddenly I remembered the dress.

“But why are you wearing that dress?” I asked, tossing my hands up.

Catra snickered. “Because, dumbass, your mom bought it for me. The three of us went shopping and when I put it on, she said something about red being my color.”

I frowned, looking Catra over again. I couldn’t deny it, my mom was right. Catra looked amazing. Her skin looked so warm against the dress. And the way she’d twisted her hair up into a bun with curls dangling down…

I looked down at my own clothes again.

“Catra,” my hands started to shake, “what am I supposed to do?”

“Hey, hey, hey.” Catra grabbed my hands. “It’s okay.” She pulled me to the closet and gave my hands a squeeze. “I’ve got you.”

She turned, reaching into my closet, and pushing through all my clothes. After a few seconds, her face lit up with a smile, and she pulled out a dress.

She held it up for me to see and ran her hand down the skirt. "I'm just saying, blue really makes your eyes pop."

Catra was holding a deep royal blue, knee-length, short-sleeved velvet wrap dress. It was the dress my mom bought me for Evelyn's wedding. And when I first put it on at the random boutique in the mall that probably cost more than it was worth, my mom had said, "Sweetheart, you look ethereal."

I took the dress from Catra and smiled a little. I actually liked that dress. I liked how it made my hair kinda glow and my eyes "pop" like Catra said. I liked how loose it was without being floppy. I liked that it made me feel pretty, but not super girly. I liked how the velvet felt under my hands, and the way you could see my arms.

And I liked that my mom thought I looked "ethereal."

I smiled at Catra. "Yeah, this is it. Thanks."

She pulled a tight smile, and I knew something was wrong.

"What?"

She sighed and crossed the room to sit on my bed. "Okay, look – I know I *asked* how I could help with the funeral. I know I offered. And I really wanted to help. And it's Marlena and Rand and I wanted to do this, for them. And—"

I rolled my eyes. "Catra, it's fine."

She shook her head and crossed an arm over her chest to hold the other. "No, but you asked me to write a song for the funeral and the thing is—"

"The thing is," I cut her off, "I shouldn't have asked you to do that. Especially not in three days." I shake my head. "I just—I thought maybe that would be a way you could help that you would like, ya know? It was stupid."

She shook her head and grabbed me by both arms. “It wasn’t stupid. And I still want to play, I just… it won’t be a Catra original is all.”

I bit my lip and gave her a little smile. “You still wanna play?”

She nodded. “You guys got me the guitar. I think you all deserve one last recital.”

I smiled. “This isn’t gonna be your last, Catra. Not if I have anything to say about it.”

Catra stood at the front of the funeral home’s long non-denominational chapel with her guitar in her hands. She was standing in front of a mic stand and for the first time ever, she looked nervous to perform.

Then she took a deep breath and stepped up to the mic.

“Hey,” she smiled a little, “I’m Catra Weaver. Um, Randor and Marlena were really important to me. *Are* really important to me. And, uh, I just wanted to sing this song for them. So… anyway.”

She lifted her guitar and took another deep breath, moving her fingers, practicing the movement before she started, which was something she always used to do.

And then there was music.

I didn’t recognize the song right away, but it felt familiar, like something I’d heard over and over again. I tried to place it for a second, then Catra started singing.

“There’s no one in town who I know. You gave us some place to go. I never said thank you for that. I thought I might get one more chance.”

I let out a quiet gasp as my heart seized in my chest. I still couldn't place the song, but I didn't care anymore. Because wherever I'd heard it before, it didn't belong. It belonged there, in that moment.

" *What would you think of me now? So lucky, so strong, so proud. I never said thank you for that. And now I'll never have a chance."*

I felt Adam wrap his fingers around mine and tears stinging my eyes.

"May angels lead you in. Hear you me my friends, on sleepless roads the sleepless go, may angels lead you in."

Catra continued to play and sing, her gentle voice carrying through the room and shaking me to my core. She was so beautiful, holding her head high with the saddest and kindest of smiles warming her face.

And as cold as I'd felt for days, I finally remembered I could feel warm.

Catra moved and swayed through her little guitar solo, letting herself feel the music and I remembered singing along with my dad in the car and dancing to my mom's records in the living room. I remembered Adam blaring his music in his room and Catra quietly plucking away at my family's piano. I remembered singing and dancing in the living room while watching Barbie movies in dress-up dresses.

I remembered how great it felt to be a family and to be surrounded by love.

Catra got quiet again, her fingers moving slower, she stepped closer to the mic, breathing the next words gently like they would break her.

"And if you were with me tonight… I'd sing to you just one more time. A song for two hearts so big," Catra's voice got thick and a tear slipped down her cheek, *"God wouldn't let them live."*

"May angels lead you in. Hear you me my friends, on sleepless roads, the sleepless go, may angels lead you in."

As soon as Catra sang her final note, I was running up the stairs on the side of the pulpit. She barely had time to put her guitar on its stand before I threw my arms around her and buried my face in her neck.

"Thank you," I breathed, gripping her tight. "Thank you so much."

Catra slipped her arms around me and sniffed, which meant she was trying not to cry. I didn't even care anymore.

Not two seconds later, Adam had his arms around both of us. He kissed the top of both our heads and almost laughed.

"Mom and Dad loved you so much, Cat. I mean, they loved Adora most, but—"

I turned my head and threw a punch at his gut.

Catra laughed, then reached to hug Adam too. "That's okay. I love Adora most too." She gave me a squeeze and my heart burst into flames.

Then Catra nuzzled in closer to me and took a shaky breath.

"Thank you," she whispered, her voice thick. "Thank you, for—ya know, giving me a home."

I turned my head and gave her neck a quick kiss. "I love you most too."

"Oh, come on, guys!" Adam groaned. "What the fuck?"

Catra and I just laughed.

December 31, 2021

I couldn’t be having a worse time if I tried.

I’m standing in the corner of the high school gym, watching as a group of teenagers and young adults dance their hearts out to music I don’t even recognize, with a cup of unspiked punch in my hand. I shouldn’t be drinking it. It’s bright red, and my jumpsuit is white with gold swirly thingies. But I don’t care. I kinda don’t care about anything anymore.

God, I’m pathetic.

A girl. That’s all Catra is. Just a girl! Sure, she was my first kiss. And I spent the last decade pining over her. And I thought she was the love of my life. But in the end, she’s just a girl!

I sigh and drop my head. I wish I could believe that.

It’s been a week, and everything still hurts like it did that day. I still feel the way I did when I walked out of Catra’s place, whirling after she’d called me an idiot and a liar. Broken down, tired, angry, but, more than anything, sad.

I’m so… sad. I already miss her. But, I guess I never really got to stop.

Glimmer appears at my side, with Bow on her heels and she smiles at me. “Adora,” she says through clenched teeth, “you are killing the vibe.”

I groan and lean into the wall.

“What Glimmer means,” Bow says, shooting his wife a look, “is that we thought you wanted to come to this, but it seems like you’re just miserable.”

I arch my brow. “How is that better?”

Bow grimaces. “You’re right. It’s not.”

I sigh and look down into my drink. I consider just pouring it right onto my leg. I don't know why, maybe I just want to ruin something on purpose for once. Instead, I push off the wall and down the rest of it in one swallow.

"Maybe I should just go home." I mutter.

"What?" they cry out in unison, Glimmer reaching out to grab my hand. "No," she shakes her head, "that's not what we're saying."

I shake my head. "Look, guys, everything reminds me of her." I look back in my cup at the lone drop of red punch at the bottom. "Especially here. I just don't think—"

And just as I'm speaking, the song that's blaring over the speakers changes.

"We'll do it all. Everything. On our own…"

"Are you kidding me?" I nearly growl, and drop Glimmer's hand to throw my cup at the nearest trash can with all the strength I have. "What *year* is it?"

Bow and Glimmer share a loaded glance. "Well, it's about to be 2022…" Bow murmurs.

I brush my hand over my forehead and shake my head again. "No, I mean—it's not important." And it's not important. It's just a song. So, it's the song Catra and I first danced to. And whenever I hear it I think about her. And when it gets to the part about "perfect eyes," I almost always start crying because I picture Catra's eyes. None of that matters because it's just a song that makes hardly any sense by some band no one's heard from in fifteen years.

"My point is, I'm 'killing the vibe', just like Glimmer said. You'll have more fun if I go home."

"No," Glimmer puckered her lips, "Adora. Stay. We didn't mean to make you feel bad."

"Yeah," Bow steps up to my other side and puts a hand on my shoulder, "we're just worried about you."

I put on a strained smile. "Thanks, guys. I appreciate it. But it's—"

The music cuts out completely.

I furrow my brow and look to the stage. It's strange, I don't remember them cutting off mid-song to announce Snow King and Queen when I was in high school. I step forward and look to the risers that perform as a makeshift stage at the front of the gym, expecting to see Hordak, who is apparently principal now, or even Spinnerella or Netossa, who I found out earlier tonight both still work at the high school. Instead, I see some high schooler, with cropped dark hair and a scowl on her face, step up to the mic. She's short, so she has to adjust it a little, but she doesn't move it near as much as she needs to. She has a guitar hanging over her shoulder, and now she's trying to smile, but it looks more like a grimace.

"And now, with a special performance to commemorate the end of Yule, Ms. Catra."

My heart leaps into my throat as Catra appears out of the shadows. She blinks in the bright spotlight and steps up to take the teenager's place at the mic. "Um…" she swallows, and shakes her head, a small chuckle ringing out over the speaker, "sorry, about that. Frosta said I needed an introduction and wouldn't help me unless I agreed. Also," she winces, "sorry about, uh, commandeering your night? I promise – I'll be quick."

She laughs again, fiddling with the tuning pegs on her guitar, and it's then that I notice how she's dressed. She's wearing her suit, her red suit. The suit she wore while we danced to 'Chasing Cars' and kissed to Dashboard Confessional. The suit Razz tailored for her. The suit from the night I first thought about telling her I loved her.

I don't know why I didn't. It seems really dumb now. I kissed her in front of the entire town, but I wasn't ready to use three little words that she wouldn't have believed anyway?

"Um… so, this is easily the most embarrassing thing I've ever done in my life." The entire room chuckles at that. "But… Adora?" She looks up and there's no way she knows I'm in the corner of the room, hiding from everyone else, but I swear she looks right at me.

"Ten years ago, you asked me to write a song for your parents' funeral, and I told you I couldn't come up with anything." She takes a deep breath. "I lied. I wrote a song, but—I didn't… it was the wrong song. I—I wrote a song about you."

My breath hitches in my throat and I feel Glimmer and Bow wrap their hands around mine.

"I love you, Adora. I always have. This… this is 'Adora's Song'."

Catra takes a step back and her fingers practice the movements on the neck of her guitar for just a second before she starts plucking at the strings. Then soft music fills the room. I recognize the song instantly, and I furrow my brow.

"And you're always free to begin again," she breathes, her voice soft and gentle, like it's caressing each word. *"And you're always free to believe. When you find the place where your heart belongs…"* She closes her eyes for just a second, and I can hear her voice warble a little. *"You'll never leave…"*

Then the tune shifts, just a little, and the little teenager standing behind Catra joins in, strumming simple chords.

"I needed a friend and I found you, " Catra starts, and my heart skips from its place in my throat. " *I needed a plan and up you drew, maps and charts and works of art. Visions and dreams, right from your heart."*

A small smile creeps onto Catra's face, and I'm stupid over it.

"And I'm right there in all. In your messy scrawl, is my name circled twice. You melt my heart of ice."

I take a step forward and, for a second, I wish Bow and Glimmer weren't holding my hands so I could cross them over my chest and hold myself.

" *I promise to love you forever. I promise, my friend, to be better. I see you, I know you. I like you, I owe you. For giving me a home in this dark, lonely world."*

Catra's face gets tight and her eyes close. *"If I was brave, I'd sing you this song. If I was brave, I'd risk it all. "* She shakes her head and lets out a small sigh. " *But instead, I'll cower and pine. Instead, I'll just dream you're mine."*

"I promise to love you forever. I promise, my friend, to be better. I see you, I know you. I like you, I owe you. For giving me a home in this dark, lonely world."

The music slows and a small smile takes over Catra's face again. She looks back at her student and gives her a small nod. She seems to understand and stops playing. Then Catra turns back to the mic and plucks a final few notes before taking her hands off her guitar and letting it hang around her neck.

"I know it's not easy my love, but you keep trying. So thanks to your folks, who today we're losing. Thank you for bringing her into this dark lonely world and giving me a home."

Then Catra picks up her guitar and so does the teenager, and they play stronger than ever.

"I promise to love you forever. I promise, my friend, to be better. I see you, I know you. I like you, I owe you, for giving me a home in this dark, lonely world."

And slowly the music fades, shifting for one final second, into that all too familiar song. And Catra's smile is the biggest it's been since she started singing.

"You and I will always… be."

Then it's done, and Catra is standing in front of a silent crowd, with a guitar in her hands, and her heart on her sleeve.

After a second of silence, the crowd bursts into riotous applause, and Catra beams. She looks back at her student and smiles, then she looks back out at the crowd and she looks proud.

And I'm just standing here, stock still, gripping Glimmer and Bow's hands like they're lifelines, and staring at the girl that I've loved my whole life.

"Adora…?" Glimmer whispers and I just clamp my jaw shut and shake my head.

The applause dies down and Catra looks around at the crowd, and I feel her eyes graze over me. And I notice the twitch in her lip when they do.

She stands for a second longer then swallows. The room is quiet and muttering now, like they're all waiting for me to act. I can feel eyes on me, but I don't meet any of them. I just watch Catra.

"Um…" she steps up to the mic again and she blinks furiously. "I… you deserve to know." She sniffs and closes her eyes. "I'm sorry."

She steps back from the mic and rips her guitar up and over her head. She looks at it for a second in her hands, then passes it off to some kid on the stage who's just standing there watching her. "Here ya go, kid," I hear her quiet voice carry through the silence. Then she's running off the stage, head low, hands clutching her arms. And she heads straight for the door.

I drop Bow andGlimmer's hands and run after her.

I've made a lot of mistakes, I'm not about to make another one.

"Catra!" I cry, right as she slips out the door. I'm only a few steps behind her, but if she really tries to get away, I'll never be able to

catch her.

But just outside the door, she stops. Her shoulders stiffen and her hands clench, but she stops.

I slow down a little as I approach her, brushing my loose hair out of my face. “Catra—”

“I shouldn’t have come, okay?” She’s talking so fast, her words are running together. “Just let me go and we can pretend—”

“Did you mean it?”

There’s a second of silence and then she turns around, frown curling her perfect mouth. “Did I mean what?”

I bite my lip and fiddle with the fabric of my pant leg. “You love me?”

Catra blinks and then throws her head back and groans. “Of course, I fucking meant it, Adora.” She levels me with a stare that sees right through me. “What is with you thinking people are kidding when they say they love you?”

I smile. I can’t help it. I smile and I reach out and wrap my hand around her wrist. She stiffens a little at my touch, but I take a step closer and watch her face as she visibly relaxes.

“You’re the one who thinks they’re lying.”

Catra’s cheeks flush red, and my smile gets a little bigger. I can’t help it. Catra loves me. Catra *loves* me. I don’t have it in myself to be mad anymore. Or sad. Or any of those other feelings I was feeling ten minutes ago. Now all I feel is warm.

“That’s different,” she whispers, and I furrow my brow.

“How?”

She takes a deep breath and shrugs. "I'm not, ya know," she meets my gaze and it's like I've been set on fire, "the most lovable human being to have ever existed."

I grin. "Aw," I pull her closer by the wrist, "you think I'm lovable?"

She scowls a little, but I can see her eyes are getting glassy. "Don't get any ideas, Princess."

I cock my head, and my smile slips. Catra looks like she's about to cry. She shouldn't. This is a good moment. A happy moment. "Like, what kind of ideas?"

She blinks and sniffs. "Like—like maybe we could make this work. Or, ya know," she wipes at her eyes with her free hand, "anything dumb like that."

I narrow my eyes. "Why can't we make this work, Catra?"

Catra closes her eyes again and shrugs, like she isn't saying something devastating and horrible. "I'm broken, Adora. And you can't fix me."

That cuts through me so deep, I think I may never recover. If that's what she thinks – if Catra thinks that *she* needs fixing… I won't argue with Catra that she's not broken, I'd never win that fight, but I will fight to the death if that's what it took to convince her that I love every single one of her broken pieces.

Just as they are. Just as she is.

But if she doesn't think this is worth trying for—

"Then why'd you get up there?" I whine, and she stares at me with wide eyes.

"Because! I—I wanted you to know."

"Know *what* ?" I say, lifting my hand and cupping her cheek. She doesn't flinch away. She actually leans in and her skin is so soft

and warm…

“That I love you,” she breathes, eyes closed. “I always have and I’m always going to.” She opens her eyes and they’re soft and she gives me that gentle soft smile that only I ever get to see. “Just the way you are, Adora.”

I bite my lip. “But… I’m broken.”

Immediately, Catra’s smile falls away and she’s rolling her eyes.

“And you can’t fix me.”

“Adora—”

I tighten my grip on her face, turning her to look at me. “It’s a stupid argument.”

“I’m going to hurt you again!” she cries, grabbing onto my wrist. “I—I don’t want to hurt you again.”

I crack a small smile. “Try not to.”

She sniffs and I can tell she wants to cry again. But I can also tell by the set of her shoulders and the way she’s biting her lip that I’m winning. “But what if I do?”

I lean forward, pressing my forehead to hers. “Kiss it better.”

She lets out a quiet little laugh but shakes her head. “Adora—”

“It’s not fair, Catra,” I murmur, lifting my lips to press a kiss to her forehead. “Love shouldn’t be this thing you only get to do when you’re perfect! Why do we have to be less broken to be loved?”

I listen to the silence and smile when Catra takes a shuddery breath. “I hate when you’re wise…”

My smile grows and my lips rub against her skin. “Why? Is it hot?”

Catra laughs, like actually laughs, and it gets a little squeaky and it's perfect. "No!"

I drop my head to look into her eyes. "Does it distract you?"

She scoffs and turns her head. "Between my mom, your dead parents, and whatever this last week was, we're gonna need so much therapy, Princess."

"That's okay," I whisper, wrapping an arm around her waist. "As long as I get to be with you."

Catra sighs, reaches up and curls a hand around my neck. "Are you sure?"

I give her a quick nod. "Absolutely." I lean in again and brush my thumb over her cheek. "Can I kiss you now?"

She bites her lower lip and lets out a breathy little, "Please."

And I do. I kiss her with everything I have left. I kiss her for every minute I wasn't by her side. I kiss her for every doubt she's ever had. I kiss her for every moment she hurt and every moment I wasn't there to kiss it better.

And I kiss her for me. I kiss her for every moment I dreamed about being with her again. I kiss her for every fear and anxiety and how they all seemed to come true at once. I kiss her for all the seconds I wanted to share with her, and all the kisses I never got to give her.

And most importantly, I kiss her for the future. I kiss her because we have one. I kiss her because I'm not letting go again. I kiss her because she's not going to run.

I kiss her because I want to.

She kisses me back.

And when her hand tangles in my hair, and her tongue touches mine, I notice the song pouring out of the speakers on the other side of the room.

"You have stolen my… heart."

Chapter End Notes

Let me know what you think!

Epilogue: To Favor Fire

Chapter Notes

Soapie, this one's for you.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

"We're all just walking each other home." – Ram Dass

March 15, 2001

Adora was tugging Catra along recklessly and, when they made their way down the steps of the school bus, Catra was certain she was going to fall and that Adora's firm grip would pull her arm right out of its socket.

That didn't happen, but she did stumble and knock into Adora's backpack.

"Slow down!" Catra cried, pulling at her hand until Adora let it go. Adora stopped in her tracks, turning around to look at her best friend.

"What?" she said, a look of genuine confusion on her face. Her eyes were bright, excited, and the little perfect ponytail she'd come to school in was falling out. Anxious joy was radiating out of her like light from the sun.

Catra rubbed her hand. "You were hurting me."

Immediately Adora's face fell. She stepped back to her friend, picking at the fabric of her pants. "I'm sorry. I didn't mean to."

Catra had a little scowl souring her delicate features. "You were going too fast."

Adora lifted her hand with the intention of taking Catra's in her own. Not to tug or squeeze, but to hold. But when her fingers brushed her friend's palm, she pulled away.

"I'm sorry," Adora frowned, dropping her hand. "I'm just… excited."

Catra's scowl morphed into a gentle pucker. "Why?"

Adora rocked back on her heels. "'Cause, you've never been to my house before."

Catra sighed a little and crossed her arms. "My mom doesn't let me go to anyone's houses. She doesn't want me bothering people."

Adora scoffed, and the sound was so sharp coming from her young voice. "You're not bothering us. I want you to come over. And you shouldn't be home alone, Catra." Adora frowned, a little ball of anxiety blooming in her stomach. "I don't want any bad people to come and hurt you or take you away."

Catra sighed. She'd messed up. She shouldn't have told Adora that her mom wouldn't get home until almost six. She shouldn't have told her that she was gonna be home alone.

It was an accident really. At recess, everyone had been bragging about the big kid/adult things they could do. Adora knew how to make juice from the frozen cans. Lonnie could make SpaghettiOs in the microwave. And Catra, well Catra could make mac n' cheese all by herself.

"How do you know how much stuff to put in it?" Lonnie asked.

"I watched my mom. And it says on the box. And the cups you use to measure say how much they are. It's easy."

"Doesn't sound easy…" Lonnie muttered, crossing her arms.

"Well, if you aren't a dum—"

“Why do you know how to make mac n’ cheese, Catra?” Adora’s face was pinched in confusion, and she looked almost mad. It didn’t make sense. Everyone else had been impressed. Why did Adora have to ask questions?

Catra shrugged. “I just do. I watched my mom make it a couple times and then I tried it. I can make tuna salad sandwiches too.”

Adora furrowed her little brow and crossed her arms. “Your mom lets you use the stove? All by yourself?”

Catra rolled her eyes. “No. My mom doesn’t know. But I get hungry waiting for her to get home from work…” Catra looked down at the ground, suddenly feeling embarrassed whereas seconds before she’d felt empowered. “And there’s… there’s not always leftovers.”

Adora’s eyes got wide. “When does your mom get home from work?”

Catra shuffled her feet. “Six o’clock.”

Usually. It had been getting later though, and Catra knew that.

“Six?” Adora cried, voice hiking in pitch. She threw out her hands. “And you don’t have a babysitter?”

Catra crossed her arms. “I don’t need a babysitter.”

Adora narrowed her eyes. “Catra, there are bad people who could hurt you. You shouldn’t be by yourself.”

And now she was here, in a standoff on the sidewalk in a neighborhood she’d never been to, on her way to a house she’d never seen, with the pushiest girl in the world.

“Whatever. Let’s just go.”

Adora smiled, feeling victorious, and held out her hand to Catra. Catra eyed it skeptically.

"I'll go slow," Adora murmured.

So Catra took her hand.

They started walking again, Adora leading the way with gentle nudges and squeezes as they made their way through the maze of Adora's neighborhood. Catra noted that the houses were nice, but they were older. They were painted in rich colors, with large trees and weeds growing up in between the cracks on the sidewalk. She liked it a lot more than her own neighborhood, where all the houses were pale and looked the same.

"You called your mom, right? And gave her my address like I said?" Adora asked, coming to a stop at a street crossing and looking both ways.

"Mhmm," Catra hummed, thinking back to the way her hands shook as she held the school's office phone and punched in her mom's cellphone number.

"Okay. I just don't want you to get in trouble. My mom gets really mad when she doesn't know where I am."

Catra bit back a grimace. She had called her mom, three times actually, and each time she'd been sent to voicemail after two rings. She almost started crying when she realized that she wasn't going to be able to go to Adora's. Despite her early protestations, Catra secretly did want to go. Adora was her best friend. She wanted to play in her room and see her backyard. And she didn't want to be alone. She spent so much time alone.

But more than anything, she wanted to spend more time with Adora.

So she made a decision, and after hearing that beep for the third time Catra left a message.

"Hey, Mom. Um… Adora asked me to come over to play after school. I'm gonna ride the bus home with her and she said her mom can bring me home. Okay. Bye."

Her mom never called back.

“I told her, Adora,” Catra lied, smooth and easy. “But your mom is gonna take me home anyway, right?”

“Yeah!” Adora beamed, and Catra’s shoulders untensed. “I mean I have to ask her, but she will.”

Catra came to a halt, an electric shock– like bolt of fear shooting through her back. “You didn’t ask?” she screamed, ripping her hand out of Adora’s.

Adora frowned. “No, not yet but—”

“Did you ask if we could play?”

Adora started to shrink. “I’m going to.”

Catra grabbed at her long tangled hair. “Adora! What if she says no?”

For some reason, that seemed to give Adora a little of her signature confidence back. “She won’t.”

Catra’s stomach was churning. “She could! She might get mad and then…” Catra couldn’t even finish the sentence. *She might not take me home. My mom might find out and she’ll be mad. Adora will get in trouble and then never be able to play with me.*

As Catra started to spiral out, her fists clenching and all of her throat getting thick with the yell and mean words she was going to throw in Adora’s face , a hand fell on her shoulder.

Catra opened her eyes, which she hadn’t even realized she’d closed and looked into Adora’s soft gray blue eyes.

“My mom’s nice, Catra. She’s not—” Adora bit her lip and gave Catra’s shoulder a squeeze. “She told me to ask you to come play. A lot. My mom wants to meet you.”

Catra blanched and unclenched her hands. “Really?”

“Mhmm.” Adora smiled. “She makes really good cookies too. And she only makes them when we have friends over. So, she’ll probably make some!”

Catra took a slow, shallow breath. “Yeah?”

Adora bobbed her head and pulled her hand from Catra’s shoulder. She reached down and took her hand again. “We can help her too if you want! I like making cookies.”

Catra had never made cookies before.

“That sounds fun,” she whispered and Adora started walking again. Catra trailed half a step behind and watched Adora’s face intently.

“Or we could watch a movie. Or TV. Do you like Arthur? I watch Arthur every day. I don’t have to today though. Oh! We can play in my bedroom. I got a Polly Pocket pool for Christmas. My dad won’t let me put any real water in it, but it’s still pretty cool. And I also got some horses and—”

Catra listened to Adora ramble the entire rest of the way to her house.

When Adora turned into the driveway, Catra paused a moment. She looked up at the soft yellow house with the white shutters and the blue roof. She noticed the flowers blossoming on the large tree in the front yard, and the scooters thrown haphazardly on the porch. And when they got to the front door with the pretty window design, she looked at the welcome mat that said “hello” in swooping black letters.

Something shifted in Catra then, and when she looked up into Adora’s smiling face, it locked in place.

They walked inside and Catra tried to soak in every detail – the thick blue carpet, the soft beige couches. She noticed the heavy

brown boots on the little shoe shelf by the door as she followed Adora in taking off her shoes. And when Adora took her hand again, pulling her into the main room where Adam sat on the couch, a bowl of popcorn in hand, she noticed the pictures on the walls.

Then she heard her voice.

"There you are!" Catra and Adora both turned to look at the entrance to the hallway. Walking out was a woman that Catra knew, even in her limited understanding, was beautiful. She had long curly red hair, bright, happy eyes, and her smile was brilliant. Catra recognized it instantly – it was Adora's smile.

"What, did you get lost on the way home from the bus stop?" She chuckled, setting a blanket down on the couch behind Adam's head. She ruffled his hair and snickered when he silently swatted at her hand. Then she turned back to Catra and Adora.

"Oh! Another one." She laughed but looked over Catra with a discerning eye. "Who's this?"

Adora stepped forward, pulling Catra with her and smiling like the sun. "This is Catra!" she said, pride ringing in her voice.

And Catra tried not to shrink away.

"Catra." The woman nodded and gave a little sigh. "I was wondering when you'd show up on my doorstep." She glanced at her daughter and smiled softly. "Adora talks about you all the time."

Catra's stomach, which had been churning, settled then, and then started to flutter. She turned to look at Adora. "You do?"

Adora returned Catra's gaze. But instead of smiling, she looked puzzled. "Yeah. You're my best friend…"

Catra's heart burst in an explosion of glitter and butterflies.

She and Adora had been friends all year, but she'd never called her "best friend" before.

"Oh," Catra mumbled, but a slow and soft smile spread across her face.

One grew on Adora's to match.

"I'm Marlena," the woman spoke again, hand to her chest, "Adam and Adora's mom. Welcome to our home, Catra."

"Thank you," she breathed.

Then Marlena started rolling up her sleeves, and she shot Adora a look out of the corner of her eye. "Adora, we are going to have a talk about asking for permission. You're not getting out of that."

Adora huffed. "You said you wanted me to ask her to come play!"

Marlena rolled her eyes. "You know better than that, Adora." She sighed and shook her head, reaching back and gathering her hair. "But we'll deal with that later. I'm sure Adora promised cookies." She took an elastic from her wrist and tied her hair up in a quick knot at the nape of her neck. Then she dropped her hands to her hips."Do you like chocolate chip, Catra?"

Catra gave a quick nod and Marlena gave her an easy smile.

"Perfect." She stepped through a large arched doorway and glanced back at the girls. "Come on."

Adora's grin was a thousand watts. She giggled and ran for the kitchen, holding tight to Catra's hand and pulling her along.

So Catra learned how to make cookies. She met Adora's dad when he got home from work. She saw him hug his wife from behind and kiss the back of her head. Then, of course, he took her in a gentle headlock and messed up her hair. So she threatened to butter his favorite tie. Luckily Adora managed to facilitate a truce.

Catra had leftover casserole for dinner and learned that Adam's middle name was Herman when he kept poking Adora's side at the table.

Catra was not alone. Catra was with Adora, in a place and with people that even in their brashness felt gentle.

Eventually, Catra knew she had to go. It was well after six, and her mother was most certainly home and fuming. So she, Marlena, and Adora piled in a little blue Toyota and drove Catra back.

As Catra stepped out of the car and turned to say her goodbyes, she was startled to see Adora clambering out of the car after her. Before she could ask what was going on or what was wrong, Adora was reaching for her and wrapping her up in her arms.

For several seconds, Catra stood stock still, shocked by the feeling of the embrace. But slowly, she reached out and placed her hands on the planes of Adora's back.

"Thanks for coming to play," Adora whispered, as though it were a secret. "I'll see you tomorrow."

Catra nodded into Adora's neck. "Yeah."

Adora finally released her and took a step back. She smiled, then turned back to climb into the car. And for a second, Catra just stood there.

"We'll see you soon, Catra!" Marlena called, and Catra's eyes snapped up to stare at her. She gave her a small nod and slowly turned to walk up the driveway to her front door.

"Bye, Catra!" Adora shouted, too loud and enthusiastic for the quiet and empty street. "I'll miss you!"

And finally, Catra laughed. "You're so dumb!" she shouted back. "I'm gonna see you tomorrow!"

Adora pouted through the open window. “I’m still gonna miss you! And you can’t stop me!”

Catra laughed again as she reached the door to her supposed ‘home.’ She gave Adora one final wave before turning and thoughtlessly walking inside.

She was berated. The moment she crossed the threshold, her mother was yelling and, after thirty minutes of verbal assault, she was sent to bed without a pillow, blanket, or dinner.

But Catra wasn’t hungry. She’d already been fed.

February 19, 2023

“That,” Catra begins, setting a box on the coffee table labeled “Adora’s Useless Shit” and grunting, “is the last one.”

Adora turns around. She’s standing in front of the stove. She’d just set a box of silverware and dishes on the counter, and she felt warm.

“Really?” She smiles bright and wide. “I don’t have to carry another box of your books up a flight of stairs?”

Catra rolls her eyes but chuckles. “Don’t even pretend you didn’t enjoy that.”

Adora plays dumb. “I don’t know what you’re talking about.”

“You wouldn’t have worn *that,* ” Catra points at Adora’s homemade tank-top, an oversized t-shirt whose sleeves had been cut off leaving arm holes that dipped well below her bright white sports bra, “in the middle of *February,* if you didn’t want me to look at your arms.”

Adora smirks, holding up one of said arms and flexing. “You like my arms?”

Catra crosses her own arms in defiance. "I have eyes, Adora."

Adora's smile softens and she walks around the counter. She approaches Catra and holds out her hand for her to take.

She does.

Adora pulls her girlfriend close and leans forward until their foreheads touch. Catra lets out a quiet little sigh and her shoulders relax.

We did it, she thought. *We're* doing *it. We are officially moved in. Together.*

Well, sort of. There were still boxes to unpack – she refuses to acknowledge just how many knick-knacks she has. And furniture that needed to be bought – Catra refuses to be those people who eat dinner at the coffee table every day. But they have a place. They have something that is theirs; something they get to share.

They have the chance to make a home.

Adora takes a deep and cleansing breath. "I'm hungry," she says, the hint of a whine in her voice.

Catra chuckles and moves her hands to Adora's neck. "How hungry?"

Adora pouts. "Hungry enough to eat those meals that they used to give in the military. Like the dehydrated stuff." Adora cocks her head and pulls back so she can wrap her arms around Catra. "Are those still a thing?"

Catra's smile falters for a second. "They're called MRE's, dummy." She drops her hands and pokes Adora in the tummy. "And they're not that bad…"

Adora jerks away from Catra's finger with a little squeal. "How do you know?"

Catra's smile slips away completely and Adora's brows furrow. "I've had them before…" she trails off, giving a little shrug. "Obviously."

Adora thinks that isn't obvious, but she can tell by Catra's stance that she's not going to get a straight answer right now. And she doesn't want to ruin what should be a perfect night.

"Maybe," Adora manages a smile, "but are you gonna make me eat one? Today? Our first day in our beautiful new home?"

Catra shakes her head and manages a smile. "No." She chuckles. "Arby's, maybe? You carried enough boxes to earn as many roast beef sandwiches as you want."

Adora steps back into Catra's space and places a hand on her cheek. "You're so good to me."

"Oh, you're paying," Catra affirms, a playful smirk on her mouth. "Didn't that gold medal come with a cash prize or something?"

Adora laughs, full and loud. "I can't believe you know that," she says, snaking her arms around Catra's waist.

Catra shrugs and returns the embrace. "I got curious. Going around, training your ass off, for free? In this economy?"

Adora nods and smiles. "I mean it's a good amount, but not really enough to live the rest of your life on," she makes a face. " *Really* not enough to live the rest of your life on. But—"

Catra's smile tightens. "But most people go back and get more."

Adora sighs. This is a kind of new thing – not Catra's guilt, though she had never really felt guilty for the things she did and said in their youth, but the hyperfixation with Adora's Olympic career. In their last therapy session, Catra had admitted that even the thought of the Olympics makes her sick now.

She convinced herself that she robbed Adora of a bright and fulfilling future.

"She won gold her first Olympics," she'd seethed, like she was angry. "She could've done it again. Fuck, she could've just played professionally and she'd still at least get to do something she loves! And she'd make a hell of a lot more money than she's going to being a middle school art teacher."

Adora had stared at Catra dumbfounded, and their therapist had simply asked, "Do you think money would make Adora happy? Or, more importantly, that Adora is *unhappy* ?"

And Catra had shrugged. *Shrugged.* "It just doesn't make sense if she is…"

After several minutes of breaking these fears down to the bare essentials, Adora had the chance to speak.

"I love you. You know that." Her voice was pleading and Catra had looked up from the floor. "But even without you, even if you never spoke to me again, I would be here. I always wanted to come back *here* . I wanted to retire after the Olympics. I want to be a teacher – I *love* art. And…" Adora took a deep breath, "if we weren't together, I would still want to be near you. Even if we were just friends, I want you in my life. I want *our* life."

Catra had almost managed to smile then.

Now, her mind was right back in it.

"Most people aren't in it for the money," Adora says, narrowing her eyes.

After a beat of staring back into her eyes, Catra drops her head. "Sorry," she whispers, "I know you hate that."

Adora sighs, reaching up to grab Catra's chin. She lifts her head and gives Catra her softest, saddest smile. "I hate that you feel *bad* , Catra. I just want you to be happy."

But there is a small part of Adora that hates the distrust – hates that Catra doesn't believe her when she says she's where she wants to be, and that the woman she adores has always been so resistant to being loved.

Catra returns Adora's smile and lifts onto the tips of her toes. She kisses Adora on the lips, soft and warm, and Adora's fear and hurt melt out of her. She can't be scared or hurt when she's kissing Catra. She can't be much of anything, she always gets so overwhelmed. The feel of Catra, the smell and taste of her, all consume Adora's senses until she forgets anyone aside from Catra has ever existed.

Catra pulls away slowly and opens her eyes. She grins and steps out of Adora's arms. "I'm thinking we Doordash it. 'Cause I *really* don't want to have to leave the house." She turns, then glances at Adora over her shoulder as she walks to the kitchen counter where she'd left her phone. "I don't know if I want to leave this house ever again."

Adora laughs and slowly follows after her. "Oh yeah? Do you like it here or something?"

Catra shrugs, picking up her phone and dropping her head to look at the screen. "It's a pretty house." She looks up, arching a brow. "And I have a hot roommate."

Adora beams, stepping up to the opposite side of the counter so she is standing across from Catra and can count the freckles on her cheeks. "You like me? Wow," Adora *tsks* , "that is so embarrassing for you…"

Catra gives a shake of her head. "This," she gestures all around her, at the kitchen, the living room, and the whole house, "is not because I like you."

Adora shakes her head. "How's that river, Catra?"

Now Catra looks genuinely confused. "What river?"

Adora smirks. “Dah-nile.”

There’s a moment of total silence but Adora’s smile doesn’t waver.

“You know like the river in Egy—”

“Yeah, no I get it.” Catra bites her lower lip. “I just hate it. So. Much.”

Adora scoffs. “You love my puns.”

“Puns are the lowest form of humor, Adora. I love you, but I won’t lie to you.” She glances back down at her phone and swipes.

Adora laughs and reaches across the counter. She wraps her fingers around Catra’s wrist and Catra looks back up, gentle surprise in her eyes.

“I love you too,” Adora whispers, smiling brightly, “and I’m so happy we’re moving in together.” She straightens and pulls Catra’s hand to hover above the center of the countertop. But it’s Catra who moves their fingers to tangle together. “Can I tell you something dumb?”

Catra gives a small little nod and Adora squeezes her hand.

“Last night, when I was falling asleep, I thought about how we were in *your* bed. But tonight we’ll be sleeping in *ours.* And that just made me really happy.”

Catra fights very hard to keep her heart from melting into a puddle right on the floor. She coughs a little and blinks to keep tears from her eyes. She’d been crying so much lately – really ever since she and Adora had started therapy. It was like whatever plug Catra had kept on her emotions for her entire teenage years – whatever the hell had kept her from breaking down at Randor & Marlena’s funeral and from sobbing on the phone with Adora on her 18 th birthday – had popped out and they were spilling everywhere now.

“You’re a dork,” Catra says and Adora chuckles.

“I’m your dork.”

Catra shakes her head, like she can shake off her blush. “What do you want from Arby’s, asshole?”

Adora laughs again, louder this time, and holds out her hand to take the phone. “Let me do it.”

Catra narrows her eyes. “You don’t know what I want…”

Adora scoffs and gently pries the phone out of Catra’s hand. “You get the same thing every time. Unless it’s March, then you also get the mint shake.”

Catra sighs and relinquishes the phone. “You know too much. It’s dangerous to leave you alive…”

“Ha!” Adora shakes her head and leans forward on the counter. “You’d miss me,” she sighs, scrolling through the app and selecting all the food that made her stomach rumble. She ordered a lot of food.

“Would I? I think I’m perfectly capable of ordering my own food.”

Adora glances up under her lashes. “I provide other services,” she breathes, her voice lower.

Catra bites down on her lower lip, cheeks flushing a little. “So does a vibrator.”

Adora smirks, finalizing their order and setting the phone down on the countertop. “I can do a lot more than your vibrator.”

“I don’t know…” Catra breathes, not even realizing that she is leaning in. “I have a really nice vibrator.”

Adora slowly lifts her hand to put her hand on Catra’s jaw. “We can test my theory…” she whispers and Catra’s heart jumps.

Then Catra is washed in a wave of cold reality, dousing the heat in her stomach.

“Shit! We have to make the bed.”

Adora startles, blinking once or twice. “Tha—right now?”

Catra nods, pulling back from Adora’s touch. “I don’t wanna wait until we’ve eaten.”

“Why not?” Adora pouts a little.

“Because I’m not gonna wanna do it after. Obviously.”

Adora sighs, pushing herself off the counter with quiet dread. “Okay…”

Catra, who has made it to the hall that leads back to their bedroom, glances back. “Adora?” Adora looks up, from the floor and Catra cocks her head. “If we make the bed *now* , we can have sex *later.* ”

“So,” Adora starts walking, a skip in her step, “there’s a bed that needs to be made?”

They make the bed quickly, which means it’s not exactly up to Adora’s expectations. She’s always been very particular about them for some reason, like a cadet who has to present for inspection. When she starts to get finicky with the length of the sides on the blanket and how far down the top is folded Catra shakes her head.

“I’m gonna go find Melog,” Catra says, uncrossing her arms. “They should’ve eaten hours ago.”

Adora nods, not looking up from the blanket. “Uh-huh.”

Catra rolls her eyes and turns toward the door. “Any idea where they’re at?”

Adora glances up quickly, and then returns her attention to the pillows she's rearranging. "I thought they were hiding in the pantry."

Catra nods slowly, watching as the love of her life steps back to admire her handiwork; a perfectly made bed.

It makes her smile. "Thanks. Be right back."

Catra dips out of the room and Adora finally looks back to watch her walk away.

It doesn't take long for Adora to remember the warmth in Catra's face from the kitchen, and the way her eyes got teary when she talked about sleeping in *their* bed. She looks back at the bed and thinks about how it's going to feel to curl around the woman she loves under the warm blankets.

"Hmmm," she furrows her brow, eyeing the comforter.

Catra, despite putting off more body heat than Adora thought possible, got cold a lot. She'd curl her hands around Adora's shirt and tangle their feet together just to warm her fingers and toes. Not that Adora would ever complain about that, but maybe another blanket…

Adora looks around at the dozen or so boxes in the room, wondering just where she was supposed to find one.

Then, tucked in the corner, a clear blue tote with the lid askew and Adora's red gingham blanket spilling out the top. Adora crosses the room smiling to herself. She'd thought she lost that particular blanket a while ago until she started packing to move, and it was one of her favorites. She bends down and pulls the blanket from the tote, letting the lid fall with a loud slap against the hardwood floor.

She flinches and folds the blanket over her arm so that she can reach down and grab the lid. But she doesn't. The moment she looks down, she sees something far more important than a tote

lid. Lying haphazardly on the ground, the shiny red paper ripping at the corner and label peeling away, is Catra's Christmas present.

Adora is stock-still, heart beating hard in her chest. She'd forgotten. How had she forgotten? That fateful Christmas afternoon when, cheeks tearstained and throat sore, she'd wrapped that godforsaken gift in her favorite blanket and hidden it in the back of her closet. How did she let that moment go?

She couldn't bear to get rid of it at the time. It ached to even imagine it. She'd put so much thought into the gift, spent her time, money, and energy on finding something Catra would not only value, but that would tell her how much Adora valued her.

In the end it didn't matter, but she liked to imagine that it could've.

Adora reaches down and picks up the box and backs up to sit on the edge of the bed. She picks at the ripped paper and smooths her hand over the peeling label that she'd written herself.

For Catra

Love, Adora

Love. That Christmas Eve had nearly destroyed her faith in love. Something she'd believed in and fought for her entire life made fallible and meaningless in a single hour.

Adora's heart clenches. It terrifies her now, how easily she'd been convinced to give up, to lose hope. It terrifies her that she *would* give up – not on being Catra's lover, but on being in her life at all. It terrifies her that she had ever felt broken enough to walk away from everything she'd ever fought for, even for a few days.

Adam told her, the times she had expressed this fear before, that it was only a matter of time before Adora would've gotten back in the saddle. He said she was the kind of bullheaded that didn't give up, no matter how hopeless, and that is what won Catra's heart in the first place.

"You never walked away from her, no matter how many times she tried to push you away. You make her feel loved."

Adora strokes the glossy red paper with her thumb. Adora is pretty sure Catra doesn't doubt that love anymore. Therapy has done them wonders, knocked down walls and built bridges. Catra was even friends with Bow & Glimmer now. She was letting people in.

But now, thanks to therapy, Adora knew just how hurt Catra had been. And still was.

She knew about Shannon and all the ways she'd dismissed Catra and kept love just out of reach. She knew about how much her parents had really meant to Catra, and how poorly the girl had let herself grieve.

And that stupid phone call, the Thanksgiving she missed, and how little she'd fought to stay.

Adora was learning that nothing had hurt Catra quite like her negligence.

"Stop."

Adora looks to the doorway. Catra is standing there, hand on her hip, eyes narrowed, and Adora feels simultaneous relief and dread.

"Stop what?" Adora asks, sitting up straight and setting the package in her lap and under her arms to obscure it from view.

Catra steps into the room. "I know that face," she stands in front of Adora and presses her finger to Adora's forehead. "You're thinking. Don't."

Adora smiles a little. Catra is so much warmer and louder than the fears that plague her troubled heart. "Don't think? You don't even know what I'm thinking."

Catra twists her wrist, turning her palm against Adora's skin and drags her fingers down Adora's temple, over her cheek to her jaw. "Whatever it is, it's hurting you," Catra whispers, her expression sad. She pushes her hand back and strokes her nails through Adora's hair. "So please," she lets out a shaky breath, "stop."

Adora's smile falls away and her expression twists into a grimace. "Catra…" she breathes, like some kind of plea; like only Catra can save her.

Catra sighs, dropping her hand from Adora's cheek. Before Adora can miss the warmth, Catra is gripping her shoulder and turning to sit beside her. "Okay," she murmurs, dragging her hand down Adora's back and wrapping around her waist, "tell me."

Adora closes her eyes. She doesn't want to. Her instincts fight against it. Protect Catra, that's what she's *supposed* to do. She's not supposed to hurt her again.

But hadn't she said it first?

"What if I hurt you again?"

"Kiss it better."

"It was always an accident," Adora almost whimpers, covering the hand Catra has at her waist with her own.

"What was?" Catra asks, squeezing.

Adora turns her head, deciding that she has to look Catra in the eye as she says this. No other ways can she be absolved. "Every time I hurt you."

Catra's brow furrows and Adora goes on.

"I didn't want to, Catra. All I've ever wanted is to make you happy. But—but I *failed.* I let your mother hurt you, I ignored your grief over my parents, and when we started dating—" Adora's voice thickens, cutting off her words. She swallows and Catra's

mouth pops open. But she cuts her off. “No, I forgot about you – not on purpose, and not really, I thought about you every day. But I forgot about your feelings.” Adora’s mouth twists with disgust. “I let you become the collateral damage of my plans.”

A tear slips down Adora’s cheek. “And I’m so, so, sorry.”

For a moment Catra is silent, just searching Adora’s face for something that she can’t even name.

“You…” she breathes, “are such an idiot.”

Adora’s eyes squeeze shut and Catra’s hand jumps to her cheek. “No, no, no, baby, not like that. I’m sorry. I didn’t mean it like that. You’re so smart, sweetheart, and it means…” Catra takes a shaky breath, “so much that you care enough about me to… see my pain?” She bites her bottom lip and Adora opens her eyes. “I’m not sure how to say it, but knowing you understand how I felt now means… well, the world.”

Adora’s eyes tighten with confusion. “Then wha—”

“Adora,” Catra breathes, stroking Adora’s cheek with her thumb. “I hurt you on purpose. And that…" tears form in Catra’s eyes, “is so much worse.”

Adora furrows her brow. She thinks about that for a moment, and eventually, she sighs. She knows Catra is probably right, at least a little. Intention matters and being ignorant to the wrong you’ve done, while not a good thing by any means, is probably a bit of a saving grace. But that doesn’t mean she feels better.

She’d been negligent. She’d been stupid. And… she’d failed.

She wasn’t who Catra needed her to be.

“You’re doing it again,” Catra says, her voice firm, but Adora stares down at her hands. “Stop.”

Catra scoots closer to Adora on the bed, but she doesn't look up. "Adora, look at me." Catra watches Adora close her eyes tighter. "Adora, *please* ."

Finally, she lifts her head and Catra gets to stare into her tear-filled eyes.

"It is not your fault," Catra whispers, her voice hoarse but filled with conviction. "I am my own person. You are *not* responsible for me."

Adora sighs and lifts her hand to cover the one Catra has placed on her cheek. "But it *is* my fault. At least… some of it."

Catra lifts her chin. "No, it's not. Not any of it. Not anymore."

Adora's brow furrows, but she doesn't fight. She doesn't tell Catra she's wrong. She asks, "How?"

"Because," Catra shrugs a little and tries to smile, "I forgave you. I *chose* to forgive you." Catra leans in closer to Adora so that she can feel her breath on her face. "And you forgave me. So blame and mistakes don't matter anymore. What matters," Catra swallows her tears, "is that I love you. And you love me. So, I choose us."

Adora's lip trembles. "Really?"

Catra presses her forehead to Adora's. "Really. I'm not letting you go again."

Adora sighs her next word, a hesitant relief washing over her. "Promise?"

Catra nods, the skin of her forehead brushing against Adora's. "I promise."

Adora can't hold herself back. She presses forward and takes Catra's lips with her own. Catra hums into the kiss, trying not to

smile so wide their lips would part. They kiss until Adora's out of breath, unable to breathe through her nose because of her tears.

Catra tightens her grip on Adora's jaw. "As long as you love me, Adora, I'll be here." She sniffs. "And even if you don't—"

Adora scoffs and kisses Catra's cheek. "That's not gonna happen."

"Good," Catra whispers, comforted infinitely by the words. "Because I'll never be able to afford this house on my teacher's salary."

Adora laughs, pulling back to look into Catra's sparkling eyes. "Hey! I'm a teacher too!"

Catra rolls her eyes. "You've been teaching for half a school year. And it's middle school." She lifts her hand and presses her index finger into Adora's forehead. "It's only a matter of time before you throw in the towel and capitalize on your celebrity."

Adora shakes her head with a small smile on her face. "You think I'm a lot more famous than I am."

Catra shrugs, but then her eyes fall to the package Adora had set behind them during the thick of their conversation. "So… what's that?"

Adora is immediately flustered, her cheeks flowing pink. She picks up the package hesitantly and holds it between her and Catra.

"If I say 'nothing'," Adora eyes her girlfriend, "will you let it go?"

Catra thinks for a moment. The respectful thing, the "right" thing would be to let it go. But Adora knows Catra, and she knows how to convince her to really let it go.

"You already know the answer to that."

Adora laughs, and then lets out a weak little sigh. "It's… your Christmas present," she admits, flipping it over in her hand. "From

last year." Catra's eyes go wide and Adora nibbles at her lip. "It's for you."

Catra's expression is one of silent awe. Her eyes dance between Adora's own and the package in her hands. "Can I have it?"

Adora keeps nibbling. "It's really dumb. You'll probably—"

Catra holds out her hands. "Don't care. Gimme."

Adora snickers but slowly places the wrapped gift in Catra's hands. Immediately Catra's fingers are on the corner where the paper has torn. She rips quickly, no ceremony involved, and is soon holding two thin pink boxes, taped together by their plastic faces.

Her heart stops.

She gently, oh so gently, pries the two boxes apart, revealing their contents behind clear plastic screens.

They're Barbies, one in a soft blue dress with long dark hair held to the back of the box by a strip of plastic, adorned with a flower crown. The other in pink, layers of tulle, and with blonde hair that is just as long as her counterparts, topped with a crown.

It's Erika and Analise.

The Princess and the Pauper.

Catra's throat feels thick as she tries to speak. "Adora…"

"I know it's dumb. And like we didn't *just* play Princess & the Pauper, but I thought you might, I don't know, appreciate the nostalgia?"

Catra holds the two Barbies in her hands, staring at them in awe. She has questions – how did Adora even find these? How much must she have *paid* for them? What did Catra ever do to deserve this kind of thoughtfulness?

But she doesn't ask her questions. She just stares.

Erika and Analise… two girls brought together by chance to change the course of one another's lives. The princess and the pauper, two searching souls who found solace in the things they shared rather than the ones that made them different.

They would do anything for the other, even risk their lives, because even though they barely knew one another, they knew they'd found a kindred spirit worth loving.

"And you're always free to begin again, and you're always free to believe. When you find the place that your heart belongs, you'll never leave."

"I…" Adora begins, "If you don't like them I can probably sell them and—"

Catra's head snaps to attention, and she levels a glare at Adora. "Don't you fucking dare."

A hesitant smile appears on Adora's lips. "You like them?"

Catra closes her eyes. *This beautiful, wonderful, perfect dummy!* Catra thinks and gives a small nod. "They're perfect."

Catra drops her gaze, a thought popping into her head. She cocks her head. "Almost."

Catra turns a little in her seat, setting one of the dolls behind her. Then without thought, and without any warning, she starts to open the other's box.

"Catra!" Adora cries.

Catra just arches a brow. "What?" She continues to pull at the plastic flap that keeps the doll inside. "I'm gonna put them back."

Adora groans. "Then what are you doing?"

Catra glances up and smiles. “You’ll see.” She slides the piece of thin cardboard the doll was tied to out of the box. She sets it gently on her lap and starts untwisting the ties that hold her in.

Adora looks on in shock.

Soon Erika is being held to the cardboard by her hair alone, and Catra is reaching behind her. She tugs at the Velcro on the back of her dress and gently slides it off.

“Damn–” Catra notes, setting the dress in Adora’s lap. “—hold this —the proportions on this thing are kind of whack.”

Adora scoffs. “Yeah. It’s a Barbie.”

Catra bobs her head. “You’re right. I just never had one.”

Adora sighs like she often does when Catra’s words break her heart. “Seriously,” she says watching as Catra removes Analise’s dress next, “what the fuck are you doing?”

Catra’s eyebrows shoot up. “Damn. The ‘fuck’ word? You don’t trust me at all.”

“Right now,” Adora bites the inside of her cheek, “it’s kinda hard.”

Catra sighs, sliding the blue dress onto Analise’s body and refastening the doll to the board. “What on earth did I do to— actually don’t answer that.”

That makes Adora chuckle for a second and Catra moves on to Erika.

It’s odd, Adora thought, seeing them in one another’s dresses, the pairings of blue and blonde, pink and brown. But it isn’t unpleasant. Something about it makes sense.

Catra slides the dolls back into the box and closes them. A triumphant smile shines on her face. “There.” She places Analise in Adora’s lap. “Now you get to wear the blue dress, Princess.”

Adora blinks and looks up into Catra's face. She's smiling that soft and sweet smile only Adora ever gets to see, and it leaves Adora feeling warm everywhere.

Her chest is warm, her cheeks are pink, and she can't imagine ever being cold again.

"How do you remember that?" she whispers.

Catra sighs, her shoulders falling. "Because I remember you. I remember every moment with you." She gives Adora that smile again. "Isn't that pathetic?"

Adora shakes her head vigorously. "No. It's… it's great." She looks down at the doll and the one in Catra's lap. She thinks about that day and Catra hiding in the bathroom.

"You're my best friend," Adora whispers, and takes Catra's left hand in her right. She feels the crown on Catra's ring finger. She thinks about the promise it was meant to symbolize. She thinks of Catra wearing it on a necklace every day they were without each other – keeping Adora with her but holding her at arm's length. She thinks about how she never wants that space between them again.

"Catra, you're my best friend. And I wanna marry you."

Catra's breath catches in her throat. Her eyes pinch in the corners with concern. "I'm not—"

"Not today," Adora says, squeezing Catra's hand between her own. "Not tomorrow. Maybe a year from now, or two, or three. However long it takes to convince you that you're worth it, and I'm so happy to be building a life with you. You're—you're my home."

Catra's smile grows with every word out of Adora's mouth. And Adora realizes blue isn't her favorite color anymore.

It had changed somewhere along the line. Maybe it was when she saw Catra in that dress for her parent's funeral. Maybe it was when she danced with Adora at the New Year's Eve Gala in that suit. Maybe it changed in her first art class when her professor explained the difference between warm and cool colors.

Nothing is warmer than Catra. Catra is fire. Catra is vivid. Catra is soft and loud and angry and bleeding and brilliant.

And Adora's favorite color is red.

She looks down at Erika's new dress.

Pink's a shade of red.

She laughs and her eyes crinkle with delight. "I love you, Catra. So much."

Catra's smile is bright, passionate, and warm. "I love you too."

Adora leans forward and kisses Catra softly on the lips.

Adora feels safe and warm pressed against Catra in their room, and perhaps that's risky. Catra is still Catra. She still has the power to devastate and hurt. But if her world is going to end in fire, Adora knows her home is in the flames.

Chapter End Notes

> I'm gonna be honest - this has been a long, kind of terrible road. I did NOT expect the kind of reactions that this fic got and I did not prepare myself to deal with them. I used to reply to ever comment, every time. I don't know if I do that anymore, or if I even can and keep my sanity. But I'm proud of the story I told and I know that I said what I meant to. That's what matters.
>
> I've got more stuff in the works. You're invited to check it out when it comes.

Thanks to ResFlower and ya_girl_static for listening to me rant and rave. You two put up with me a lot, and it means a lot. Thanks to petty_labelle, horchatta_latte, and infinitegay for beta reading. The amount of tense errors you found... yeesh. I'm forever grateful to all of you.

And again, special thanks to Soapie. Your comment on the last chapter kinda saved this for me. I'm genuinely so grateful.

Have a nice life, motherfuckers.

End Notes

AHHHH! I did it. It's out there. Oh gosh. Hopefully a kudos or two, (or a comment if you're feeling generous) will give me the boost I need to not only keep writing, but also finish packing...

I'm on twitter btw. @QMilliBystander. Sometimes I tweet cursed content pertaining to my fics. Ask ResFlower. They know.

Please drop by the archive and comment to let the author know if you enjoyed their work!